

RAFFLES INSTITUTION			
YEAR 6 GENERAL PAPER – ARTS & CULTURE			
INFORMATION PACKAGE 2026			
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Enduring Understanding(s): *What will students understand as a result of this unit?*

Definition & characteristics of the arts

EU1: Fundamentally, art is an expression of human creativity, and one of its greatest values lies in the intangible socio-psychological benefits it provides to the individual – both artist and audience.

EU2: Our artistic tendencies are expressed through various branches of creative activity – termed “the arts” – including visual (e.g. painting, sculpture, architecture), performing (e.g. theatre, dance, music) and literary arts (e.g. poetry, prose, drama).

EU3: There are often parameters placed upon the arts by entities (e.g. the state, religious authorities) due to perceptions that they pose a threat to establishment values and ideologies. Conversely, they may be used by these same entities to entrench established values and ideologies.

EU4: The creation of art and the perception of “meaning” in art works can be influenced by globalisation, modernisation, and even advancements in technology and communications. This may result in tensions between traditional/“conservative” and more contemporary/“radical” perceptions of the roles and “value” of art.

EU5: The sustenance and development of the arts require funding, with investment in them possibly reaping economic and other benefits. This funding, however, may be limited or inconsistent due to perceptions that the arts are a frivolity and an extravagance.

Defining characteristics of culture and how culture is related to the arts

EU6: Culture comprises both observable and unobservable elements like identity, customs, beliefs, ideas, and history of a particular people or society, which in turn shape how we perceive ourselves, society, and the world.

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EU7: Culture is learned and shared, but can also alter over time in response to changes in the material and nonmaterial environment.

EU8: Aspects of culture can be expressed through the arts (as well as other markers such as architecture, language, food) that a people or society regard as distinctive and important markers of the group/s they belong to.

EU9: In embodying aspects of culture, the arts play a key role in shaping culture and identity, be it in recollecting the past, showcasing the current societal mood and psyche, expressing future hopes or building connections.

EU10: Cultural conditioning, biases and circumstances can therefore make what is considered art highly subjective. Nevertheless, arts practitioners sometimes seek to provoke thought by pushing socio-cultural boundaries and may, in the process, gain prominence and/or suffer the consequences of this.

Essential Questions (EQs)

1. What is art? What purposes does it serve?
2. Are some forms of art superior to others?
3. What is the value of arts and culture to the ordinary person or society at large, especially in the light of societal or global changes?
4. How and why is culture affected by changes? Does it become diluted or does it adapt in its various forms?
5. Is there value in preserving culture in its various forms?
6. What threats are there to cultural preservation?
7. How and why do entities with power and influence seek to curtail – or use – the arts?
8. How, if at all, should governments support the arts and culture? Why so?

2026 RI Y6 "ARTS & CULTURE" INFOPACK
PAST-YEAR EXAMINATION QUESTIONS

(1a) ARTS – Cambridge

1. Assess the view that only well-known works of art can be considered great. (Cambridge 2025)
2. 'There is a lack of appreciation for the value of music.' How far is this true in your society? (Cambridge 2024)
3. Consider the argument that there should be no censorship of the arts in modern society. (Cambridge 2023)
4. 'Dramas on television or film are never as effective as a live performance.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2022)
5. Examine the claim that music without words lacks both meaning and appeal. (Cambridge 2022)
6. 'Films are concerned with escaping from the problems of everyday life, rather than addressing them.' Discuss (Cambridge 2021)
7. 'The arts are nothing more than a luxury.' How far is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2021)
8. 'An appreciation of music is vital for a fully rounded education.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
9. Does violence in the visual media portray reality or encourage the unacceptable? (Cambridge 2019)
10. Can fiction teach us anything meaningful about the real world? (Cambridge 2019)
11. 'Works of art which have been removed from their country of origin should be returned.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2018)
12. In your society, to what extent is it acceptable for public money to be used for the acquisition of works of art? (Cambridge 2017)
13. Examine the role of music in establishing a national identity in your society. (Cambridge 2017)
14. 'Any adaptation of a novel for a film, television or the theatre is never as effective as the original.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2016)
15. To what extent should the arts in your society focus on local rather than foreign talent? (Cambridge 2015)
16. 'For the majority of people, the Arts are irrelevant to their daily lives.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2014)
17. Do films offer anything more than an escape from reality? (Cambridge 2014)
18. 'Unlike the Arts, such as writing or music, Mathematics lacks the capacity for creativity.' How far do you agree with this statement? (Cambridge 2013)
19. 'People in the Arts, living or dead, receive far more recognition than those in the Sciences, even though it is less deserved.' Consider this claim. (Cambridge 2012)
20. 'Only modern architecture and modern art have a place in today's world.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2011)
21. 'The book has no place in modern society.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2010)
22. Would it matter if all the performing arts venues in your society, such as concert halls and theatres, were closed down? (Cambridge 2010)

(1b) ARTS – RI

1. 'There is a decline in the appreciation of traditional art forms today.' How far is this true in your society? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
2. 'The arts should not rely on government support.' Comment. (RI 2024 Y6 Prelim)
3. To what extent can popular music today be considered works of art? (RI 2024 Y6 Timed Practice)
4. To what extent do the Arts contribute to the Singaporean identity? (RI 2023 Y6 Prelims)
5. 'There needs to be more emphasis on the arts in the school curriculum than the sciences.' How far do you agree? (RI 2023 Y6 Common Test)

6. 'Censorship of the arts is necessary to maintain social cohesion.' To what extent is this view still relevant in your society? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
7. Should efforts be made to preserve traditional art forms? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
8. To what extent should traditional art forms be preserved in a world driven by innovation? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelims)
9. Does your country do enough to develop the Arts? (RI 2022 Y5 Promo)
10. 'A career in sports or the arts is still undesirable.' How far is this true of your society? (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
11. Consider the view that comics offer nothing more than entertainment. (RI 2022 Y5 Common Test)
12. To what extent are the arts valued in your society? (RI 2022 Y6 Timed Practice)
13. 'The arts ask questions while science provides answers.' How valid is this view? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
14. 'Art is only worth what people will pay for it.' Do you agree? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
15. 'Pop music has no value beyond being a source of entertainment.' What is your view? (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
16. Should the Arts do anything more than entertain? (RI 2021 Y5 Common Essay Assignment)
17. How far do you agree with the view that the literary arts are about personal enjoyment rather than practical benefits? (RI 2020 Y6 Term 3 Common Essay Assignment)
18. 'Support for the arts should come mainly from the government.' Discuss. (RI 2020 Y6 Timed Practice)
19. 'The Arts have no place in a society that values practicality.' What is your view? (RI 2020 Y5 Timed Practice)
20. Consider the value of creativity in society. (RI 2020 Y5 Timed Practice)
21. Consider the notion that the Arts are aesthetically pleasing but are of little real value. (RI 2019 Y6 Prelims)
22. 'Fiction has no place in a pragmatic world.' Discuss. (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)
23. 'Now more than ever, the arts should be subject to government censorship.' Comment. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
24. Examine the extent to which fashion can be considered art. (RI 2018 Y6 Prelims)
25. Examine the claim that artists should have complete freedom of expression. (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
26. In times of economic hardship, should a government be expected to provide financial support to the arts? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
27. To what extent has technology had a negative impact on the arts, such as music or photography? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
28. Should the Arts do anything more than entertain? (RI 2018 Y5 CT1)
29. 'We should abolish state funding for the Arts.' How far do you agree that this should be the case for your society? (RI 2017 Y6 Prelims)
30. Consider the consequences if all art museums and art galleries in your country were closed down. (RI 2017 Y6 CT1)
31. 'An education in sports or arts is still seen to be undesirable in your society today.' Do you agree? (RI 2017 Y5 Promo)
32. 'Comic books have little to offer us except entertainment.' Comment. (RI 2017 Y5 Promo)
33. 'The progress of a society is sustained by the sciences rather than the arts.' How far do you agree with this statement? (RI 2016 Y6 Prelims)
34. 'The arts, such as music and literature, are of no real value to society.' Is this a valid comment? (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
35. Examine the extent to which graffiti can be considered art. (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
36. Should the Arts always challenge the status quo? (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
37. Is an arts education becoming irrelevant in your society? (RI 2016 Y5 CT)
38. To what extent can Mathematics be considered a form of art? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelims)

39. 'Young people today have no appreciation of art and no taste in music.' Do you agree? (RI 2015 Y6 CT2)
40. 'The Arts are nothing but mere entertainment.' Is this a fair assessment of the Arts in your society? (RI 2015 Y6 CT1)
41. Does music offer anything more than momentary pleasure? (RI 2015 Y5 Promo)
42. 'Different for the sake of being different.' Is this a fair assessment of the arts? (RI 2015 Y5 Promo)
43. To what extent can the literary or performing arts be a vehicle for change? (RI 2014 Y6 Prelims)
44. 'Real art is something that makes us uncomfortable.' Do you agree? (RI 2014 Y6 CT2)
45. 'Science requires more thinking than the Arts.' Is this true? (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)
46. Is there any value in horror films and books? (RI 2014 Y6 CT1)
47. To what extent do you think that creativity can be cultivated? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)
48. To what extent is cooking an art form? (RI 2013 Y6 CT2)
49. Consider the significance of theatre in modern society. (RI 2013 Y6 Prelims)
50. 'The teaching of literary classics should be made compulsory in schools.' Discuss. (RI 2013 Y6 CT1)
51. 'Art is not a mirror held up to reality, but a hammer with which to shape it.' Do you agree? (2013 Y5 CT)
52. To what extent has technology revolutionised the arts? (RI 2012 Y6 Prelims)
53. 'Literature, drama and art all amount to making something out of nothing.' Is this a fair assessment of the arts? (RI 2012 Y6 CT1)
54. 'Above all, the Arts teach us to be human.' Do you agree? (RI 2012 Y5 Promo)
55. 'There is too little artistic freedom in Singapore today.' Comment. (RI 2012 Y5 CT)
56. 'Copyright benefits the arts.' Do you agree? (RI 2011 Y6 CT2)
57. 'The arts disturb while the sciences reassure.' How true is this? (RI 2011 Y6 CT1)
58. To what extent are the arts important in your society? (RI 2011 Y5 CT)
59. Is creativity all about breaking rules? (RI 2010 Y6 Prelims)
60. Do the arts have a future in Singapore? (RI 2010 Y6 CT1)
61. 'Art has little practical value in today's society.' What is your view? (RI 2010 Y5 Promo)
62. Should the arts ever be censored? (RI 2010 Y5 CT)
63. 'Literature is useless in a pragmatic world.' Do you agree with this view? (RI 2010 Y5 CT)

(2a) CULTURE – Cambridge

1. To what extent are festivals and national holidays effective in promoting unity in your society? (Cambridge 2023)
2. Assess the view that accurate translation between languages is always necessary. (Cambridge 2023)
3. 'We shape our buildings, but then our buildings shape us.' To what extent is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
4. Assess the importance of food within Singaporean culture. (Cambridge 2019)
5. Do handicrafts still have value when machine-produced goods are so readily available? (Cambridge 2018)
6. Assess the view that traditional buildings have no future in your society. (Cambridge 2016)
7. Consider the view that spoken language is more important than the written form. (Cambridge 2013)
8. Is there any value in preserving minority languages in the world? (Cambridge 2012)
9. How important is it for people in your society to retain a sense of tradition? (Cambridge 2010)

(2b) CULTURE – RI

1. 'Traditional beliefs have little value in the modern world.' Discuss. (RI 2023 Y6 Prelims)
2. 'The world would be a better place if everyone spoke the same language.' Do you agree? (RI 2023 Y6 Prelims)

3. 'Young people today have little interest in traditional marriage.' How true is this of your society? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
4. How far do you agree that traditional clothing is outdated and impractical in today's world? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
5. 'The way that people tend to argue online makes things worse.' How true is this of your society today? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelims)
6. 'Obedience is a virtue.' Is this an accurate reflection of your society? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelims)
7. Discuss the view that risk-taking should be embraced in your society. (RI 2022 Y5 Promo)
8. Consider the importance of physical appearance in today's world. (RI 2022 Y5 Promo)
9. Consider the view that the globalisation of culture is to be embraced and not feared. (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
10. How far do you agree that celebrities have too much influence today? (RI 2022 Y5 Common Test)
11. Consider the value of travelling for leisure in the world today. (RI 2022 Y6 Timed Practice)
12. 'Fashion is more than just looking good.' What is your view? (RI 2022 Y6 Timed Practice)
13. Is there still a point in preserving national identity in your society? (RI 2022 Y6 Timed Practice)
14. 'Handicrafts no longer have any practical benefits in modern society.' Comment. (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
15. 'The belief in the supernatural serves little purpose in modern society.' Discuss. (RI 2020 Y6 Term 3 Common Essay Assignment)
16. 'Memories help us remember the past but do little for our future.' How far do you agree? (RI 2019 Y6 Prelims)
17. How far do you agree that popular music serves no real purpose? (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
18. Discuss the significance of fashion in today's world. (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
19. Do you agree that fashion serves no real value? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
20. Is there any value in preserving minority languages in the world today? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)
21. 'Traditions are increasingly irrelevant in today's world.' Do you agree? (RI 2016 Y6 Prelim)
22. Should countries spend resources on preserving historical monuments when they are struggling to meet the basic needs of their own people? (RI 2016 Y6 CT2)
23. Consider the value of fashion. (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
24. Consider the importance of preserving memories today. (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
25. To what extent does travel broaden the mind? (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
26. 'Tradition does more harm than good.' To what extent do you agree with this statement? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelim)
27. 'Fashion is as much a good thing as a bad thing.' To what extent do you agree? (RI 2015 Y6 CT2)
28. To what extent can travel broaden a person's perspectives? (RI 2015 Y6 CT2)
29. Examine the value of beauty in today's society. (RI 2015 Y6 CT1)
30. Consider the importance of traditional festivals in today's society. (RI 2015 Y5 CT)
31. 'We have placed too much importance on historical preservation.' Discuss this with reference to your society. (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)
32. To what extent has popular culture destroyed traditional art forms? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)
33. How important are memories? (RI 2013 Y6 Prelim)
34. Is it foolish to believe in the supernatural today? (RI 2013 Y6 Prelim)
35. Should entry to museums be free? (RI 2013 Y6 CT2)
36. Assess the impact of foreign films or foreign TV programmes on the culture of your society. (RI 2013 Y6 CT1)
37. Consider the view that popular culture thrives on the trivial. (RI 2011 Y5 Promo)
38. To what extent has Singapore evolved a distinct culture? (RI 2011 Y5 Promo)
39. Consider the view that globalisation destroys culture. (RI 2011 Y5 CT)
40. 'Pop culture is all about appearance.' Is this a fair comment? (RI 2010 Y5 Promo)

SECTION A: FOUNDATIONAL CONCEPTS

Reading 1: What is art?

EUs 1 & 2

Since the arts have traditionally claimed a right to our thoughtful attention, we need to spend some time exploring their nature and value. Hence the question “What is art?” In thinking about this question, the real focus of our interest is on what distinguishes worthwhile art from junk. At a practical level, this is an important question because we have limited amounts of time and money and we have to decide what to spend them on. We don’t want to waste our time on junk and we don’t want governments to waste our tax dollars buying junk for the national gallery, or supporting its production.

Most people would agree that for something to be a work of art, it must be man-made. A sunset may be beautiful and the Grand Canyon awe-inspiring, but neither would be called a work of art. Beyond this, opinions differ about what makes something art. We will explore three possible criteria:

- The intentions of the artist
- The quality of the work
- The response of spectators

1a) Intentions of the Artist

According to the intention criterion, something is a work of art if it is made by someone with the intention of evoking an aesthetic response in the audience. (**Aesthetics** is a branch of philosophy which studies beauty and the arts.) We naturally think of an artist as wanting to communicate something to us, and communication is a deliberate, intentional activity. A sunset may evoke various emotions in us, but it is not a work of art because it does not intend to have any effect on us. Similarly, if some ants crawling around on a patch of sand happen to trace out what looks like a portrait of Tony Blair, we would not say they had produced a work of art. This is because the portrait is the result of random activity rather than conscious design.

If something is to count as a work of art, then it should not be made with a practical end in mind, but simply with the intention of pleasing or provoking people. You would not describe a manufacturer of pots and pans as an artist because his intention is to produce kitchen utensils rather than works of art. Admittedly, many functional objects also have an aesthetic element built into them, and I prefer attractive and elegant pots and pans to ugly and awkward ones. Nevertheless, there exists a special class of objects that are made with a specifically aesthetic intention, and these are the ones that we properly call works of art.

We can say, then, that works of art differ from natural objects in that they are made with an intention, and they differ from everyday objects in that they are made with the specific intention to please or provoke rather than for some practical end.

1b) Criticism of the Intention Criterion

Despite the appeal of the intention criterion, some critics have doubted that simply intending something to be art is enough to magically transform it into art. For example, if I take my desk with papers and a half-drunk cup of coffee on it, put it in an art gallery with a glass case around it, and call it Teacher’s Work Desk – VIII, is it magically transformed into a work of art simply because I intend it to be so ?

The artist Tracey Emin did something not so different with a work called **My Bed**, which was exhibited at the Turner Prize exhibition in London in 1999, and which consists of an unmade bed with packets of condoms and a bottle of vodka next to it. (When Emin’s work was first exhibited, two art students caused a stir by staging a semi-naked pillow fight on it with the intention, they said, of making it ‘more interesting’. They claimed that what they did was itself a work of art, which they called **Two Naked Men Jump Into Tracey’s Bed**. Some years ago, a canny Scotsman called Fife Robertson came up with

a name for this kind of thing: he called it PHony ART, or 'phart' for short. Emin's work was eventually bought by the collector Charles Saatchi for 150,000 pounds.)

In his book ***The Culture of Complaint***, the art critic Robert Hughes gives the following amusing example of what happens when art is judged merely by the intentions of the creator with no regard to its quality:

In Holland...the government set up a fund to buy work by artists almost irrespective of how good it was. All that mattered was that they should be alive and Dutch. About 8000 Dutch artists are represented in that collection. None of it is shown and as everyone in Holland except the artists involved now admits, about 98 per cent of it is rubbish. The artists think it's all junk except their own work. The storage, air-conditioning and maintenance expenses are now so high that they have to get rid of the stuff. But they can't. Nobody wants it. You can't give it away. They tried giving it to public institutions, like lunatic asylums and hospitals. But even the lunatic asylums insisted on standards – they wanted to pick and choose. So there it all sits, democratic, non-hierarchical, non-elitist, non-sexist, unsalable and, to the great regret of the Dutch government, only partially biodegradable.

Taken together, our two criticisms of the intentions criterion suggest that the intentions of the creator are neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition for something to be a work of art. They are not necessary because something that was not originally intended as art may now be treated as such; and they are not sufficient because something that is intended as art might simply be junk.

2a) Quality of the Work

The second criterion for distinguishing art from non-art is the intrinsic quality of the work. This criterion is closely connected with the idea of skill. We generally expect an artist to have a high level of technical competence, and feel that an artist should be able to make a good likeness, a musician a pleasing melody, and a poet a well-crafted rhyme. In short, we feel that a work of art should not be something that a person with no talent or training in the arts could have made.

The belief that a work of art should have some kind of intrinsic quality has often been associated with the idea of beauty. Traditionally, it was believed that beautiful art is produced by painting beautiful objects, or by revealing the beauty in everyday objects. But, since we can speak of beauty with respect to the form of a work of art as well as its content, perhaps we should say that a great work of art is a perfect marriage of form and content.

- The content of a work of art is what it depicts – such as a face, a landscape, or a bowl of fruit
- The form of a work of art concerns the way it is put together, and such things as unity, order, rhythm, balance, proportion, harmony and symmetry are relevant to it.

In fact, a great deal of modern art seems less concerned to produce beautiful things which please the senses than to shock or challenge the viewer. However, you might still feel that if a work of art is to be worthy of our interest it should have some kind of quality which reflects the skill of its creator.

2b) Criticisms of the Quality Criterion

Despite the appeal of the quality criterion, it is open to criticism. A work of art may, for example, have a great deal of technical competence but lack originality. There are plenty of competent but unoriginal artists churning out impressionist pictures for calendars and greeting cards. Such art is known as **kitsch** – from the German *verkitschen etwas* meaning to 'knock something off'. Kitsch is basically any form of clichéd art. The USA's 'most popular painting' – is an example of kitsch, as is the music you hear in shopping malls, or the soap operas you see on TV.

The problem of forgeries is also relevant here. Perhaps the most famous forger of paintings was the Dutch artist Han Van Meegeren (1889-1947) who painted some fake Vermeers in the 1930s that fooled the art world and were widely accepted as genuine. (Vermeer was a seventeenth-century Dutch painter). Even after Van Meegeren's hoax was exposed, some art critics continued to insist that the paintings were genuine! The best-known of Van Meegeren's 'Vermeers', called ***The Disciples at Emmaus***.

The other side of the above point is that a work of art can sometimes show originality, and yet require little technical skill. Consider the bull's head by Pablo Picasso (1881-1973). The head is made of an old bicycle saddle and a rusty pair of handlebars, and a small child probably could have put it together. Yet for Picasso to see beyond the everyday function of these objects was an astonishing insight and is, in a way, similar to a great writer making a strikingly original metaphor.

To summarise, we can say that quality and skill seem to be neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition for something to be a work of art. It is not necessary because works such as Picasso's Bull's Head are original but do not require much skill; and it is not sufficient because kitsch and forgeries may require skill but are hardly interesting works of art.

3) Response of Spectators

The third criterion for distinguishing between art and non-art is the response of spectators. It might be said that, just as a joke requires someone to laugh at it, so a work of art requires an appreciative spectator in order to complete it. Writers want to be read, painters want exhibitions, and choirs crave an audience.

One of the key questions in thinking about this criterion is which spectators we should appeal to. Since 'the general public' usually prefer the familiar to the strange and content to form, they have often been hostile to new artistic movements, and many artists have had little time for their opinions. The poet Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792-1822) once observed that 'Time reverses the judgement of the foolish crowd', and there seems to be some truth in this. The 1913 world premiere of Stravinsky's *Rite of Spring* in Paris was booed off stage by the audience, and Picasso's *Les Femmes d'Alger (O.J.)* (1907) met with shock and outrage from his contemporaries. Both works are now considered to be part of the canon of great works of art.

At the same time, we must keep in mind that some artists may have a vested interest in dismissing the opinions of the 'uninformed' public – for the public have the annoying habit of pointing out the absurdities of the more extreme fringes of modern art. An artist may comfort himself with the thought that many new works of art now accepted as great art were originally dismissed as 'rubbish' by the public; but perhaps some of the things the public dismiss as rubbish really are rubbish.

At this point, we might appeal to expert opinion to help us to decide which works of art are genuinely worthwhile. Some people think it makes no sense to speak about 'expert opinion' in the arts on the grounds that you cannot argue about matters of taste. But good critics can help you to decide which of the millions of artworks available are worth your time and attention; and they can also help you to see things in a work of art that you might otherwise have overlooked. Indeed, just as a psychoanalyst may reveal things about a person that they are not consciously aware of, so a good critic may understand the meaning of a work of art better than the artist who made the work. Admittedly, experts sometimes disagree in their judgements, but their arguments are usually much more sophisticated than the 'I like it' / 'I don't like it' disagreements of those who do not have any background knowledge.

OTHER IDEAS ABOUT THE NATURE OF ART

Given the difficulties with the above criteria, a simple answer to the question 'what is art?' might be 'art is what is found in an art gallery or treated by experts as a work of art'.

Is everything art?

In the early twentieth century, the French artist Marcel Duchamp (1887-1968) began exhibiting what he called 'readymades'. As the name suggests, these were simply objects taken out of their everyday context, renamed, and put in an art gallery. Perhaps the most famous of Duchamp's readymades was his work called *The Fountain*, which was a white porcelain urinal with the pseudonym 'R Mutt' daubed on it.

By suggesting that everyday objects might have aesthetic value, Duchamp can be seen as raising the question of where art ends and non-art begins. Taking our cue from Duchamp, we might be tempted to say that if we just opened our eyes, we would see that everything is art. But if we say that everything is art, then the word 'art' is in danger of losing its meaning because it no longer distinguishes some things from other things. Just as 'high' only means something relative to 'not-high', so 'art' only means something relative to 'non-art'.

Instead of saying that everything is art we could perhaps rescue the above idea by saying that everything can be looked at from an aesthetic point of view. When something is put in an art gallery, that is precisely the way we are invited to look at it. Thus, while an unmade bed in a hotel room is unlikely to engage your aesthetic interest, if you put a glass case round it and put it in an art gallery, you will stop looking at it as a purely functional object, and this might set in motion the wheels of thought and feeling... But then again it might not! After all, just because something is in an art gallery does not necessarily mean that it is worthy of our interest.

Inexhaustibility

Perhaps the distinguishing feature of a great work of art is that it is inexhaustible in the sense that every time you come back to it you discover new things in it. A related idea is that great works of art stand the test of time and speak across generations and cultures. There is, for example, something extraordinary about the fact that Sophocles' play *Oedipus Rex* can move us with the same power and intensity that it moved Athenian audiences two and a half thousand years ago. Indeed, it could be argued that the winnowing effects of time act as a kind of ideal spectator helping us to distinguish enduring art from art which is merely fashionable.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. Which of the three criteria do you think is most important & why? Duchamp's Readymades and Maurizio Cattelan's Comedian are two examples of art that seem to straddle the line between art and non-art. Would you consider these works to be art? Why / why not? How do you think perceptions of what constitute art have changed over time and why? In what way(s) might future trends shape perceptions of what is considered art? Conversely, do you think there is/are any perception(s) that may always be considered important regardless of time?
2. The article identifies the Response of Spectators as a criterion. Do you think spectator response in terms of what kind of art is considered beautiful or artistic is likely to be consistent or to vary significantly across individuals and communities? Why?
3. The author asserts that "good critics can help you to decide which of the millions of artworks available are worth your time and attention; and they can also help you to see things in a work of art that you might otherwise have overlooked" (lines 121-122) – to what extent do you agree with this and why?

Related essay questions:

1. Assess the view that only well-known works of art can be considered great. (Cambridge 2025)
2. Examine the claim that music without words lacks both meaning and appeal. (Cambridge 2022)
3. To what extent can popular music today be considered works of art? (RI 2024 Y6 Timed Practice)
4. 'Art is only worth what people will pay for it.' Do you agree? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
5. Consider the notion that the Arts are aesthetically pleasing but are of little real value. (RI 2019 Y6 Prelims)
6. Examine the extent to which fashion can be considered art. (RI 2018 Y6 Prelims)
7. Examine the extent to which graffiti can be considered art. (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
8. To what extent can Mathematics be considered a form of art? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelims)
9. 'Literature, drama and art all amount to making something out of nothing.' Is this a fair assessment of the arts? (RI 2012 Y6 CT1)

SECTION A: FOUNDATIONAL CONCEPTS

Reading 2: Why we need arts in times of crisis

Artwork Archive | Anonymous | 9 June 2020

EUs 1 & 2



Ryan Katz
created
Everything Will
Be Okay in
partnership with
The Lytle House
Art Initiative and
Jason Kofke.
Designed
by: Jason Kofke /
Muralist: Ryan
Tova Katz. Image
permission, Ryan
Katz

Art allows us to examine what it means to be human, to voice and express, and to bring people and ideas together. As we rise to the challenge of our new normal of life in a global pandemic, we are seeing more clearly what needs to change in our pre-COVID-19 society.

We are still experiencing a global pandemic. We are engaging with racial injustice made more visible with George Floyd's death and the recent protests across the globe. In times of crisis, we need humanity, expression, and the community that the arts create. In the United States and around the world, COVID-19 has shed light on our economic, social, and political systems. We are seeing how systemic racial inequality is putting people of colour at a higher risk during the pandemic. We are realising the economic implications of relying on minimum wage "essential" jobs. We are seeing disease become politicised. And we are seeing a growing mental health crisis as a response to COVID-19. What we put our energy and efforts into now will affect what our future looks like. In campaigning for arts support, the Colorado Business Committee for the Arts stated, "The values we support today will determine what we have when this is over."

This is a time to value the arts. Whether big or small, sidewalk chalk art or community murals, art makes a difference in how we live our lives. The arts create wellness in our day-to-day lives by helping us process our lives individually and allowing us to come together collectively. Art allows us to communicate from afar, generating positivity, appreciation and hope during COVID-19. In times of social injustice and unrest, art amplifies important voices and messages. In a tumultuous world, art matters. Here's why.

Art is an expression of what it means to be human

Art-making and viewing art allows us to process our experiences. Art helps us to express and to understand the world around us. We are unique in our human drive to create and engage with the arts. Historically, humans have been visually expressive beings. The cave of the hands, *Cueva de las Manos*, in Argentina is an example of early visual expression. The artwork in the cave carbon-dates to an estimated 7300 BC. These cave walls host a hybrid of hunting scenes and relief handprints, probably made by blowing paint materials through hollowed-out bones, or reeds. This sea of overlapping hands and illustration provides a lens into a past life and builds a present-day connection with our stone-age ancestors.

30 Ancient humans not only recorded their lives through art, but they also used art to express themselves. We do this today, too—the arts create community by depicting shared events and to express our individual perspectives. We define our human experience by the cultures we create and participate in. Culture, made up of customs, social interactions, and activities, is fuelled by the arts. Be it music, food, or visual arts, culture and the arts are inseparable.

35 We are seeing an increased turn to the arts during the COVID-19 pandemic. Globally, we have turned to art engagement as a source of comfort and strength. Participating in and viewing art makes us connect to a more universal human experience. Be it art-making at home, public murals, watching and listening to plays and music, or new-found interests in culinary arts, art is an expression of what it means to be human.

Art fosters understanding between communities

40 As we globally grapple with inequalities that have always existed but are more visible and striking in the past weeks, we are seeing art being used as a tool to create stronger communities. Art can allow us to not just understand ourselves, but to understand each other on a deeper level.

We can engage with online arts in a way to connect more deeply with current issues and events. There are a multitude of ways to experience the arts virtually during COVID-19. Museums are moving exhibits online. Virtual galleries are hosting online show openings and artist talks.

45 Museums today are also working to be more community-informed, but they are working within the heavy frameworks of their past. Historically, museums have reinforced inequality in their structure and tradition of exclusivity, in objectifying other cultures, and with unjustly collected artworks. However, there are many museums that are working to overcome this past. Many institutions are working to repatriate, create self-aware programming, and to re-interpret and re-contextualise their collections. With the internet at our fingertips, gaining access to art made by historically
50 unrepresented voices and thoughtful museums is easier and more important than ever. Here are just a few examples:

The Smithsonian created a National Museum of African American History and Culture on the National Mall in Washington, D.C. Visitors to the NMAAHC travel through time to understand the Black American. The NMAAHC has a digital resource guide and access to online exhibits and video archives.

55 The Birmingham Civil Rights Institute is an interpretive museum and research centre in Birmingham, Alabama exploring the struggles of the Civil Rights Movement in the 1950s and 1960s. The institute is actively exploring the effects of COVID-19 on Black communities. The BCRI has an online oral history archive.

60 The Whitney Plantation is the only plantation museum in Louisiana that exclusively focuses on the lives of enslaved people. While visitors learn through guided tours, online viewers can connect through a virtual book club and by reading about and viewing photos and videos on the site. The Equal Justice Initiative created The Legacy Museum: From Enslavement to Mass Incarceration in Montgomery, Alabama. Web visitors are able to learn about slavery in America through videos, photos, and online resources.

65 The Studio Museum in Harlem focuses on exhibiting works by both emerging and established artists of African descent and has a residency program that continues to have artists establish themselves in high powered careers. Thelma Golden, an art-world celebrity and current director, is an outspoken art-world leader changing the way curators think about art and presentation with her commitment to opening minds and highlighting new voices.

70

Art is good for our health

While you are enjoying art viewing and engaging with different perspectives from home, revel in the knowledge that you are being healthy! Art is a proven tool for stress reduction and well-being. There are countless studies into the physical and mental benefits of making art, and the benefits of even

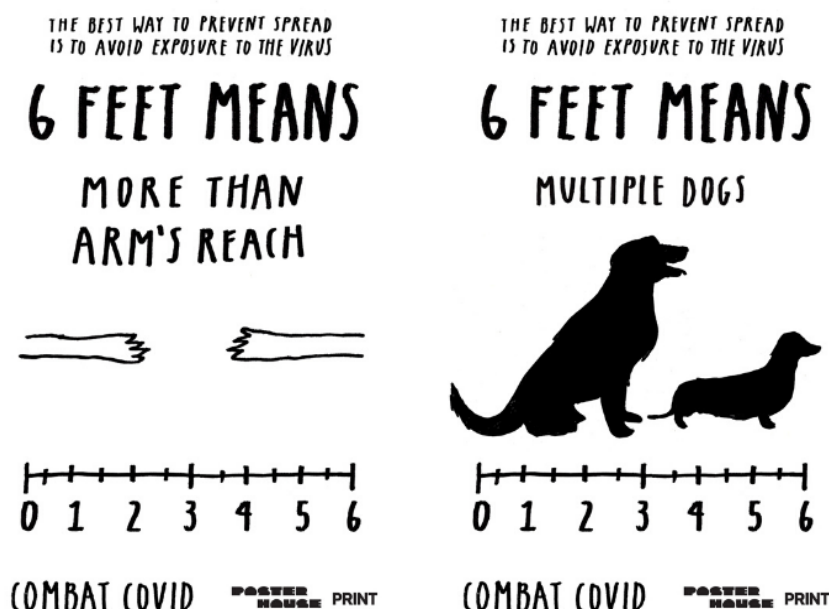
75

looking at an artwork. Making and looking at art has long-term effects like boosting our brain function and our immune systems as well as contributing positively to our mental and emotional health. Art helps us process trauma, express difficult feelings, and work through experiences.

80

Art has promoted health within our homes during COVID-19 as families have been getting creative at home. As we are spending more time with ourselves and during this pandemic, art and craft-making have rocketed.

Public art allows us to see ourselves and our identities within a larger society and to feel comfortable in our surroundings. It's no surprise that statues of oppressive historical figures are being removed as a part of the current social justice movement. When our environments represent and reflect our experiences and communities, we are healthier and happier.



PSA by Joe
Hollier part of
the Times
Square Art's
Messages for
a City Project.
Courtesy of
Poster House
and Times
Square Arts

85

Art can be a public health tool during COVID-19

Art helps to quickly communicate ideas through memorable visuals.

Public art can be used as a directive tool in a crisis to benefit our general wellbeing. When artists create public art featuring masks to reflect our current experiences, they send a powerful message to the public.

90

Art guides and signals how people should interact and behave within a space. Visual cues help us understand how we fit into space and make statements about what a community values. People are taking artistic interventions into their own hands and placing masks on statues all over the world to spread messages of public safety and social distancing. Masked statues are a friendly reminder to wear masks and forge an environment of solidarity. Now that we are wearing masks to help reduce the spread of COVID-19 globally, masks are getting more innovative. A range of creative masks are allowing us to continue to express ourselves and encourage us to wear masks in the first place. Mask designs, whether fun or functional, may increase usage and promote public health.

95

Not only does art help us to stay healthy through our viewership and participation, but some arts organisations are also actively fundraising to provide healthcare support during COVID-19. NOAH, the National Organisation for Arts in Health, started an Arts for Resilience in Clinicians campaign. This campaign is raising money to help health care workers avoid burnout and to address anxiety through the COVID-19 pandemic.

A winged health care worker and construction worker don boxing gloves and masks in Austin Zucchini-Fowler's Front Line Fighter and Construction Hero in Denver, Colorado. Image Credit, Austin Zucchini-Fowler.



Art helps us express gratitude during difficult times

While we are not able to congregate with friends and families as we usually would as we live through this pandemic, art allows us to create a message of gratitude from a distance.

In the past few weeks, artists of all types and from all over the world have been creating artworks that thank essential workers and healthcare workers.

For example, New York City is releasing digital artistically rendered public service announcements and messages of hope and solidarity through a city-wide art campaign. Artists are creating works to replace advertisements across the city.

In Denver, artist Austin Zucchini-Fowler started a series of murals that depict healthcare professionals as angels— masked, with wings, and donning boxing gloves. Zucchini-Fowler has expanded the series to include other professionals— a teacher with wings appeared during Teacher Appreciation Week in early May and a winged chef recently emerged on a downtown wall.

Artwork Archive user, Osian Gwent painted a 17.5ft x 8ft public mural in the Welsh town of Llanidloes. He's calling the work *The Big Thank You Mural*. The work features well-known landmarks and various individuals local to the Llanidloes area, paying tribute to essential workers within the community.

Art makes close-to-home spaces more meaningful

As more people are taking walks around their neighbourhoods as a way to get out of their homes while still following social distancing guidelines, art helps us tune in to the spaces and people around us.

In neighbourhoods across the US, families are creating chalk art murals and messages. “Chalking the walk” allows creators and walkers to experience places in a more personal way.

Similarly, people are decorating their windows and laws with signs and Christmas lights to create visual cheer. Hearts made of Christmas lights are popping up across the United States as a way to spread positivity and create a visual connection with neighbours.

Messages of community and support during the COVID-19.



Artists are rising to the occasion with art projects centred on themes of coronavirus and quarantine. Banksy playfully interpreted his stay at home life with a topsy turvy work-from-home scene in his bathroom. Banksy typically creates large scale public artworks. His work-from-home scene shows rats wreaking havoc in his real-life apartment complete with his mirror askew and rats treadmill on toilet paper rolls and swinging from hand towel rings.

In her Everything Will Be Okay Mural, Ryan Katz shares a message of comfort with her community in partnership with The Lytle House Art Initiative. Katz is starting a new arts initiative to donate murals around the city to promote positivity and beauty during COVID-19. Her first mural as part of the initiative will be a four-story-high mural to help celebrate the graduating 2020 class of Northwestern University.

Art allows us to document and process events

World events are often remembered through what comes to be iconic artwork. My God, Help Me to Survive This Deadly Love is one of the best-known artworks on the Berlin Wall. Dmitri Vrubel's painted scene in 1990 of Leonid Brezhnev and Erich Honecker embracing in a socialist brotherly kiss stands today still as a way people understand the period before the fall of the Berlin Wall.

Nearby to Vrubel's painting on the Berlin Wall is a new work that is quickly becoming iconic in representing the early weeks and stressors of COVID-19. Artist Eme Freethinker's toilet paper hoarding Gollum from Lord of the Rings is now a hallmark in the Mauerpark public park in Berlin. Gollum is depicted with wild eyes and his frog-like body holding a single roll of toilet paper and saying, "Mien Shatz." My precious.



Gollum and Ice Age's Scrat covet toilet paper in Eme Freethinker's Gollum and Scrat, Berlin, Germany 2020 image courtesy of EME Street Art.

As protestors walk throughout the United States to demand justice for George Floyd and the countless others, protest art is appearing as well. Eme Freethinker returned to the same wall where he painted Gollum to mural George Floyd. Greta McLain, Xena Goldman and Cadex Herrera painted a mural at the corner of 38th Street and Chicago Avenue South, on the wall of Cup Foods—with the blessing from the store owner—where George Floyd was arrested and killed.

Muralists Thomas “Detour” Evans, Richard Brasil, and Giovannie “JUST” Dixon aka Justin Spire are creating murals in memory of George Floyd and Breonna Taylor. The three artists are pairing their large-scale portraits of victims of racial violence with the call for memorialising and remembering with the sentiment #spraytheirname.

More and more, art is appearing around the United States and the world to document COVID-19 and experiences of racial injustice. Art helps to make social justice visible and documents movements— it is able to rally support and create a sense of community in times of crisis.

We need the arts in difficult times

Art gives us immeasurable personal and social benefits. We rely on the arts to help us through difficult times. Art reminds us that we are not alone and that we share a universal human experience. Through art, we feel deep emotions together and are able to process experiences, find connections, and create impact.

Art helps us to record and process more than just individual experiences. Making art documents the world around us and allows us to work through how we are a part of it. Art making is half of it—we also need to photograph, share, and record these creations so that they will live on throughout history. Documenting your artwork is easier than ever with online inventorying and management platforms like Artwork Archive. Together, we can expand the art world “archive” with more representative voices and experiences and contribute to our historical narrative through the arts.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. Which of the purposes outlined resonates most with you, and why?
2. Which of these purposes do you consider particularly relevant to your society, in light of recent crises?
3. Conversely, might there be certain preconditions that are necessary for the arts to fulfil such purposes, which you believe might not be present in your society?
4. Do you believe that for any of these purposes to be fulfilled, society may have to make certain sacrifices or suffer adverse consequences?

Related essay questions:

1. 'Films are concerned with escaping from the problems of everyday life, rather than addressing them.' Discuss (Cambridge 2021)
2. 'The arts are nothing more than a luxury.' How far is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2021)
3. 'An appreciation of music is vital for a fully rounded education.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
4. To what extent do the Arts contribute to the Singaporean identity? (RI 2023 Y6 Prelims)
5. 'Art is only worth what people will pay for it.' Do you agree? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
6. 'The arts ask questions while science provides answers.' How valid is this view? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
7. How far do you agree with the view that the literary arts are about personal enjoyment rather than practical benefits? (RI 2020 Y6 Term 3 Common Essay Assignment)
8. 'For the majority of people, the Arts are irrelevant to their daily lives.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2014)

Related case study:

- 1)  <http://estonianworld.com/culture/what-role-does-art-serve-in-times-of-war-and-suffering/>
(Estonia, 2022, estonian world): Discusses the role art serves in times of other crises like war.

SECTION A: FOUNDATIONAL CONCEPTS

Reading 3: The many meanings of culture

EUs 6-9

Jason Rothman | *The New Yorker* | 26 December 2014

There's something innately funny about Merriam-Webster's announcement, earlier this month, that "culture" is their 2014 Word of the Year. "Culture" is the "Scary Movie" of words of the year, which, ordinarily, are supposed to reflect culture ("vape," "selfie") without actually being "culture." Merriam-Webster's editors are at pains to clarify that they weren't trying to be meta (which, incidentally, would've made a great word of the year back in 2000). The word "culture," they explain, was simply the word that saw the biggest spike in look-ups on their Web site. Confusion about culture was just part of the culture this year. People were desperate to know what "culture" meant.

It goes without saying that "culture" is a confusing word, this year or any year. Merriam-Webster offers six definitions for it (including the biological one, as in "bacterial culture"). The problem is that "culture" is more than the sum of its definitions. If anything, its value as a word depends on the tension between them. The critic Raymond Williams, in his souped-up dictionary, "Keywords," writes that **"culture" has three divergent meanings: there's culture as a process of individual enrichment, as when we say that someone is "cultured"** (in 1605, Francis Bacon wrote about "the culture and manurance¹ of minds"); **culture as a group's "particular way of life,"** as when we talk about French culture, company culture, or multiculturalism; and **culture as an activity,** pursued by means of the museums, concerts, books, and movies that might be encouraged by a Ministry of Culture (or covered on a blog like this one). These three senses of culture are actually quite different, and, Williams writes, they compete with one another. Each time we use the word "culture," we incline toward one or another of its aspects: toward the "culture" that's imbibed through osmosis or the "culture" that's learned at museums, toward the "culture" that makes you a better a person or the "culture" that just inducts you into a group.

There's a historical sense, too, in which "culture" is a polemical word. In the nineteenth century, Williams explains, "culture" was often opposed to "civilisation." Civilisation, the thinking went, was a homogenising system of efficient, rational rules, designed to encourage discipline and "progress." Culture was the opposite: an unpredictable expression of human potential for its own sake. (It's for this reason that a term like "the culture industry" has an oxymoronic ring.) Today, we don't often use the word "civilisation"—we prefer to talk, more democratically, in terms of culture—but we're still conflicted. We can't help but notice how "civilised" life seems both to facilitate culture and to deaden it. Museums make it easy to see art, but they also weigh it down. Rock and roll sounds better in a club than in a concert hall.

These are solid, perennial reasons to look up "culture" in the dictionary. But why did more people than usual look it up this year? The editors at Merriam-Webster decline to speculate. They note, merely, that "the term conveys a kind of academic attention to systematic behaviour." Here's my theory: more people looked up "culture" this year because it's become an unsettling word. "Culture" used to be a good thing. Now it's not. That isn't to say that American culture has gotten worse. (It has gotten worse in some ways, and better in others.) It's to say that the word "culture" has taken on a negative cast. The most positive aspect of "culture"—the idea of personal, humane enrichment—now seems especially remote. In its place, the idea of culture as unconscious groupthink is ascendent.

In the postwar decades, "culture" was associated with the quest for personal growth: even if you rejected "establishment" culture, you could turn to "the counterculture." In the eighties, nineties, and

¹ *Manurance is an obsolete word that refers to the cultivation or training of the mind.*

aughts², it was a source of pride: the multiculturalist ethos had us identifying with our cultures. But today, “culture” has a furtive, shady, ridiculous aspect. **Often, when we attach the word “culture” to something, it’s to suggest that it has a pervasive, pernicious influence** (as in “celebrity culture”). At other times, “culture” is used in an aspirational way that’s obviously counterfactual: institutions that drone on about their “culture of transparency” or “culture of accountability” often have neither. On all sides, “culture” is used in a trivialising way: there’s no real culture in “coffee culture” (although the coffee at Culture, a coffee shop near my office, is excellent). But, at the same time, it’s hard to imagine applying the word “culture” to even the most bona-fide “cultural institutions.” We don’t say that MOMA fosters “art culture,” because to describe art as a “culture” is, subtly, to denigrate it. In 1954, when the magazine *Film Culture* was founded, its name made movie lovers sound glamorous. Today, it sounds vaguely condescending.

An antiwar activist couple who shaped history

This year, there was the rise of the powerful term “rape culture.” (It was coined a long time ago, in a 1975 documentary film called “Rape Culture” that focussed, in part, on an organisation called Prisoners Against Rape; Ariel Levy, in a recent piece for this magazine, defines it as “a value system in which women are currency, and sex is something that men get—or take—from them.”) The spread of the idea of “rape culture” hasn’t just changed how we think about rape; it’s changed how we think about culture. Among other things, “rape culture” uses the word “culture” in a way that doesn’t involve, on any level, the idea of personal enrichment. Instead, the term’s weight is placed, fully and specifically, on Williams’s other two aspects of culture: on the subterranean, group-defining norms (misogyny, privilege) that encourage violence against women, and on the cultural institutions (movies, fraternities) that propagate those norms. The term works, in part, because of its dissonance. You can’t see the word “culture” next to the word “rape” without revising your ideas about what “culture” means.

No comparable “culture” term has been invoked in relation to the deaths of Michael Brown, Eric Garner, and the other African-Americans killed, recently, in encounters with the police. But those events have also pushed us to think about “culture” as an inhumane, malevolent force. And I suspect that many of us have also been keeping our own inner ledgers, where we track the ways in which “culture” has seemed, more and more, like the kind of thing you’d want “civilisation” to overrule.

That’s not to say, necessarily, that music culture or art culture or book culture has gotten worse—or that our collective way of life has gone downhill. It’s our sense of the *word* “culture” that has grown darker, sharper, more sceptical. But, if words are tools for thinking, then this year “culture” has been used to think about the parts of our society that function poorly. That may even be a sign, in a way, of an improvement in our culture. If our increasingly analytical, sociological way of thinking about “culture” is helping us to improve the culture, that’s a positive development. Confusion over its evolving meaning is a good reason to look up “culture” in the dictionary, but so is an interest in understanding the world and making it better.

All this might make you wonder: Does it even make sense to have a single word, “culture,” with such divergent uses? Maybe not; many people, Williams writes, have called “culture” a “loose or confused” term. It’s possible to imagine a more rational system, in which one word describes the activities of artistic and intellectual life, another our group identity, and a third our implicit norms and ways of living. Those terms, whatever they might be, would be narrower and simpler—but they’d also be less accurate. They would obscure the overlap between life, art, and politics.

And they’d be less meaningful, too. “Culture” may be pulling itself apart from the inside, but it represents, in its way, a wish. The wish is that a group of people might discover, together, a good way

² This refers to the 2000s

85 of life; that their good way of life might express itself in their habits, institutions, and activities; and
that those, in turn, might help individuals flourish in their own ways. The best culture would be one in
which the three meanings of “culture” weren’t at odds with one another. That’s not the culture we
have at the moment; our culture is fractured, and so our sense of the word “culture” is, too. But it’s
90 possible to imagine a world in which our collective attitudes and institutions further everyone’s
individual growth. Maybe, in such a world, the meaning of “culture” would be more obvious; we
wouldn’t have to look it up.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. In Reading 3, Rothman outlines three key meanings of ‘culture’ (lines 12-17). When considering the relationship between the arts and culture, which meanings do you find meaningful and why?
2. Why does Rothman say that “the culture industry” is, to an extent, “oxymoronic” (line 26)?
3. Rothman argues that increasingly, people consider culture a form of “unconscious groupthink” (line 38). Do you agree with such an assessment of culture? What are some local examples that appear to support and refute this respectively?
4. In line 39, Rothman asserts that “the quest for personal growth” is one way in which culture may lead to change. In what ways may a concern with different understandings of culture prompt change either on an individual or community level?
5. In lines 59-61, Rothman argues that rape culture is based on two meanings of culture that reinforce each other: as a set of “group-defining norms” and of “cultural institutions that propagate [such] norms”. Apart from rape culture, what other ostensibly pernicious ‘cultural’ phenomena can you think of that seems to be based on these two sets of forces working in tandem?
6. From lines 66-68, how does Rothman use language to show that society tends to have a negative perception of culture?
7. In what ways is the last sentence of the last paragraph an effective conclusion (lines 90-91)?

Related essay questions:

1. To what extent are festivals and national holidays effective in promoting unity in your society? (Cambridge 2023)
2. ‘We shape our buildings, but then our buildings shape us.’ To what extent is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
3. Assess the importance of food within Singaporean culture. (Cambridge 2019)
4. How important is it for people in your society to retain a sense of tradition? (Cambridge 2010)
5. ‘Young people today have little interest in traditional marriage.’ How true is this of your society? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
6. ‘Handicrafts no longer have any practical benefits in modern society.’ Comment. (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
7. ‘The belief in the supernatural serves little purpose in modern society.’ Discuss. (RI 2020 Y6 Term 3 Common Essay Assignment)
8. ‘Tradition does more harm than good.’ To what extent do you agree with this statement? (RI 2015 Y6 Prelim)

SECTION B: INVESTING IN THE ARTS

Reading 4: The role of the arts in making a nation home

EUs 3 & 5

Paul Tan | *The Straits Times* | 4 June 2017

This reading will help you:

- Examine how the arts can have a transformative effect on a nation, not only economically, but socially and politically.
- Understand that, despite being a relatively young nation, Singapore's multi-ethnic heritage has led to diversity in art-making and its reception.
- Consider how such diversity may lead to the arts challenging boundaries or posing awkward questions that are part and parcel of a maturing nation.

One of the most abiding memories in my leisure travels is visiting the small islands in the Seto Inland Sea of Japan. This is a clutch of islands in a rural part of Japan in between the city of Okayama and the large island of Shikoku. Previously an under-the-radar destination among art aficionados, these isles have in recent years become popular with general tourists looking for a unique experience focused on art and culture, coupled with the assurance of quality Japanese hospitality and cuisine.

What struck me on my brief visit to that region was how art has been integrated into these islands and how this process has been instrumental in revitalising local communities. These were islands which faced a raft of problems – depopulation, the loss of a farming economy and even environmental degradation.

Today, there are small museums, public art installations and art trails found everywhere – particularly on the islands of Naoshima, Teshima and Shodoshima – and old buildings and industrial sites have been repurposed to house fascinating and visually arresting artwork. Anyone who has visited the islands would have interacted with elderly island residents acting as docents in arts spaces, or serving in cafes and bed-and-breakfast establishments.

When one reflects on the local history of these islands, it is nothing short of amazing how art has activated all typologies of spaces and brought back life to the region, generating economic activity and bringing a sense of purpose and optimism to the local communities.

Given the charge that contemporary art is an elite enterprise which alienates the average man on the street, there is something refreshing in hearing an elderly local – possibly a farmer in an earlier part of his life – explain how one could interact with an artwork.

The islands also play host to a well-regarded contemporary arts festival, the Setouchi Triennale, which sees temporary site-specific artwork installed across the islandscape. First organised in 2010 and running for about eight months each time, the Triennale was last held last year.

With the support of the National Arts Council (NAC), Singapore's independent arts centre The Substation and artist Grace Tan took part in the 2013 edition of this visual arts festival. Grace Tan's work, titled *In The Stillness*, transformed a classroom in a defunct school on Shodoshima with a huge cloud-like sculpture made of two million polypropylene loop pins. (These are the plastic bits you see in a department store which attach price tags to apparel.)

Artist Grace Tan's work, *In The Stillness*, transformed a classroom in a defunct school on Shodoshima with a cloud-like sculpture made of two million polypropylene loop pins. Grace, who spent about three weeks in Japan, described how the work was constructed with the help of volunteers from Fukuda town, involving residents ranging from kindergarten and high school students to nursing home residents. They would spend time creating the sculpture bit by bit in the community centre or at other local sites, drinking tea and sharing local snacks.

Grace spoke of the warm ties that resulted from time spent together and how the completed work attracted Triennale visitors, who also got to enjoy the food specially prepared in the makeshift cafe within the defunct school. (Parallel to the art-making were workshops which taught local residents how to cook South-east Asian dishes, such as chicken rice and prawn noodles.)

- 40 For us to deepen the level of arts appreciation, there is the need for the arts to be relevant or accessible for first-timers, with the aim of helping them build a foundation of understanding and importantly, a love for the arts. This must be the only sustainable way to broaden the base of Singaporean audiences, readers and art collectors in the long term.

- 45 It is heartening that a Singapore artist like Grace can create work which resonates on so many levels, in both critical reception and social outcomes. It is a reminder of the power of good art. I suspect though, that in all likelihood, such broadly transformative arts projects are more the exceptions than the norm, across the globe.

Diversity in art

- 50 As the agency that champions the arts, NAC has to acknowledge that art in Singapore is created with different artistic intentions for diverse audiences. Singapore is a modern cosmopolitan country with a multi-ethnic, multi-religious heritage. This means we have artistic traditions that go back centuries as well as an open attitude towards external ideas. For sure, these circumstances create for a complex art-making and reception in a relatively young nation.

- 55 Borrowing the lingo from the marketing world, one could say that the potential consumer base for the arts in Singapore can be divided into discrete describable segments. Each segment has different attitudes and expectations of the arts, responds to different stimuli and thus, needs to be addressed differently, if NAC wants Singaporeans to embrace the arts.

- 60 Our most recent population survey in 2015 revealed that while eight in 10 Singaporeans attended an arts event, in reality, only four in 10 expressed an interest in the arts. It could mean, I remarked to colleagues in a moment of levity, that half the people who encountered the arts in 2015 – perhaps a free performance or exhibition in a public space – were dragged there reluctantly by family members, or had experienced the arts "accidentally" on a weekend errand run.

The statistics underline the fact that the appreciation of the arts is in its nascent state in Singapore. But when taken together with the upward trend of important indicators, it gives us in NAC some comfort. Things can only get better in the longer term.

- 65 This is especially so when we consider today's opportunities for arts exposure in our public schools. There is also increasing recognition that young people should chase their dreams and that there are many possible pathways to become a contributing member of society.

Art for all audiences and ages

- 70 For today's artists, there is little doubt that the base of interested audiences and arts appreciators (the four in 10 Singaporeans) is indeed a varied one. For every serious collector of conceptual art who visits international art fairs and enjoys in-depth discourse about art, there is someone who derives an uncomplicated aesthetic pleasure from a beautiful watercolour painting.

- 75 For every audience member who is willing to shell out top dollar for a hard-hitting stage drama on a difficult topic, there is someone who is happy to hear beautifully harmonised pop songs, reprised from her youth. For every reader of serious poetry and follower of the vibrant literary scene, there is a parent hunting for accessible children's stories for his mobile-device addicted child.

With this demographic diversity – which we at NAC are trying to understand better – as well as the variety of art forms practised here, NAC's support of the arts needs to be multi-dimensional. We will need to cater to audiences who are encountering the arts for the first time as much as we need to

champion artists who are presenting art which well-informed arts lovers expect of a global cultural city.

For us to deepen the level of arts appreciation, there is a need for the arts to be relevant or accessible for first-timers, with the aim of helping them build a foundation of understanding and importantly, a love for the arts. This must be the only sustainable way to broaden the base of Singaporean audiences, readers and art collectors in the long term.

Fortunately, there are many artists in Singapore like Grace who can develop work which can be accessed at different levels and who are interested to reach out to the community in the process of artistic creation. There are also many seasoned programmers, curators, and producers who know how to build bridges between the artwork and the audience, who know how to mediate that tricky space between artistic intention and critical reception. We can do more in this area, for sure.

Pushing boundaries and posing awkward questions

While we have said Singapore's arts scene is still relatively young, there is no denying that the last decade has seen a dynamic growth in the range and quality of cultural offerings.

There is a plethora of quality art which reflects our diverse communities, recognises our local contexts and poses thoughtful questions. We have, for instance, enjoyed theatre that uses humour to talk about integration of new immigrants, experienced installation art that expresses the hope of prisoners waiting for their day of release, and read poetry that mourns the loss of local landmarks and captures a forgotten way of life. This vibrant scene has not gone unnoticed internationally, with both international tourists and expatriates appreciating the sea change.

At the same time, there is a need to remember that art is not about the lowest common denominator. We cannot assess the merit of the arts based on the numbers of audiences, or exhibition attendees, or book sales. If we did, we would not support poetry, vernacular theatre, experimental performance art, or contemporary dance. Niche, we should not be shy to declare, is not a bad word in itself.

Of course, some Singaporeans will like their art immediate, not taxing or overly cerebral. They just want a good evening out after a demanding work day, or a stress-free excursion during the weekend with the children in tow. We have to respect that art serves that role too, and NAC must strongly support such endeavours.

In the same breath, it also needs to be said that we must also continue to support artwork that challenge boundaries or pose awkward questions. We should not be afraid. If a play pokes fun at us as Singaporeans, may we have the grace to laugh it off, recognise our foibles and think about the merit of the critique. If a piece of music sounds strange at the first listening, or a novel seems too difficult in the first few pages, may we have the patience to persist a little longer and give the artist that consideration. If we do not like any work in the end, may we have the generosity not to generalise all home-grown artwork.

Such works do reflect the polyphony of artistic voices in Singapore, even if at an individual level, we may not take a shine to some of these works. More often than not, they are unique to our island and collectively express perspectives on life here, ultimately adding to and enriching our growing national canon. Singapore would be poorer if we did not support such art forms.

Art in making a country home

120 My wish for the next few years is to see more arts in the heartland and for artists to keep creating works which have universal appeal but are yet locally anchored and to showcase more works that welcome multiple responses.

Critically, I hope to see more Singaporeans who understand that art, in all its forms and voices, is relevant to their lives, their sense of self and their well-being. When that happens, there would be greater recognition of the role of the artist in society, including a ready willingness to support the arts as patrons, collectors, ticket-buyers and volunteers.

125 With the present uncertainty in global geopolitics and gloomy talk of protracted slow growth, there should also be a recognition, however unquantifiable it may seem, that an appreciation of and participation in the arts too have a part to play in the future economy of this island.

130 The creative mind does not belong only to the artist. An engaged arts lover will have the intellectual curiosity and nimbleness of a creative disposition: An individual who can imagine broader horizons and may be better able to respond to challenges created by the "disruptions" that we see in the market today.

In this age of global connectivity and unprecedented movement of peoples, some have responded to the accompanying anxieties by looking inward or raising barriers. Singapore, as a port city and trading hub that has prospered by being open to ideas and people, cannot afford to do that.

135 While we must be careful of placing too much emphasis on the instrumental role of the arts, the truth is that the artwork being created in Singapore are uniquely placed to speak to our citizens and residents. They can capture, channel and reimagine the lives of residents in a way that an imported Broadway musical or a work by an international writer cannot.

140 The understanding and connections forged by such art can indeed be a bulwark against the vicissitudes of uncertain times or the anxieties of a borderless cyber world. What art can do is to root the young Singaporean who is still finding his or her voice and provide a link, through the imagination, to his or her forebears and a physical landscape that has been lost. It can also create a sense of empathy for the people we encounter in our midst – from the unhappy domestic worker to the newly retrenched office manager or the child from a new immigrant family.

145 At the end of the day, what makes a country home? The answer must lie beyond physical trappings, gleaming buildings and state-of-the-art infrastructure. The bedrock of that home must be in its social fabric – its people, the relationships they have with each other and the experiences they build in the common spaces they share. The arts and culture form a vital part of this fabric and there is so much potential yet unlocked.

150 On the one hand, Singaporeans can remember the lump in the throat when an entire stadium sings in unison to Cultural Medallion recipient Dick Lee's song *Home*. But what else is out there? What artwork can articulate what we know, remember and treasure about our world; capture the struggles and milestones of a young nation; and ultimately, help us see ourselves and the world beyond? What new visions of the future can inspire us?

155 If we want a glimpse of the answers, we should all support our artists as they imagine those possibilities and together celebrate the works they create.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. The author notes that “there is no denying that the last decade has seen a dynamic growth in the range and quality of cultural offerings” (lines 90-91). If this view is applied to cultural offerings in the current decade, what might be some reasons contributing to such a trend in the local arts scene?
2. The author briefly explores the idea that we should “continue to support artwork that challenge boundaries or pose awkward questions” (lines 106-107). What are some examples of these works of art, and what could be some possible implications of supporting such works in Singapore society?
3. The author believes that “the artwork being created in Singapore are uniquely placed to speak to our citizens and residents” (lines 136-137). What would be some examples of such works and in what ways do they especially speak to us in ways that foreign art cannot or does not?

Related essay questions:

1. Examine the role of music in establishing a national identity in your society. (Cambridge 2017)
2. ‘There is a decline in the appreciation of traditional art forms today.’ How far is this true in your society? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
1. To what extent do the Arts contribute to the Singaporean identity? (RI 2023 Y6 Prelims)
2. There needs to be more emphasis on the arts in the school curriculum than the sciences.’ How far do you agree? (RI 2023 Y6 Common Test)
3. Does your country do enough to develop the Arts? (RI 2022 Y5 Promo)
4. ‘The Arts have no place in a society that values practicality.’ What is your view? (RI 2020 Y5 Timed Practice)
5. Consider the consequences if all art museums and art galleries in your country were closed down. (RI 2017 Y6 CT1)
6. ‘The progress of a society is sustained by the sciences rather than the arts.’ How far do you agree with this statement? (RI 2016 Y6 Prelim)
7. To what extent can the literary or performing arts be a vehicle for change? (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim)

Related case studies:

- 1)  [**Mural Arts Philadelphia: Public Art as a Conduit for Urban Transformation, Political Mobilization, and Community Building \(USA, 2023, Harvard Political Review\)**](#): *Mural Arts Philadelphia transforms city walls into a living “outdoor gallery,” with over 4,000 murals to date. For example, **Legacy** is a bold street-mural that raises awareness about the fight for Black freedom. Through projects like these, urban space gives communities a voice, injecting beauty, and offering hope through public art.*
- 2)  [**The transformation of Medellín’s Comuna 13 \(Columbia, 2020, Medium\)**](#): *Comuna 13 in Medellín transformed from a violent gang-controlled warzone into a global urban-art hotspot. After Operation Orion reduced crime, residents used murals, hip-hop, and escalators (yes, escalators!) to rebuild community pride. Today it’s a vibrant tourist magnet celebrating resilience and creativity.*
- 3)  [**https://knowledgehub.clc.gov.sg/liveability-in-action/opinion--arts-and-heritage---the-soul-of-a-city-with-a-nation-s-heartbeat/**](https://knowledgehub.clc.gov.sg/liveability-in-action/opinion--arts-and-heritage---the-soul-of-a-city-with-a-nation-s-heartbeat/) (Singapore, 2025, Centre for Liveable Cities Singapore): *Explores the relationship between arts and liveability, and presents it from the perspective of what the government can do/has done.*

SECTION B: INVESTING IN THE ARTS

Reading 5: Singapore Cultural Statistics 2025



https://www.nac.gov.sg/docs/default-source/about-us-files/singapore-cultural-statistics-2025.pdf?sfvrsn=55c16a35_1

Reading 6: Art education holds some lessons on the way we teach

EUs 5 & 9

Ye Shufang | TODAY | 19 July 2019

This article will help you to understand:

- How art education can spark richer dialogue and discussion in the classroom
- What benefits art education can have beyond the classroom
- How museums can play a key role in supporting art education

I am always struck by how students who study together cooperate to create a learning environment that suits them well. A handphone is playing music, another two are used to search for information online while a fourth phone is for sending text messages to other study groups to share the information learnt and help one another complete the assignment.

- 5 As a parent and educator, I often wonder how they concentrate and retain their learning with such “distractions” around them. Children and students are quick to make use of the latest technologies for learning. They create and share content, comment on other shared content, enhance and share their own content again, sometimes in a span of just a few minutes.

- 10 A decade ago, in response to how technology will change the way we learn and teach, researchers like Clayton Christensen, Thomas Arnett and Ron Ritchhart challenged educators to rethink their roles as knowledge or subject experts. They suggested that educators should start thinking of themselves as facilitators of good discussions.

- 15 With this in mind, how can parents and educators better facilitate learning and help transform information into knowledge and well-deliberated thinking? How do we encourage, guide and enable good discussions, while relying less on model answers?

The benefits of art education

- 20 This is where art education comes in. Art education provides many different entry points to kickstart good discussions. Artists communicate their thoughts on personal, historical and current issues differently from historians, journalists and writers. When looking at and discussing art, each of us, children included, can contribute differently to the interpretation and discussion of an artwork with our diverse backgrounds and cultures.

- 25 Art inquiry requires us to analyse and deliberate on the meaning of the visual imagery we encounter, as well as to consider the concepts and perspectives expressed by the artist. At the same time, we also study the social, cultural and historical contexts of the artwork when it was first created, against the current landscape to deepen our understanding of it. Through this process of inquiry, our children develop visual literacy, analytical skills and critical thinking. This strong connection between art inquiry and critical thinking has been studied and is well documented in many educative research projects like ‘Artful Thinking’, ‘Project MUSE’ and ‘The Studio Thinking Project’ by the Harvard Graduate School of Education.

Developing art education in Singapore

30 At the National Gallery Singapore, education is learner-centred with the long-term goal of developing self-motivated independent individuals. For instance, young children get many opportunities for self-guided imaginative play and art-making to nurture curiosity and imagination.

35 A close collaborative relationship with the Ministry of Education has enabled the gallery to co-develop a museum-based learning programme for primary school children, with the aim of developing knowledge, visual inquiry and appreciation of Singapore art and artists. On a gallery tour, students are guided to look at art, ask questions, and share their interpretations and responses with one another. A gallery education facilitator may start with a question such as: "What is the first thing you noticed about this artwork?" or "Imagine you were one of the figures in this painting, what would you hear?" Such open-ended questions encourage students to respond in a personal and imaginative manner, while reducing the expectation of a right or model answer.

40 The facilitators then continue to build on the students' thinking by asking more in-depth questions such as: "What do you think inspired and compelled the artist to create this work?" or "If you were the artist, how would you title the work differently and why?"

45 Given the space and time to share their responses, the children feel affirmed that their opinions matter and their voices are heard. As a result, they feel motivated and empowered to ask questions too. Some questions that children have asked at the gallery include: "Why don't artists smile in their self-portraits?" and "What happens to the art after a long time?" Their questions show us that children are observant, capable of making connections between the past and their present, and thinking beyond the subject at hand.

Art education and the "learner-centred approach"

50 The learner-centred approach acknowledges the learner's voice as being central to the learning experience. This approach has been adopted by many museums and education institutions. For example, the Children's Book Museum at The Hague — a fellow shortlisted institution for the Children in Museums Award 2018 — enables children to experience the power of stories and learn to make connections to their own lives and the world around them. Designed to include children as young as babies and toddlers, the experiences aim to develop language, creative expression, and motor skill development among the visitors as they listen, read, imagine and write stories freely.

60 The Young Museum in Frankfurt similarly encourages young visitors to explore the artefacts with their parents as they go on designed family trails where they experience collaborative, hands-on activities, without model answers to them. In 2018, Grand Rapids Public Museum High School in Michigan welcomed its first cohort of high school students who learn and study inside a museum in close proximity to artefacts and exhibits.

The innovative curriculum fosters a culture of co-learning where students learn collaboratively together in small groups under the guidance of teachers. In the process, students take on roles that involve acquiring, researching, cataloguing artefacts and curating exhibits.

65 As today's parents and educators, we do not necessarily need to establish ourselves as the content or knowledge experts to help our children and students learn. Instead, we can co-learn and search for the answers together with them.

70 We can engage in thoughtful discussions and debate our opinions with an open mind. We can also facilitate good discussions as we acknowledge their responses and accept differences in opinions. In this way, we aspire for, and look forward to, our children and students showing us new ways of interpreting and understanding the subject at hand, including art.

More importantly, while these unique viewpoints and different perspectives may not be similar to ours, this learner-centred, model-answer-free environment will help us nurture self-motivated independent learners ready for the future.

Ye Shufang is Deputy Director, Education at National Gallery Singapore.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. In light of Ye's question concerning how children cope with ' "distractions" around them' (line 6), why does she then make reference to them "mak[ing] use of the latest technologies for learning" in lines 6-7?
2. Ye also identifies some benefits of art education in lines 16-28: (a) Which have you encountered in your personal and schooling experience? (b) Which of these benefits do you think Singapore's education system needs most urgently today, and why?
3. "Art inquiry" (line 21) is presented as providing the means for children to enhance "analytical skills and critical thinking" (line 25). How an arts education manages to achieve this is explained in lines 21-24: (a) Do you believe this ability is unique to arts education? Why or why not? (b) If not through an arts education, how else might the analytical and critical thinking skills of the next generation of students be enhanced?

Related essay questions:

1. 'An appreciation of music is vital for a fully rounded education.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
2. 'For the majority of people, the Arts are irrelevant to their daily lives.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2014)
3. 'Unlike the Arts, such as writing or music, Mathematics lacks the capacity for creativity.' How far do you agree with this statement? (Cambridge 2014)
4. 'There needs to be more emphasis on the arts in the school curriculum than the sciences.' How far do you agree? (RI 2023 Y6 Common Test)
5. How far do you agree with the view that the literary arts are about personal enjoyment rather than practical benefits? (RI 2020 Y6 Term 3 Common Essay Assignment)
6. To what extent has technology had a negative impact on the arts, such as music or photography? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
7. 'An education in sports or arts is still seen to be undesirable in your society today.' Do you agree? (RI 2017 Y5 Promo)
8. Consider the consequences if all art museums and art galleries in your country were closed down. (RI 2017 Y6 CT1)
9. 'The progress of a society is sustained by the sciences rather than the arts.' How far do you agree with this statement? (RI 2016 Y6 Prelim)

Further reading:

- [Art education key to developing an innovative mindset](#) (Ye Shufang, TODAY, 2017)
- [The Values of Arts Education](#) (American Academy of Arts & Sciences, Commission on the Arts, 2021): *This section argues that arts education is essential to human development, cultivating creativity, empathy, cultural understanding, and engagement, while strengthening schools and communities beyond narrow academic or economic outcomes.*

Related case study:

- 1)  [The Mind-Expanding Value of Arts Education](#) (USA, 2023, NYT): *Research in 42 Houston schools shows how arts education boost writing, empathy, engagement, and reduce behavioural issues. However, public-school arts funding has dropped significantly, reducing access to music, visual arts, and theatre. These cuts threaten not only creative development but also the broader social and academic benefits that arts education provides.*

SECTION B: INVESTING IN THE ARTS

Reading 7: The full measure of an arts education

EUs 1 & 5

Yuen Sin | *The Straits Times* | 1 June 2017

This article will help you to understand:

- Why there was debate and contention over the setting up of SOTA as a dedicated art school and the relative dearth of graduates who go on to pursue the arts
- SOTA's original mission and educational approach, which are not well understood
- Tensions around balancing academic and artistic priorities, staff departures, and persistent social stigma around arts careers
- Why focusing on the number of SOTA graduates pursuing arts-related university degrees alone can yield a misleading picture about the long-term benefits of SOTA

News last month that fewer than three in 10 School of the Arts (SOTA) graduating students go on to pursue arts-related university courses stirred debate, with some saying this was too low a figure and asking if taxpayers' dollars were well spent in funding such a school. Those remarks invited heartfelt responses from a handful of Sota alumni and their parents, who defended the school and its programme and detailed the tremendous benefits of an arts education.

SOTA is the only secondary school here with a dedicated arts programme. Singapore's other arts schools offer programmes at tertiary level. The other secondary schools that offer specialised programmes include the Singapore Sports School, the School of Science and Technology, Singapore and the NUS High School of Mathematics and Science. At NUS High, some seven in 10 students go on to science, technology, engineering and mathematics (Stem) courses in university.

But the SOTA-NUS High comparison may not be apt when one considers why SOTA was set up in the first place. When it was first mooted in 2004, the aim was not to set up a vocational school aimed solely at producing arts practitioners.

Instead, the committee that drew up the report on a School for the Arts back in 2004 said such a school would give students at the pre-tertiary level a strong foundation in the arts, and plug a gap in mainstream schools which lacked teaching resources and opportunities to expose students to an arts learning environment. SOTA students, the committee said, would be "better positioned to pursue higher education in the arts or arts-related fields, or apply their artistic and creative capabilities in other fields". That, in turn, would support Singapore's plans to develop its own artistic talents in its push to position itself as a "global city for the arts", and provide new opportunities for those with creative aspirations as society matures.

What numbers don't say

To secure a place in SOTA, Primary 6 pupils have to go through individual or group auditions in the art form they are interested in, whether music or dance. They may also have to prepare a portfolio of their artistic works, and are interviewed by the school's arts teachers. Once admitted, SOTA students embark on a six-year programme which culminates in an International Baccalaureate diploma. In the first two years, students are also exposed to art forms other than the one they are specialising in. They also study a full slate of academic subjects, including science and mathematics.

The arts are often integrated into the academic subjects and that allows students to approach what they are learning from multiple perspectives. So a music student may, for example, demonstrate

30 during physics class how the pitch of a violin is adjusted and how that corresponds to sound frequency. Dance students may apply the principles of cultural anthropology to carry out research on different dance cultures.

As the SOTA committee said in its 2004 report, an arts education can help students develop critical thought and creative expression, nurture self-development and leadership qualities, and also enrich
35 their study of other subjects.

Whether or not a SOTA student pursues a university degree in the arts is a poor indicator of the school's success. Some Sota alumni have moved into law or the humanities after graduation, but continue to contribute to the arts scene, with some starting arts education programmes and others founding literary magazines. Yet others apply their ability to think critically and independently in the
40 non-arts disciplines they have ventured into.

All this is consistent with the national push to encourage lifelong learning and with the SkillsFuture movement which emphasises that learning is a personal endeavour and that every person should be given the autonomy to decide when and how to apply the skills and knowledge they have acquired, and have the flexibility to switch from one industry to another depending on interest and market
45 demand.

The other thing to note is that SOTA is a very young school, having been founded in 2008, which means it is just approaching its 10th year. It may be premature to size up its impact on society at this stage. The proportion of students entering arts courses at university excludes students who left Sota before completing the six-year programme to pursue tertiary studies in the arts, at institutions like the
50 National University of Singapore's Yong Siew Toh Conservatory of Music or the Central School of Ballet in London, as well as those who return to work full-time in the arts sector after working professionally in another discipline.

Singapore Management University Associate Professor Margaret Chan says: "It should not be seen as a failure of SOTA that their graduates go on to non-arts courses." She studied business administration
55 at university before becoming an actress and earning a PhD in performance studies later. "Art is about meaning-making; it is understanding ourselves and society, reaching into ourselves and out to others," she adds.

Room for change

The recent debate has, however, served a useful purpose in surfacing questions about the teaching of the arts and how arts careers are perceived. That is partly due to reports that a sizeable number of
60 teachers have left SOTA of late, with some citing a disconnect between educators and management on how the arts should be taught. Mr Charles Tee, a parent of a SOTA alumnus, also wrote to The Straits Times Forum to register his unhappiness that SOTA seems to be chasing after academic excellence at the expense of artistic development.

The question of what balance to strike between arts education and a rigorous academic curriculum is
65 one that SOTA's management needs to address, SOTA teachers told The Straits Times. A related issue is the widespread perception among Singaporeans, including some parents of Sota students, that to pursue a career in the arts is to court unemployment and hardship.

Sota alumna Faye Tan, 21, who left SOTA after four years for the Rambert School of Ballet and Contemporary Dance in London, says young people are discouraged by pessimistic labels attached to
70 arts careers, such as "risky, difficult, poor and unappreciated". Now a full-time company artist and digital marketing manager at contemporary dance company Frontier Danceland, she says there is also

no need for SOTA alumni to limit themselves to pursuing the arts as a hobby just because they are not training full-time or extensively in the arts.

- 75 Theatre practitioner and Nominated Member of Parliament Kok Heng Leun believes there is no lack of career options in the arts. But society's perceptions of artists need to change, he says. "We need artists to be respected. A lot of people still see artists as just entertainers or, for some, trouble-makers because they tackle difficult issues. Artists need to be seen as being as important as scientists, economists and entrepreneurs," he says. It is also important that people respect artistic work, he adds, as that reflects their appreciation of the time and effort the artist has invested in art making.

Paths for different talents

- 80 At the official opening of SOTA in 2011, Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong said the school demonstrates how Singapore is opening up multiple paths to different talents, giving artistically-inclined students every opportunity to excel. He added that SOTA's mission is "not to produce a single peak of excellence, along which everybody is trying to climb, but a whole mountain range with many peaks".

- 85 "Each person then chooses his own area of interest or focus, areas where he wants to put in his passion and his effort, and to excel and do well. And ultimately, we want to have lots of people standing on top of all of the mountains." He had also forecast that many SOTA graduates would go on to professions not directly related to aesthetics, such as medicine or engineering, but maintained that an education in the arts is of value in itself. Addressing SOTA students, he said: "I hope whatever you do, your training in the arts will equip you with a more comprehensive perspective and way of thinking
- 90 and add an extra touch to the new profession which you will learn."

As Singapore's only dedicated arts school at the pre-tertiary level, SOTA is an important source of arts education. National Institute of Education don Jason Tan notes that the school also provides an avenue for pedagogical innovation. SOTA, he says, can develop creative models for imparting skills and content through the arts that other schools can consider adopting.

- 95 To pin the value of such a school to the percentage of students that go on to pursue arts degrees is reductionist. A better approach is to see where a SOTA education is working so as to draw out lessons for other educators and schools, and critique those aspects that are not working and in need of change. There will always be a place for the arts in society, and it is fitting that young people who are eager for an arts education have access to a secondary school that offers them just that.

For Discussion/Reflection:

- 1) In light of the original objectives of setting up SOTA, which was to provide its students "a strong foundation in the arts" (line 15) such that they would be "better positioned to pursue higher education in the arts or arts-related fields" (lines 17-18) and the finding that "fewer than three in 10 [SOTA] graduating students go on to pursue arts-related university courses" (lines 1-2), do you think Singapore should continue to fund a school with a dedicated focus on the arts? Why or why not?
- 2) The author compares the low number of SOTA graduates who "go on to pursue arts-related university courses" (lines 1-2) with the significantly higher number of NUS High graduates who opt for STEM courses in university. What might be some reasons for this discrepancy?
- 3) Associate Professor Margaret Chan is cited as saying that "[i]t should not be seen as a failure of SOTA that their graduates go on to non-arts courses" (lines 53-54). What might she be implying?
- 4) In the section "Room for change" (lines 58-79), several concerns emerge: teacher attrition, differing beliefs about how arts should be taught, and social stigma surrounding arts careers. How

do these issues reveal larger structural or cultural challenges in Singapore's arts education ecosystem?

- 5) Former PM Lee describes SOTA as contributing to a "mountain range with many peaks" (line 83) rather than a single path of excellence. Do you think Singapore's education landscape today truly reflects such diversity of pathways? Why or why not?

Related essay questions:

1. 'An appreciation of music is vital for a fully rounded education.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
2. 'There needs to be more emphasis on the arts in the school curriculum than the sciences.' How far do you agree? (RI 2023 Y6 Common Test)
3. 'A career in sports or the arts is still undesirable.' How far is this true of your society? (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
4. Is an arts education becoming irrelevant in your society? (RI 2016 Y5 CT)

Further reading:

- [Is arts education being de-emphasised in Singapore?](#) (Epoch Times, 2018)

Related case study:

- 1)  [Can Art Degree Programs Churn Out Real Artists?](#) (China, 2022, *The World of Chinese*): *Art education in China faces major challenges: oversubscribed programs, uneven teaching quality, and political censorship. Students often lack practical training (e.g., portfolio development, curating), while graduation work may be censored or renamed. Despite competitive entry, many graduates end up in unrelated jobs.*

SECTION B: INVESTING IN THE ARTS

Reading 8: “When a cultural landmark is at risk: What The Substation teaches us about arts and state in Singapore”

EUs 3, 5, 9

Eunice Lacaste / MOMUS | 21 December 2021 [adapted]

This reading will help you to consider:

- The tensions between state control & artistic independence
- The difficulties faced by Singapore’s arts practitioners in securing and maintaining physical arts spaces
- The frustrations faced by arts practitioners when state regulators make decisions without sufficient dialogue between the two parties
- The challenge a state faces when balancing: (i) cultural development and economic/urban planning priorities; (ii) supporting creative expression via the arts and protecting existing standards of public morality

The Substation, a leading arts centre in Singapore, announced its permanent closure in March after its thirty-year stint as an independent home for the arts. Triggered by the pandemic year, other arts spaces such as DECK (an art photography centre), Centre 42 (a theatre space), The Necessary Stage (another theatre centre), and Nanyang Technological University Centre for Contemporary Arts (NTU-CCA) also announced that they are losing their physical spaces. Meanwhile, the Singapore Art Museum (SAM) was closed for renovations. The arts community immediately voiced its disappointment, organising online discussions about the closures through video town hall meetings and social media threads. The issue became a community force, and eventually, the decision to close The Substation was overturned.

The rough circumstances of a global lockdown have made the sequential closing of art spaces seem even more erratic, and arts communities across Singapore have rallied to protect what they see as essential to civic welfare. It’s seldom that community-initiated discourses occur outside the city’s top-down programming by institutions, state councils, or authorities. Recent events surrounding the Substation both demonstrate the problems faced by art spaces in Singapore and the importance of interdisciplinary participation in shaping its cultural industry.

As its name suggests, The Substation building operated as a power substation until the 1920s to ‘70s. The Urban Redevelopment Authority (URA) launched conservation plans in the 1980s which protected built heritage in the central district. Around the same period, the Singapore government was interested in riding the Asian art wave and invested in the art workforce, hoping that doing so would encourage the culture industry to grow alongside Singapore’s manufacturing sector. The Substation was founded in 1990 and took over the restored building. It had been one of the longest-standing arts incubation spaces in Singapore that provided an independent stage for both emerging and established artists. The arts centre not only served as a stepping stone for art practitioners who went on to represent Singapore in international arts biennales and festivals, it was also a safe space for experimental artmaking and community building.

During its earlier days, artists known in the Asian circuit – such as the late performance artist Lee Wen – were among the familiar faces at the space. Lee spent eight hours a day in the gallery during his 1993 exhibition, performing rituals as the Yellow Man, with his body, exposed but for a pair of briefs, painted completely yellow. Photographer John Clang – whose 2007 White Book installation included a single book of photographs on a white table, inside a white cube lit with zig-zag fluorescent lights – credited his early roots to The Substation.

During this time, the institution's watershed infrastructure stimulated ideas for later state institutions such as SAM, which opened in 1996, and its Singapore Biennale, and the National Gallery of Singapore (NGS), which officially opened in 2015 after a decade of planning and renovations. Like The Substation, SAM and NGS both occupied restored buildings within the same district; SAM is housed in a Catholic church built in 1833 that was converted to St Joseph's Institution (STI boys' school) completed in 1867 while NGS is housed in restored colonial buildings formerly the city hall and supreme court which were constructed in the 1920s to 1930s.

Though its website stated that it was an independent home for the arts, The Substation had, in fact, been renting its state-owned heritage building at a subsidised rate since its inception. The arts centre was listed as a non-profit private company and registered as a charity. It also had been receiving major grants from the National Arts Council (NAC). In 2017, the NAC informed the arts centre that its building was scheduled for a renovation in 2021. In July 2020, newspapers reported that many important arts centres were losing their arts housing, including The Substation. After its renovation it will only be able to retain a third of its former space, and the rest will be rented out to other arts groups. NAC made this decision, citing financial instability.

Constraints arts spaces face in Singapore: Instability and inaccessibility

On the surface, this arrangement appeared ideal for arts practitioners in general, as other arts groups would be able to share studio spaces. However, members of the arts community had already witnessed what restructured arts centres could become under NAC's centralised purview. **To manage Singapore's land scarcity, civic plans such as the Arts Housing Scheme were launched by the NAC to align with the URA's strategies for effective land use. Old buildings in the central district were restored and renovated to maximise their hybrid potential as both commercial and heritage sites. Under this scheme, the arts groups that were displaced from the Stamford Art Centre (SAC) when it was renovated in 2017 could not return to their units because the rental fees had doubled in rates.** There were new contracts that stipulated the leases must be renewed every few months. This was not ideal for spaces that needed a stable studio to hold their rehearsals, stage their performances, store their bulky stage sets and props – or to set up heavy machinery and equipment for offset printing, ceramic firing, metal and wood processing, etcetera. It was also not ideal for the audience's sense of place.

Understanding the instability of art spaces in Singapore is crucial to realising their value. In 2020 alone, more than five arts centres had to surrender their arts housing, yet this was not a new problem. In 2012, the prolific curator Ute Meta Bauer was invited by the NAC and Nanyang Technological University (NTU) to establish the Centre for Contemporary Art (NTU-CCA). Singapore wanted to position itself as a global arts hub and Bauer became the channel for international artists like Joan Jonas to show there. However, on NTU-CCA had to leave its exhibition space in 2021 – well before it had a chance to develop its global audience. **The arts centre was based at Gillman Barracks, a state-owned army encampment converted to an arts compound just on the outskirts of the central district, and not the most accessible for visitors who mainly used public transport.** Many galleries had also left the compound in the last five years due to low sales and visitorship. NTU-CCA's closure was just one more example of a prevailing instability.

Compounding challenges: Regulation and censorship

Even in the 1990s, independent art spaces such as The Artist Village (TAV), 5th Passage, and Plastique Kinetic Worms found it hard to maintain their spaces for different reasons – sky-high rental rates and state to list a few. **Performance art was banned in Singapore for ten years after a 1994 show at 5th Passage where, protesting police entrapment of homosexuals (in a country that still criminalises same-sex activities), artist Josef Ng bared his posterior and trimmed his pubic hair while facing a wall. He was charged and fined by the Singapore police for indecency.**

Censorship and its compounding challenges have inspired arts institutions like DECK to move online. Others have been forced to continue their arts programs without a physical space after they had to shut down their original housing. Despite no longer having a 'village' or museum, however, institutions like TAV and the Post-Museum continue to participate in important arts events locally and overseas.

But after the announcement that Substation would shut down, the arts community was quick to voice their disappointment online. Members of the arts community created a Facebook group ("Substation Futures") to discuss the value of the arts centre. Effendy, a theatre practitioner, mourned "Farewell my home... I have loved you, but it will never be enough." Someone posted "the Substation has outlived its purpose," positing that as an incubation space, the quality of Substation's arts programs was outdated and substandard compared to larger and newer state institutions with heavier budgets such as the Esplanade and the Arts House.

But others challenged this opinion, like writer Li Shan Chan, who argued that **"the Substation symbolises independence of thinking and art-making in a society where censorship and losing state funding are real fears."** This online community was populated by the young and old, by enthusiastic practitioners and outsiders, alike, and coming from different professions. They all voiced their concern.

Community resistance brings a reprieve

In March 2021, an open letter addressed to the NAC and signed by more than 500 arts practitioners was published in the local newspapers. The NAC asked them not to publish the letter, but the authors were uncompromising. This statement from the arts community challenged the NAC's own statement, which claimed that the Substation was mismanaged and financially unstable. Unlike bigger institutions like SAM, NGS, NTU-CCA, and Esplanade, which have the financial capacity to host blockbuster mega-exhibitions with international artists such as Yayoi Kusama, The Substation was focused on local incubation.

As the spring and summer wore on, more people made their grievances over the loss of The Substation heard. Artist Akai Chew created an Instagram handle, "Here, 45 Armenian Street," posting memories submitted by different individuals. The many independent efforts like this confirmed that local arts communities see the merit in having alternative spaces that hold holistic criticality even if they contradict the NAC's one-dimensional ideals. **In late September, after many months of silence from the NAC and The Substation, its board announced that a new director, the artist and educator Ezzam Rahman, would helm the arts centre through its spatial limbo.**

Though The Substation's future is still uncertain, this episode demonstrates that members of the public do have their own collective authority over the survival of their cultural institutions. The lack of elbow room was made tighter by the pandemic and the ensuing government decisions in a small nation-state such as Singapore. But the pandemic also underscored how isolated communities can preside over their own placemaking.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. With reference to paragraphs 3 (lines 16-25), why was the announcement of the Substation's permanent closure met with such strong community opposition? (Use your own words as far as possible.)
2. Drawing from paragraphs 3-5 (lines 16-46), answer the following questions:
3. What were some specific ways in which the state contributed to the development of Singapore's arts scene in earlier years?
4. The article sums up the Singapore government's motivations for doing the above as based in its "[interest] in riding the Asian art wave" (line 19). What might this mean?
5. How does the arts housing situation, as described in paragraphs 5-7, reveal tensions between the arts community and the state?

6. The article mentions an incident of arts regulation (lines 75-77). Explain some of the concerns that likely guided the authorities' decision. To what extent do you consider the decision justifiable?
7. Chan describes Singapore as a society where "censorship and losing state funding are real fears" (lines 90-91) for arts practitioners. How far do you agree? Justify your response.
8. With reference to the final two paragraphs of the article (lines 101-112), what does the author suggest is the main reason why the Substation's closure was reversed? What implications might this have on other controversial decisions regarding the arts in Singapore?

Related essay questions:

1. Consider the argument that there should be no censorship of the arts in modern society. (Cambridge 2023)
2. 'Censorship of the arts is necessary to maintain social cohesion.' To what extent is this view still relevant in your society? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
3. Does your country do enough to develop the Arts? (RI 2022 Y5 Promo)
4. 'Now more than ever, the arts should be subject to government censorship.' Comment. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)

Related case study (UK):

- I. The struggles many arts groups and practitioners experience are often linked to their reliance on state funding, which can be dependent on shifting political priorities. However, it is worthwhile to note that funding woes do not necessarily spell doom for the arts if they adapt:
 [**The funding squeeze: How stretched budgets are driving digital innovation \(UK, 2025, Arts Professional\):** Governmental funding pressures have led local city councils and arts institutions to adapt, including moving from costlier online ticketing systems to more affordable but sustainable alternatives and combining operational resources across arts & cultural institutions.](#)

SECTION B: INVESTING IN THE ARTS

Reading 9: Strengthening Singapore's unique identity through arts and heritage

EUs 6, 8, 9

Edwin Tong | Speech at MCCY Ministerial Townhall on Arts and Heritage Initiatives | 21 February 2025

This reading will help you to:

- Understand the government's perspective on the role of arts, culture, and heritage in shaping Singapore's national identity
- Recognise the government's key priorities for strengthening the arts and heritage sector

115 Good afternoon to all of you. I want to start by thanking all of you for making time to be with us today – many industry experts, our friends from the arts, culture, and heritage sectors, practitioners, leaders.

Over the last few months, I've met many of you, in different groups. We exchanged frank views, and we shared our perspectives on what it would take for us to move forward. I was very grateful for the suggestions and constructive comments that you've given us. And it has helped shape our thinking
120 about what next steps we want to put in place as we move our arts and heritage ecosystem further forward.

At Budget earlier this week on Tuesday, there were two big moves on the arts: PM announced that we will be introducing the SG Culture Pass, and will be topping up the Cultural Matching Fund (CMF) with another S\$100M.

125 This afternoon, I will share more details on the SG Culture Pass – what exactly is the SG Culture Pass; what will it cover; why introduce the SG Culture Pass; and share some other details.

Arts heritage and landscape

But I thought before I do that, let me first start with a few broader observations on our arts and heritage landscape, and also outline for you a few of our immediate initiatives.

130 Over the last 60 years, we have built up a very strong national identity, one which reflects our cultural and religious diversity.

We are proud to call ourselves Singaporeans, and we celebrate our special, very uniquely Singaporean culture. As a still young country, our identity will no doubt continue to evolve.

135 And our arts, culture and heritage will lie at the centre and at the core of this evolving identity. They embody and express who we are. It shapes our common identity – how we project ourselves to the rest of the world, and how we want the rest of the world to see us.

And in all of this, the arts and heritage will be critical and essential to Singapore's continued development as a nation.

140 Today, we have a vibrant and diverse ecosystem of arts and heritage organisations and institutions delivering quality, distinctive, as well as innovative experiences.

With high quality, creative and dedicated practitioners, including many of you in this room. Personally, I think we have creatives who are as good as any anywhere else in the world.

A growing number of our artists have also gained international acclaim overseas:

- The Singapore Ballet was in Washington DC last June where they performed the works of Goh Choo San at the Kennedy Centre to international acclaim from a big audience.
 - The Singapore Symphony Orchestra was recently in Australia.
 - The Singapore Chinese Orchestra in China.
- 145

- Robert Zhao was at the Venice Biennale last year.
- We had designers at Milan Design Week.
- We have world class curators at the Tate Modern.
- Nathania Ong who has been wowing the audience on the West End and in Singapore and beyond.
- Andrew Gn, he works out of Paris, and is very well known internationally. He will be exhibiting in Boston later this year, the first retrospective of a Singapore designer overseas.

And we will work hard to give as many of our practitioners as possible an international platform for them to shine. For them to make the world know who Singaporeans are, where we come from, and what our arts, culture and heritage means to the world.

Our unique heritage has also been recognised internationally. The kebaya and hawker culture were inscribed on the UNESCO representative list of the intangible cultural heritage of humanity. All of this, and more – it is a testament to the depths of our talent and the high quality of arts and culture in Singapore.

How we got here

But we also know that successes did not come overnight – they were built on multi-faceted foundations laid over many years.

First, and most importantly, the sheer determination of each of our arts and heritage practitioners – pushing the envelope, developing and progressing their art form.

I remember very distinctly Meena Bhaskar, amongst others, sharing with me how they have persisted over the years. Despite challenges, despite uncertainties, to want to practise their art, hone their craft.

And for those involved in heritage, to actively protect and steward our treasured heritage and culture, so that it continues for many generations to come. These are all very important aspects of building a strong arts, culture and heritage ecosystem in Singapore.

I am very grateful to the many practitioners, like Meena and many of you here, who have persevered. You have been instrumental in shaping the arts, culture and heritage landscape in Singapore.

Second, over the years, the Government has endeavoured to partner with you in this growth. To support the development of our local arts and heritage sector with a good arts infrastructure and programme, developing as much talent as possible.

And perhaps also more importantly, retaining as much talent as possible.

We have also committed to greater spending, as our arts, culture and heritage flourished. Our per-capita spending on the arts and heritage has increased by four-fold between 2005 and 2023. These resources are spent strategically to lift the entire sector with a view to permanently shifting the baseline upwards.

Mapping out the road ahead

Let me quickly touch on some of the key areas that are on our immediate horizon.

First, we are taking steps to help our arts and cultural practitioners develop deep skills and talents and that's very important for us.

185 In the past years, we have built pathways for structured development of talent through the establishment of first, SOTA, and then more recently UAS. This is because we recognise the importance of having strong arts institutions that can nurture and develop our creative talents. To give them the skills, but perhaps more importantly, also give them opportunities to pursue their aspirations.

190 Therefore, we plan to expand the scholarships that we offer so that we can continue to meet the aspirations of a new generation of Singaporeans who are interested in a career in the arts, to give more people this opportunity to pursue the arts full-time, and help them realise their potential.

We will therefore provide more scholarship opportunities for pre-tertiary and diploma students enrolled in SOTA, in NAFA and in LASALLE, as well as boost funding for the NAC Arts Scholarships to support more undergraduates and graduates.

195 We will announce more details of this later this year.

Second, we will continue to build a strong value economy, around the arts. As I said, I want our arts talents to go into the creative economy, and stay in the creative economy.

200 Therefore, we are strengthening the on-the-job training and education by scaling up workplace-based training programmes, such as arts apprenticeships and train-and-attach programmes in the arts with a focus on in-demand and emerging jobs and skills. These workplace-based training opportunities will enhance the experience of our talents in acquiring relevant practical skillsets, and also attaining valuable work experience, not just academically, but being out there in practice, in the space, learning, honing their craft day-to-day.

205 Third, we have to recognise that technology is and will continue to be a great disruptor for the arts and heritage. But at the same time, it can also be a novel if not key enabler for all of us. It can open up new possibilities, allow us to present differently, and engage audiences differently.

Many of our artists, our practitioners, are very keen on new technologies. We will facilitate this by providing more learning opportunities, piloting projects, and providing resources to develop tech in the arts.

210 One example – in our latest Our SG Arts Plan, NAC launched Project Arts Metaverse, an Alliance-for-Action to partner and co-create new arts experiences in virtual spaces with our stakeholders.

Project Arts Metaverse will pilot projects for youth engagement as well as audience development in virtual spaces, and this can provide useful lessons not in this limited space but for the whole sector.

215 Fourth, we will have to be innovative, inventive and adaptive when it comes to developing spaces for the arts. We know as well as you do how important arts venues are. But land in Singapore is also limited. Whether it is in healthcare, sports, industry, or even housing – all these sectors face competing space constraints.

The arts and heritage sector is no exception. But let me assure you that we recognise the challenges that you face, and this is something that the Government is working actively on.

The continuing role of the government

220 We will, as the Government, continue to play the role of convenor and catalyst to help to unlock spaces to incubate the arts and heritage, including activating new spaces for experimentation such as at Kampong Java especially for emerging organisations and artists.

We also partner with our development agencies in the government such as URA, to find new spaces, amidst the old, for the arts. For example, through the Community / Sports Facilities Scheme, or CSFS, and the Strategic Development Incentive Scheme. These schemes bring together resources from the private sector and funding of the private sector, with the creative energy of the arts organisations to create high quality arts spaces in prime locations.

We are currently working on some possibilities, and will announce them when appropriate.

Finally, as part of Our SG Arts Plan (2023 – 2027), we have just initiated a comprehensive review and a research study on arts spaces needs for the future. The study will provide ideas on what new arts infrastructure is needed and how they should be developed.

We will take onboard your views and work with you on this. But we are prepared to look at this comprehensively and reimagine what we might need, how we might deploy them, and what we can do to open more arts venues for all of us.

Fifth, the Government will continue to support the arts and heritage with funding. And again, like venues, we know that funding is a key enabler. As I have explained, we have almost quadrupled our per capita spending on the arts over the last 2 decades. And so, we will not shy away from committing sufficient resources to strategically develop the arts in Singapore.

At this Budget, we also topped up the CMF. The CMF now stands at about S\$600M, which we have been disbursing over the years.

The CMF encourages support of the arts through philanthropy. In some ways what we do with the CMF is that we let the audience decide which arts company has got good governance, which has got strong donor relations, and which ones have good artistic offerings. They choose, and we match.

Sixth, we have not forgotten the heritage businesses, and we will be doing more to support them. Many of these businesses operate out of a deep passion and commitment to protecting and stewarding our history, our legacy and our heritage, and I think we all agree that this is important for many of us. We will only miss it when we lose it, so let's not lose it.

The work that they do preserves a key part of what makes Singapore special and unique. But we also appreciate that there are challenges. And so, we will do more to help all of you in this business sustain the business, continue to operate, grow, and develop.

MND and MCCY have worked on some measures to help heritage businesses, and later today, my colleague, Minister Desmond Lee, will announce some measures to better support heritage businesses, particularly those in our historic districts. He will be doing so at the Kampong Glam Ramadan Bazaar and will make some announcements on this. So please look out for them! I won't spoil the fun by telling you here what they are.

Developing our audience

Finally, let me speak about audience development, and why we have decided on the SG Culture Pass.

As I have outlined above, I believe we already have a good quality, vibrant, high value arts ecosystem in Singapore – one that represents us, is diverse, as multicultural and multiethnic as we are in Singapore, which speaks to us in different ways, appeals to us in different ways. And we are doing more to nurture our creative talents, and help them push the boundaries to perform, to exhibit, and to excel.

265 But I think also that every mature arts jurisdiction needs a good, stable base of support from its own local domestic audience. Nelson Chia, Artistic Director at Nine Years Theatre, encapsulated the challenge very well. He summarised the issue as one of value – how do we get Singaporeans to see the value of local arts and culture, and be interested to attend local arts and culture events. And I think he is right.

Beyond that, is also the question of interest – how do we spark and cultivate interest, and then sustain a deep passion and following for the arts, so as to inculcate a lifelong habit of attending the arts and heritage events from a young age.

270 We have been thinking about these questions for some time.

Over the years, we have put in place many structured programmes for primary and secondary school students, such as the Arts Education Programme and Artist-in-School Scheme.

We are now looking at taking these opportunities further upstream – we will put all Government-supported preschools onto the Arts Education Programme.

275 This will reinforce our efforts to build audience following from a young age – expose them early, give them an opportunity to try out, see for themselves. They might not know much at that age, but it will hopefully leave an impression. And hopefully years later, impression would turn into passion.

280 Together with the Ministry of Education, we have also introduced Museum-Based Learning and Performing Arts-Based Learning to schools. By 2027, we will aim to reach 100% of ECDA-supported preschools through the Arts Education Programme, and 100% of lower secondary cohort in MOE schools through Performing Arts-Based Learning.

Our aim in doing so is, as I have said, for young Singaporeans to appreciate and see the value of arts and heritage from an early age, and actively cultivate a habit to support our practitioners.

285 Last year, we also launched ArtsEverywhere@CDC to bring high quality performances by professional groups to our residents right in the heartlands. I attended some of the sessions, and it was good to see how Singaporeans came together quite casually at these events, in their own neighbourhoods, to take part, enjoy and bond over arts performances. I think arts is for everyone in every space.

290 With this in mind, we want to further expand the opportunities for Singaporeans to get to know their own local artists, from across a wider and broader spectrum of different art forms. We will therefore move beyond performing arts and bring more visual arts, such as murals, sculptures and installations, right into our public spaces where we live, work and play.

295 We will launch a new public art programme and bring even more public art and programmes into various locations around Singapore, including many familiar heartland neighbourhood locations. This way, we can build up the exposure of our local population to the breadth and quality of arts in Singapore, and at the same time integrate arts into their daily lives. You don't have to go out of your way to see the arts to appreciate it; it's part of where you live and work. We will provide more details on this plan when we are ready.

We are also stepping up cross-sector collaborations to bring arts and heritage into new areas.

300 One example – in recent years, there has been an increase in focus on the positive impact of arts and heritage on wellbeing and health. I think all of us in this room who are in this space know intuitively that there is a very strong and deep connection. This programme allows the arts to impact a broader audience. It will also allow us to impact audiences in tangible and therapeutic ways.

305 To further develop this area, NAC, in partnership with SingHealth Community Hospitals (SCH) and Agency for Integrated Care (AIC), will commence a research study on the impact of arts programmes for wellbeing. NHB is also working with partners such as Duke-NUS and Alexandra Health to study and promote well-being through heritage programmes and institutions like the museums.

310 These measures help us to inculcate a stronger interest in the arts amongst a greater number in our population. This is also one of the ways we can break down the silos that might exist between the different genres and domains, be a part of the growth of the wider economy and develop new audiences.

SG Culture Pass

So, we've done quite a bit to promote audiences, grow audience participation, cut across different domains. But even with all this, I think we can do more – and the SG Culture Pass is designed to give audience participation a bigger push.

First, let me explain why we have decided to introduce the SG Culture Pass.

315 For starters, we want to encourage more Singaporeans to attend our local arts, culture and heritage programmes. They can gain exposure to different genres of artforms, of their own choice and that's important. They decide how they spend their resources. This, in turn, lower the barriers to accessibility. And in turn, we hope it catalyses an interest; develop, in as many Singaporeans as possible, a lifelong interest in the arts and heritage, whilst at the same time, strengthening support for all of us here –
320 our local practitioners in the arts, culture, and heritage space. That, ultimately, is the *raison d'être* behind the SG Culture Pass.

And I believe the SG Culture Pass will be a significant driver that will bring us closer to this ambition.

Let me reiterate some of the details. In September 2025, all Singapore Citizens aged 18 years and above as of 2025 will receive S\$100 in credits. This will be applied to offset the purchase of tickets to
325 local arts and heritage offerings, and the credits will be available for use and valid until December 2028. These credits can be used on a variety of local programmes, including performances, exhibitions, immersive experiences such as learning tours as well as participatory workshops.

330 There will be three defining features of this SG Culture Pass. First, the SG Culture Pass will be a population-wide programme for all Singapore Citizens aged 18 and above. The credits can be used on a variety of programmes that will cater to different demographics and different interests. Through this programme, approximately S\$300M will be made available to Singaporeans to choose the programmes they wish to enjoy, over the next 3 years.

335 Second, the SG Culture Pass will be used exclusively for local arts and heritage programmes. Local arts and heritage programmes simply mean those that are primarily conceptualised, created, produced and presented by locals. This is really the heart of the programme, the *raison d'être* of the programme. We want a local audience to support our local practitioners. That's how we've scoped the policy design of this programme. We want to encourage not just attendance, but interest and a strong affinity in our local arts and heritage practitioners.

340 Finally, the SG Culture Pass will focus on in-person experiences, such as performances, exhibitions and workshops across the arts and heritage sectors. These activities create opportunities for Singaporeans of all demographics to come together, to build a community in person, around the love for the arts and an appreciation for their heritage.

We will make it easily accessible, where eligible offerings will be pulled together on a single website to make it easy for Singaporeans to browse and select the programmes to attend. We've had some

345 feedback in our sessions, about how it's not quite easy to identify local programmes, where do we find them; now that we have the SG Culture Pass, how do we know which ones we can use the SG Culture Pass for.

We have taken all this on board, so we'll be developing a site where all of the information will be consolidated. You will be able to see all the offerings that will be at hand, and you can then use the
350 same site to access ticketing as well as apply your SG Culture Pass. This will help to also publicise local programmes.

We will be introducing eligible offerings progressively, over time. We are currently finalising the details and will share the guidelines for the programmes' eligibility criteria and other details shortly. We expect that by March, we will open up the application process for programmes.

355 Overall, this SG Culture Pass will make local arts and heritage more accessible to more Singaporeans. That's the intent. For those who have never been to a cultural event, performance or exhibition, this now becomes an opportunity to be introduced to our rich offerings. And, who knows, after the first taste, some will come back for more.

And with enough Singaporeans getting a positive experience from what they see, we hope to build
360 and over time maintain a keen interest in our local arts and heritage.

This is also an opportunity for our own local arts and heritage practitioners to compete for and find ways to reach new audiences, especially to reach out to those who have not engaged with local arts and heritage before – newcomers; to think about how you can appeal to these new audiences.

We will have, as I said, about \$300M in SG Culture Pass value over the next 3 years. So, I encourage
365 all of you: take up this challenge. Put up compelling offerings to attract new audiences. Find different ways of using the SG Culture Pass to attract, reach out and to retain new audiences.

This programme, as I said, will run for 3 years. This will give practitioners enough time to plan and organise the offerings to take advantage of the SG Culture Pass. It applies to the arts, it applies to heritage, but there's no reason why it can't apply to a collaboration between the arts and heritage as
370 well. So, think out of the box, be different, and think collaboratively as well.

At the same time, I want to stress that the significance of the SG Culture Pass goes beyond the dollar value alone. I see it as a catalyst that can help shift mindsets towards favouring local arts and culture offerings, allowing us to appreciate local content more, and don't always have to say we will pay well for foreign content but not so well for local content. We want to break this mould and change this
375 mindset.

And it also allows us to more deeply, and maybe over time also emotionally, connect with the Singaporean cultural practitioners – all of you. I think this can be a big driver of change, as we look at taking our entire arts and heritage industry to new heights.

Before I conclude, I want to acknowledge the various contributors who gave us ideas, and some who
380 talked to us for some time about the concept of an SG Culture Pass. Mr Terence Ho, when he was NMP, made his first maiden speech on the Culture Pass. And we used many of the ideas from Mr Ho's speech. Many others had ideas which were similar in concept.

We took onboard these suggestions, studied them carefully; we refined them, we thought about how they should be designed – as I said, what's the *raison d'être* behind it; we thought about how it would
385 be best implemented, how to scope it, and then we announced it at Budget a few days ago.

The SG Culture Pass is really a culmination of all of these engagements, all of these ideas, and many of these efforts, which have been very constructive.

390 And this illustrates that there is really much that we can do when we come together, come forward, be constructive, be open, be frank, and have a constructive dialogue between the various segments in the arts and heritage space. I have certainly benefited from many of these sessions. And I think I hold up the SG Culture Pass as one example of the fruits of all that labour and constructive dialogue.

I am grateful to all who have contributed, and my colleagues and I look forward to working further with all of you, to take further steps to uplift arts and culture and heritage in Singapore.

395 When I met some of you in our sessions over the last few months, I either started or I ended the session by asking you to think about what Singapore should do, and where Singapore arts should be, in 15, 20, 30 or 50 years.

400 I know we have an arts plan every five years, just like we do for many other plans. But sometimes we need to ask ourselves: What is that moonshot? What is that ambitious, almost unimaginable step that we should take? And what do we do now in order to get there, in 15, 20 or 30 years? How do we think big? Aim for the moon, and maybe we can fall on the stars?

We don't have all the answers – yet. We will get there.

But I think this experience has shown us that if we can come together, we work with one another. We support one another. We collaborate between different art forms, different companies, different genres, and think out of the box. And be prepared to embrace the unknown and try.

405 I am quite sure that the best years of Singapore's arts and heritage and culture will lie ahead of us with all of our collaboration.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Minister Edwin Tong states that arts and heritage “lie at the centre and at the core” (line 20) of the evolving national identity. Identify some ways arts and heritage have shaped Singapore’s cultural identity.
2. The speech implies that the arts in Singapore still struggles with “a good, stable base of support from its own local domestic audience” (lines 148-149). What are some reasons for this lack of audience support?
3. The minister believes that “the SG Culture Pass will be a significant driver” (line 208) that will encourage more Singaporeans to support the arts. How far do you agree with his perspective?
4. On a whole what assumptions does this speech make about Singapore society’s relationship with the arts? How far do you agree with these assumptions?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. ‘The arts are nothing more than a luxury.’ How far is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2021)
2. To what extent should the arts in your society focus on local rather than foreign talent? (Cambridge 2015)
3. ‘For the majority of people, the Arts are irrelevant to their daily lives.’ How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2014)
4. ‘The arts should not rely on government support.’ Comment. (RI 2024 Y6 Prelim)
5. To what extent do the Arts contribute to the Singaporean identity? (RI 2023 Y6 Prelims)
6. Does your country do enough to develop the Arts? (RI 2022 Y5 Promo)
7. ‘Support for the arts should come mainly from the government.’ Discuss. (RI 2020 Y6 Timed Practice)

Related case studies:

- 1)  [**From K-Policy to K-Brand: Making a content powerhouse**](#) (South Korea, 2025, Canada Media Fund): *This article explains how the South Korean government views K-content as a national industry and key economic driver. It highlights policy tools such as funding, tax credits, and the establishment of foreign business centres as ways the government supports the arts industry.*
- 2)  [**Sweeping cuts hit NEA after Trump administration calls to eliminate the agency**](#) (USA, 2025, NPR): *This article reports that the National Endowment for the Arts (NEA) cancelled hundreds of grants after the Trump administration called for the agency's elimination. It highlights how the cuts disrupt local arts programmes, threaten jobs, and raise concerns about the future of federal cultural funding.*

SECTION C: REGULATING THE ARTS

Reading 10: Should we censor art?

EUs 3 & 10

Daisy Dixon | AEON | 27 May 2021 [adapted]

This reading will help you to consider:

- How some artworks can assert meanings and ideologies beyond the artist's intentions
- The value of art in society and how such interpretations of its value can be contested and challenged by different stakeholders
- The problems surrounding censorship of art

In 1970, Allen Jones exhibited *Hatstand, Table, and Chair*: three sculptures of women wearing fetish clothing, posed as pieces of furniture. The sculptures were met with protests and stink-bomb attacks, particularly from feminists, who argued that the works objectified women. Despite the artist's intentions for this piece – he has since identified as a feminist – the installation became part of an artistic narrative that has, historically, reduced women to passive objects in painting and sculpture.

In 2014, Brett Bailey's *Exhibit B* (2012) was shut down at the Barbican in London after protests caused 'security concerns'. The installation, based on 19th- and early 20th-century 'human zoos', showed Black people on display, chained and restrained. Even though the artist – a white South African man – intended the work to expose historic racist and imperialist violence, protesters implored the gallery to censor it: 'Caged Black People Is Not Art' read one banner.

And in 2019, an exhibition of Gauguin's portraits opened at the National Gallery in London with a public debate to address ethical concerns about the artist and his work. Paul Gauguin was a sexual predator, and when in the South Pacific – where he created some of his best-known paintings – he used his colonial and patriarchal privilege to sexually abuse girls as young as 13, knowingly infecting them with syphilis. Indeed, many of us struggle to reconcile an artist's appalling behaviour with their art: Pablo Picasso was, like Gauguin, a sexual predator, and a misogynist; Leni Riefenstahl was a Nazi and exploited Romani people in her filmmaking; and the sculptor Eric Gill was a paedophile. Often, we can sense the artist's moral character in their works: Picasso's views about women, for example, can be detected in many of his late portraits due to his manner of depiction.

These cases, among many more, show that, far from being innocuous objects hidden away in museums and white cubes, **artworks are historically informed objects that do things and say things**. Artworks are created by people in particular times, responding to specific events and ideals. There is more to a painting or sculpture than its aesthetic forms of colour, line and shape. External properties, such as the artist's identity and relevant events during the work's creation, must be considered to fully understand the work. Just how much the artist's intentions for their art determine that artwork's meaning is a deep question – one that I can't answer here. But, in general, most philosophers agree that an artwork can admit of many interpretations, and its meaning often diverges from what the artist intended. Crucially, **artworks are communicative objects, the messages of which are partly determined by the surrounding context and are sometimes different to what the artist had in mind**.

Relatedly, it's been argued that artworks – particularly pictorial ones – can be the equivalent of 'speech acts' – that is, they can be used to do things, such as protest or endorse something. Picasso's *Guernica* (1937), which depicts the Luftwaffe air raid that destroyed the town in the Spanish Civil War, has been described as a desolate 'protest-painting' and a 'powerful antiwar statement'. Such actions – protesting, stating – are things we normally do with words. When we speak, we don't merely express meanings; our words also have what J L Austin in 1955 called 'illocutionary force'. When an officer shouts to her troops: 'Open fire!', she's ordering them to shoot. But for an utterance to have a particular force, it needs to satisfy certain conditions. To order her troops to fire, the officer must have

authority, and she must use words her troops can understand. While Austin was mainly concerned with linguistic speech acts, he noted how they can also be nonverbally performed: consider silent protests or greeting another person by smiling. Such gestures must still be understood and recognised – this is what Austin called ‘conventional’. There are conventional gestures within artmaking and curatorial display, too. Recognisable methods of depiction with particular use of perspective and light, visual metaphors, iconographic symbols and curatorial conventions governing display will facilitate a work’s performance of speech acts. If artworks can be speech acts or, at least, can express meanings with certain forces such as assertion and protest (a claim that requires further defence than I can give here), then presumably they can be harmful acts too.

In parallel to this are the statues of slave traders and white supremacists. These public memorials don’t just represent a particular person – they literally put them on a pedestal. Through various aesthetic conventions, statues commemorate and glamorise the person and their actions and, in doing this, they rank people of colour as inferior, legitimising racial hatred. As the mayor of London Sadiq Khan said after a monument to the 17th-century slave trader Edward Colston was torn down in Bristol in June 2020: ‘Imagine what it’s like as a Black person to walk past a statue of somebody who enslaved your ancestors. And we are commemorating them – celebrating them – as icons...’ And look again at Jones’s sculptures. The male artist depicted women as furniture within a society where women are still treated as secondary citizens. Regardless of the artist’s intentions, it’s thus plausible to interpret the work as amounting to a kind of sexist speech: it subordinates women by depicting us as household objects, ranking us as inferior and legitimising misogynistic attitudes.

Artworks speak, act and have concrete consequences for people’s lives. Recognising artistic speech or expression reveals a distinctive potential harm towards marginalised groups. So how should we manage it?

It’s our right to express views in public without fear of being silenced or punished, a right preserved (though not always upheld) under the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. This includes not just ordinary speaking but other forms of expression such as works of art. But as John Stuart Mill argued in *On Liberty* (1859), this freedom isn’t absolute – most philosophers and lawmakers believe that there must be some limits. Yet some legal restrictions are less stringent than others: the US First Amendment affords protection to some racist hate speech, for example – far more than the laws of the UK, Australia and Canada do.

Some theorists, such as Jeremy Waldron, think that such speech should be banned in the quest for a just society, which publicly upholds the dignity of all persons. Such a call for tougher speech legislation could mean banning any works of art that, via their hateful messages and acts, cause similarly damaging social consequences or enact harms such as subordination. So, should we forever hide away Gauguin’s paintings? Quietly remove all Confederate and slave trader monuments?

It’s commonly assumed that artworks are special and should be almost immune to censorship; silencing artists is often considered deplorable. One familiar objection, expressed by museum professionals such as Vicente Todolí, former director of Tate Modern in London, is that censorship would mean losing great art. Indeed, several people present at the National Gallery debate in London said that taking down Gauguin’s works would mean losing ‘genius’ and ‘beauty’. Given that aesthetic experiences are considered valuable, this loss would apparently be regrettable.

Moreover, under the First Amendment, for example, **many artworks that express hateful messages would be protected as legal expression because it’s hard to show that they incite violence.** Indeed, it’s notoriously difficult to prove that particular artworks directly cause criminal behaviour. Meaning in art is more complex than ordinary speech, and the artist could deny having certain communicative intentions for their artwork, and so be let off the hook.

A different kind of concern about censoring harmful art is that doing so might sweep under the carpet problematic canons and past atrocities. Such erasure could even result in a widespread amnesia (at least within dominant groups), where many won't adequately confront our true history. Removing statues and paintings without anyone noticing might not properly engage with the problem in the first place; it could even be tantamount to dismissing the magnitude of the atrocities honoured by the monuments, or the immoral messages expressed by the paintings.

Instead of censorship, some have opted for an alternative response to hate speech. We can challenge, refute or even undo the harms of hate speech with more speech. Speaking back presents counternarratives and counterevidence to the falsehoods expressed. This might involve publicly denouncing instances of hate speech and affirming the dignity of the groups targeted, or refuting transphobic speech in social media forums, or challenging racist speech on public transport or at home.

Counterspeech, in particular this 'blocking', can illuminate parallel artistic and curatorial strategies to counter hate speech such as sexist paintings or racist monuments. The idea is that we should fight visual hate speech with artistic interventions and better curation; a kind of 'curatorial activism', as the feminist curator Maura Reilly put it in 2018. This approach has the distinct advantage of avoiding the issues with banning problematic art. I shall introduce just a few such strategies, although this is by no means an exhaustive list.

First, manipulation of an artwork and its curated space. Consider the Duke of Wellington monument in Glasgow, commemorating the military leader who led British armies to extend the East India Company's control. The friezes around the statue depict the duke sacking Indian cities and slaughtering South Asians. For many years now, the statue has had a traffic cone on its head. Thought to have originated as a drunken joke, this action has taken on new significance. Amid protests after the murder of George Floyd, the cone was replaced with a Black Lives Matter (BLM) substitute. Consider also political vandalism and the addition of new artworks. The Robert E Lee Confederate monument in Virginia was spraypainted with 'Blood On Your Hands' and 'Stop White Supremacy' by BLM protestors, and was targeted with projections of Floyd's face, bearing the words 'No Justice, No Peace'. The defaced monument is now deemed one of the most influential American protest artworks since the Second World War. And on antislavery day in 2018, the art installation *Here and Now* appeared beneath the Colston statue in Bristol. The work took the shape of a slave-ship hull, with concrete figurines as cargo.

There are also interactions with pieces in galleries. In her painting *Open Casket* (2016), based on the mutilated face of the teenager Emmett Till who was lynched in 1955, Dana Schutz was accused of cultural appropriation in using Black pain as 'raw material'. In response, the artist Parker Bright stood in front of the painting wearing a T-shirt reading 'BLACK DEATH SPECTACLE' and spoke about the work's harms: 'no one should be making money off a Black dead body'.

Second, transparent curation. A few days before a Gauguin exhibition opened at the National Gallery of Canada in 2019, the curators edited some of the wall texts to avoid culturally insensitive language. Gauguin's 'relationship with a young Tahitian woman' was changed to 'his relationship with a 13- or 14-year-old Tahitian girl'. And consider Michelle Hartney's *Performance/Call to Action* (2018), in which the artist placed #MeToo-inspired wall labels next to paintings by Picasso and Gauguin at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, to underscore their transgressions. For example, next to Gauguin's *Two Tahitian Women* (1899), Hartney quoted an essay by Roxane Gay: '[I]t's time to say that there is no artistic work, no legacy so great that we choose to look the other way.'

Curation tells stories about the work on display, and curators have a responsibility to give accurate and true narratives surrounding the art. Facts shouldn't be suppressed to furnish more convenient narratives obscuring truth. Artistic curation such as Hartney's recontextualises these pieces, exposing

the violent reality behind them, prompting the viewer to look again and reconsider their sometimes-dismissive attitude to artmaking contexts.

135 Artistic and curatorial strategies might to some extent sidestep these issues. Placing a cone on a statue's head doesn't require much cognitive labour in unpacking what the statue is saying and presupposing: the action itself swiftly opens up discussion, which then exposes the harm of the monument. Moreover, protest art can offer collaborative activities with graffiti, dramatic curation or performance, which give marginalised groups better positions of power from which to shout back.

140 Some responses to harmful art will inevitably be redescribed as vandalism, thus causing legal issues. But not reacting to such works can carry even greater risks to society due to the implied collusion or indifference to the issues such works raise. I've mentioned just a few activist strategies to manage dangerous art; there are also methods that highlight marginalised artists, such as new retrospective exhibitions, as well as decolonising and democratising art education through platforms such as the Black Blossoms School of Art and Culture in the UK.

145 Outright censorship is rife with problems generally, let alone art censorship, which is far more complex than straightforward speech. So we need to find new ways of signalling our disquiet, disgust and outrage at art that perpetuates social injustice. As the Bristol poet Vanessa Kisuule puts it: 'I'm not necessarily for getting rid of statues... I want people to scribble on them, to make counteractive art about them.' Curatorial and artistic responses are the way forward here; complacency certainly isn't.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. Dixon recounts instances where art intended to prompt meaningful debate was met with outrage (lines 1-10). What are some reasons for our interpretations of art sometimes diverging from the artist's original intentions? Should there be a universal objective definition of what aesthetic beauty is?
2. In paragraph 4 (lines 28-29), Dixon claims that meaning in art is "partly determined by the surrounding context and are sometimes different to what the artist had in mind." To what extent is this a realistic take on diversity in the world of art? May such subjectivity in the meaning in art also be a function of **time** on top of being informed by **place**? Can you think of any examples that illustrate such subjectivity in the interpretation of artistic meaning?
3. In lines 41-42, Dixon states that "[t]here are conventional gestures within artmaking and curatorial display, too." Identify two other real-world examples of 'gestures' that result in some artworks being more controversial/offensive than others?
4. In lines 58-59, Dixon claims that "[a]rtworks speak, act and have concrete consequences for people's lives [in that] artistic speech or expression reveals a distinctive potential harm towards marginalised groups." Do the costs always outweigh the benefits whenever artworks are put up for public display and consumption? To what extent do **time** and **place** also impact the cost-benefit considerations of artistic consumption?
5. Dixon cites instances where "cultural appropriation" (line 117) and "transparent curation" (line 120) are used as tools to promote public engagement with art. Do you think we should be allowed to change artworks as long as the intent is positive?

Related essay questions:

1. Consider the argument that there should be no censorship of the arts in modern society. (Cambridge 2023)
2. 'Censorship of the arts is necessary to maintain social cohesion.' To what extent is this view still relevant to your society? (RI 2023 y6 Timed Practice)
3. 'The arts ask questions while science provides answers.' How valid is this view? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
4. 'Now more than ever, the arts should be subject to government censorship.' Comment. (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)

5. Examine the claim that artists should have complete freedom of expression. (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
6. Should the Arts always challenge the status quo? (RI 2016 Y5 Promo)
7. 'Real art is something that makes us uncomfortable.' Do you agree? (RI 2014 Y6 CT2)

Related case studies:

- 1)  [Art Censorship: First Amendment Violation or Private Free Speech?](#) (Scott A Leadingham, **Freedom Forum**): *The article argues that all forms of art — painting, sculpture, dance, provocative exhibitions — are protected as free speech under the First Amendment. However, protection only applies when censorship comes from the government; private galleries, museums or individuals may legally decide not to display a work — even if it conflicts with free-expression values. The piece reviews **some historical instances** of art censorship, illustrating how both public authorities and private institutions have restricted works for nudity, political commentary or social discomfort.*
- 2)  <https://edition.cnn.com/2025/09/28/style/art-museums-pressures-trump> (**USA, 2025, CNN**): *Reports on the increasing attempts to censor US museums, and exert pressure to modify, remove, or limit exhibitions and programmes.*

SECTION C: REGULATING THE ARTS

Reading 11: Samsui woman kerfuffle shows negative attitudes towards the arts

Kimberly Lim | Rice Media | 25 June 2024

This reading will introduce you to the:

- Importance of historical accuracy in artistic representation, particularly in capturing Singapore's traditions and heritage
- Need to carefully navigate gender stereotypes and perceptions in artistic representation
- Problem with reactionary public responses and censorship by the authorities
- Difficulty associated with balancing public feedback and artistic freedom

Over the weekend, a woman and her cigarette became the subject of debate.

A mural on a Chinatown shophouse featuring a youthful jade-bangled samsui woman, perched on a wooden chair, toting a cigarette, recently caught the attention of the Urban Redevelopment Authority (URA) as it apparently ran counter to the Singapore government's anti-smoking policies. This was despite the fact that samsui women, who mainly worked as construction labourers, frequently smoked—one of the few respites in their famously frugal lives. URA told the landlord to erase the cigarette in the mural and public outcry predictably ensued, *The Straits Times* reported on June 21.

The Singapore-based American artist who'd painted the mural, Sean Dunston, also alleged that URA, in their feedback to the landlord, had cited a comment from an unnamed member of the public which called the mural "offensive" and said the woman "looks more like a prostitute than a hard-working samsui woman". There's a lot to unpack there, but I'll save that for later.

URA then ignominiously walked back on its decision, saying it would review its stance after taking into account the additional feedback. While it deliberates, the mural and her cigarette get to stay. Even as it has yet to reach its conclusion, this debacle has raised questions about our knee-jerk response to complaints. What do we lose when the loudest voices find offence in the innocuous?

On stereotypes and preconceived notions

Not liking the artwork isn't the problem here. The bigger issue is the entitlement of trying to get something taken down simply because you didn't like it. As more people caught wind of the mural, it became clear that—as with any artwork—it had its fans and detractors. It wasn't just the cigarette that some people found objectionable. It was apparently the samsui woman's gaze and the upturned grasp of her cigarette.

She was holding it in "a glamorous way", AWARE Singapore claimed when they weighed in on the topic on social media. The women's rights advocacy group said the portrayal might perpetuate the male gaze. Likening the woman in the mural to a prostitute—and using the word as an insult—is an extremely damaging take, AWARE Singapore added. Indeed, it's ironic that the unnamed member of the public, in calling for more respect to be shown to our samsui women, managed to disrespect sex workers and perpetuate misogyny in one fell swoop.

At the same time, other members of the public saw no issue with the mural, even sharing photos of actual samsui women to prove its historical accuracy. The facts are, these samsui women *were* young when they came over from China to work. They *did* smoke. It's not a stretch to say that Dunston's samsui woman mural is a pretty reasonable depiction. But why does this particular portrayal of a samsui woman make some uncomfortable?

Sure, the artist is an American man. And the topic of men creating artwork to cater to the male gaze isn't new. But I'm not sure if that's the point here. It isn't as if the samsui woman dressed or

35 posed in a vulgar manner, nor is she sporting a full face of makeup. All she's doing is sitting and enjoying a smoke. Can a woman not do that without being sexualised or seen as trying to appeal to the male gaze? What even is a "glamorous" way of holding a cigarette? Must a female labourer always be portrayed as elderly and devoid of all femininity?

40 A part of the discomfort some Singaporeans are feeling also stems from the fact that we simply aren't used to seeing samsui women portrayed in this way. We're used to the monolithic representation of the samsui woman in our media: old, withered, exhausted. The image of samsui women has been appropriated in various ways to champion desirable values such as hard work, thrift, resilience, and perseverance, says *Remembering the Samsui Women* author Kelvin E.Y. Low.

45 Beyond their media portrayal as industrious pioneers then and elderly women in need of help now, there are other ways to remember their lives and experiences. For what it's worth, Dunston, the mural artist, did say that was his intent. Speaking to *The Straits Times*, he explained: "Normally, samsui women are portrayed as old women—but when they came to Singapore, they were young and you don't really see that kind of depiction. I thought it would be nice to change it up to show a younger woman and catch them in a situation when they were not working."

50 If we really care about these women's history, why are we—well, mainly just that anonymous complainant—trying to censor a historically accurate aspect of their life and sanitise it to fit our idea of them? Perhaps we're so used to seeing a PG version of our history that being faced with something outside the typical narrative is enough to offend people.

What URA could have done better

55 To be fair, it's not surprising that the mural caught the authorities' attention. All proposals for murals on conserved buildings should be submitted to the building owner and URA for prior approval, the statutory board told *CNA*. The artist in this case hadn't done that for the mural, which was completed in early April.

60 The proposal was submitted on April 19, after completion. URA had flagged the smoking in the mural as an issue on May 8, but the artist did not submit a new proposal by the stated May 22 deadline. But if URA's issue with the mural was solely the depiction of smoking, why did it have to highlight the "prostitute" message in its email to the artist? The feedback was inaccurate, hyperbolic, and misogynistic.

What purpose was sharing it supposed to achieve? By passing this feedback on to the landlord as if it was valid, was URA not lending the complaint some legitimacy?

65 Their stance of requiring murals to align with government policy is also debatable. Current legislation only prohibits tobacco advertisements and promotion. As Dunston told *The Straits Times*: "It's good to have boundaries, but a generic template for enforcing rules on art is damaging. The policy stance on cigarettes is well founded if it's an advertisement, endorsement or advocacy. This mural is not any of those."

70 Popular mural artist Yip Yew Chong agreed, writing on his Instagram account that painting a samsui woman taking a smoke break, as they used to do, is by no means promoting smoking. Yip, who's known for his large-scale nostalgic murals, also revealed that he'd originally intended for his mural at Thian Hock Keng Temple to include coolies smoking opium. However, after consulting with the authorities and stakeholders, he decided to change it to coolies cooking on their bunk beds instead. It's not as if seeing a historical depiction of coolies smoking opium would encourage viewers to try smoking opium. Sanitising our history to such an extent is obviously overkill.

If conflicting public complaints can prompt the URA to reevaluate its decision, it might be a good opportunity for them to clarify how they determine whether public feedback is worth acting on. This

80 applies not just to the URA—all government bodies would benefit from building public trust through greater transparency behind drastic decisions. Realistically, we can never be rid of censorship. But it should be based on solid parameters and principles rather than hasty reactions to whoever complains the loudest.

Complaint culture

This whole incident is reminiscent of the recent Science Centre kerfuffle, where a planned talk on gender and sex was nuked after conservatives' complaints. We could have had a productive, educational discussion at the Science Centre, but now we'll never know.

85 Are we too reactive to complaints, to the point where we stifle discourse? Of course, lines should be drawn when content or art is truly offensive. For example, if it's outrightly demeaning towards a group of people. But allowing content that sparks debate isn't a bad thing. Take this mural for example. It's already created conversations on historical accuracy, morality, sexuality, and gender stereotypes.

90 Pandering to a vocal group that takes offence to minor things might be the safe route. After all, if someone complains about something, just act on it, and the complaints will likely disappear. Problem solved. That's Singaporean efficiency for you.

95 But we have to consider what we lose in the process—vibrant, nuanced, thought-provoking discussions. Art serves as a mirror to society—this includes the good, bad and ugly. How can we have a thriving cultural scene if we only want the sanitised, wholesome bits of our history represented in our historic buildings? Some complaints are reasonable. Some, like the "prostitute" complaint, clearly aren't. We can only hope that people can learn the difference.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. What characteristics of samsui women does the wall mural depict, and how does Dunston (line 8 & 44), the artist, justify his portrayal? Should artistic representation always be historically authentic and accurate? In what ways is Singapore's context significant when it comes to how authentically art captures local culture or heritage?
2. In criticising the depiction of the mural, AWARE argues that it 'might perpetuate the male gaze' (lines 22-23). In your own words, explain what this means, and why it is something our society should be concerned about.
3. What are some positive and negative aspects of the actions taken by URA in response to public feedback about the mural?
4. Explain how the events surrounding the mural illustrate the difficulties the authorities have in striking a balance between cultural sensitivity and artistic freedom. Amongst these, which is the most problematic trade-off?
5. Do you agree that a Complain Culture is prevalent in Singapore? What might be some factors contributing to it, and how might society as a whole move away from such a culture?

Related essay questions:

1. Consider the argument that there should be no censorship of the arts in modern society. (Cambridge 2023)
2. 'Censorship of the arts is necessary to maintain social cohesion.' To what extent is this view still relevant in your society? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
3. Examine the claim that artists should have complete freedom of expression. (RI 2018 Y6 CT2)
4. To what extent can the literary or performing arts be a vehicle for change? (RI 2014 Y6 Prelims)

Related case studies (Singapore):

The following are 4 key case studies in which artists contest state boundaries or official narratives. To build your example bank, research these examples and note (i) the authorities' response to the works, (ii) the artists' defence, as well as (iii) the public/civil society's response to them. What common threads may be observed in these case studies?

- *The Art of Charlie Chan Hock Chye* (Graphic Novel, Sonny Liew) – 2014
- *Golden Staircase* (Installation, Priyangeetha Dia) – 2017
- *Small Hours of the Night* (Film, Daniel Hui) – 2024
- *Homepar* (Theatre, Wild Rice) – 2025

Further food for thought: Theatre practitioner Tracie Pang once argued that governmental restrictions are unnecessary because “we have a community of arts goers who are intelligent enough to make up their own minds.” Do you agree? Justify your response.

Here's another reading which questions the sufficiency of relying on the state to support the arts:



[Pay up: Singapore's arts and culture need your money, not your grief](#) (Singapore, 2025, The Straits Times): Journalist Bhavan Jaipragas reflects on the closure of *The Projector*, Singapore's first independent, arthouse cinema. He points out that what the artistic institutions we value needs the most is not governmental backing but patrons and public support.

SECTION C: REGULATING THE ARTS

Reading 12: Generative AI is a minefield for copyright law

EUs 3, 4, 10

Robert Mahari, Jessica Fjeld, and Ziv Epstein | *The Conversation* | 15 June 2023

This reading will help you:

- Understand the controversy surrounding AI-generated art.
- Recognise how the rise of generative AI has raised questions about copyright laws and ownership of AI-generated images.

In 2022, an AI-generated work of art won the Colorado State Fair’s art competition. The artist, Jason Allen, had used Midjourney – a generative AI system trained on art scraped from the internet – to create the piece.

5 The process was far from fully automated: Allen went through some 900 iterations over 80 hours to create and refine his submission. Yet his use of AI to win the art competition triggered a heated backlash online, with one Twitter user claiming, “We’re watching the death of artistry unfold right before our eyes.”

10 As generative AI art tools like Midjourney and Stable Diffusion have been thrust into the limelight, so too have questions about ownership and authorship. These tools’ generative ability is the result of training them with scores of prior artworks, from which the AI learns how to create artistic outputs.

Should the artists whose art was scraped to train the models be compensated? Who owns the images that AI systems produce? Is the process of fine-tuning prompts for generative AI a form of authentic creative expression?

15 On one hand, technophiles rave over work like Allen’s. But on the other, many working artists consider the use of their art to train AI to be exploitative. We’re part of a team of 14 experts across disciplines that just published a paper on generative AI in *Science* magazine. In it, we explore how advances in AI will affect creative work, aesthetics and the media. One of the key questions that emerged has to do with U.S. copyright laws, and whether they can adequately deal with the unique challenges of generative AI.

20 Copyright laws were created to promote the arts and creative thinking. But the rise of generative AI has complicated existing notions of authorship.

Photography serves as a helpful lens

Generative AI might seem unprecedented, but history can act as a guide.

25 Take the emergence of photography in the 1800s. Before its invention, artists could only try to portray the world through drawing, painting or sculpture. Suddenly, reality could be captured in a flash using a camera and chemicals.

30 As with generative AI, many argued that photography lacked artistic merit. In 1884, the U.S. Supreme Court weighed in on the issue and found that cameras served as tools that an artist could use to give an idea visible form; the “masterminds” behind the cameras, the court ruled, should own the photographs they create.

From then on, photography evolved into its own art form and even sparked new abstract artistic movements.

AI can't own outputs

35 Unlike inanimate cameras, AI possesses capabilities – like the ability to convert basic instructions into impressive artistic works – that make it prone to anthropomorphising. Even the term “artificial intelligence” encourages people to think that these systems have humanlike intent or even self-awareness.

This led some people to wonder whether AI systems can be “owners.” But the U.S. Copyright Office has stated unequivocally that only humans can hold copyrights.

40 So who can claim ownership of images produced by AI? Is it the artists whose images were used to train the systems? The users who type in prompts to create images? Or the people who build the AI systems?

Infringement or fair use?

While artists draw obliquely from past works that have educated and inspired them in order to create, generative AI relies on training data to produce outputs.

45 This training data consists of prior artworks, many of which are protected by copyright law and which have been collected without artists’ knowledge or consent. Using art in this way might violate copyright law even before the AI generates a new work.

Computer generated image made to look like a painting of a face with wires spilling out of its head surrounded by a field of grass and flowers.

50 For Jason Allen to create his award-winning art, Midjourney was trained on 100 million prior works. Was that a form of infringement? Or was it a new form of “fair use,” a legal doctrine that permits the unlicensed use of protected works if they’re sufficiently transformed into something new?

While AI systems do not contain literal copies of the training data, they do sometimes manage to recreate works from the training data, complicating this legal analysis. Will contemporary copyright law favour end users and companies over the artists whose content is in the training data?

55 To mitigate this concern, some scholars propose new regulations to protect and compensate artists whose work is used for training. These proposals include a right for artists to opt out of their data’s being used for generative AI or a way to automatically compensate artists when their work is used to train an AI.

Muddled ownership

60 Training data, however, is only part of the process. Frequently, artists who use generative AI tools go through many rounds of revision to refine their prompts, which suggests a degree of originality. Answering the question of who should own the outputs requires looking into the contributions of all those involved in the generative AI supply chain.

The legal analysis is easier when an output is different from works in the training data. In this case, whoever prompted the AI to produce the output appears to be the default owner.

65 However, copyright law requires meaningful creative input – a standard satisfied by clicking the shutter button on a camera. It remains unclear how courts will decide what this means for the use of generative AI. Is composing and refining a prompt enough?

70 Matters are more complicated when outputs resemble works in the training data. If the resemblance is based only on general style or content, it is unlikely to violate copyright, because style is not copyrightable.

The illustrator Hollie Mengert encountered this issue firsthand when her unique style was mimicked by generative AI engines in a way that did not capture what, in her eyes, made her work unique. Meanwhile, the singer Grimes embraced the tech, “open-sourcing” her voice and encouraging fans to create songs in her style using generative AI.

75 If an output contains major elements from a work in the training data, it might infringe on that work’s copyright. Recently, the Supreme Court ruled that Andy Warhol’s drawing of a photograph was not permitted by fair use. That means that using AI to just change the style of a work – say, from a photo to an illustration – is not enough to claim ownership over the modified output.

80 While copyright law tends to favour an all-or-nothing approach, scholars at Harvard Law School have proposed new models of joint ownership that allow artists to gain some rights in outputs that resemble their works.

85 In many ways, generative AI is yet another creative tool that allows a new group of people access to image-making, just like cameras, paintbrushes or Adobe Photoshop. But a key difference is this new set of tools relies explicitly on training data, and therefore creative contributions cannot easily be traced back to a single artist.

The ways in which existing laws are interpreted or reformed – and whether generative AI is appropriately treated as the tool it is – will have real consequences for the future of creative expression.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. What was the source of controversy surrounding the AI-generated artwork that won the Colorado State Fair's art competition in 2022, and how did artist Jason Allen create his winning piece using generative AI? (lines 1-5)
2. The article discusses the controversies and legal complexities surrounding generative AI in the art world. What are some of the trade-offs or compromises that artists, AI developers, and policymakers might need to consider in the development and use of generative AI for creative expression?
3. What are some ways that society can encourage the exploration of AI in art while still protecting artists and their work?

Related essay questions:

1. To what extent should traditional art forms be preserved in a world driven by innovation? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelims)
2. To what extent has technology had a negative impact on the arts, such as music or photography? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
3. To what extent has technology revolutionised the arts? (RI 2012 Y6 Prelims)

Further reading:

- [When AI can make art – what does it mean for creativity?](#) (Laurie Clarke, The Guardian, 2022)
- [AI art: The end of creativity or the start of a new movement?](#) (Claudia Baxter, BBC, 2024)

SECTION D: DIFFERENT GENRES OF THE ARTS

Reading 13: High and Low Art

EUs 1, 4, 8

Matt Plescher | The Rapidian | 10 March 2013

This reading will help you:

- Consider the difference between high (fine art) and low art (craft)
- Examine the relationship between art genres and its assigned value in society

Are some forms of art “higher” than others? Is classical music a higher form than rock music? Is poetry above detective novels? Most people are aware of a distinction between high and low art. High art is appreciated by those with the most cultivated taste. Low art is for the masses, accessible and easily comprehended.

5 The concept of high and low can be traced back to 18th century ideas about fine art and craft. Writers
in the 1700s drew a line between work that is contemplated purely for aesthetics (fine art) and work
that has some sort of utility or function (craft). The fine art grouping of painting, sculpture, music,
architecture and poetry was established at this time. The familiar phrase “art for art’s sake” comes
out of this view, and is so culturally pervasive that many people accept it as the “correct” way to
10 classify art.

There are instances the fine art method doesn't work well classifying art. A hand-made box with carved decoration is not considered fine art because of its utility. However, the decoration could be aesthetically contemplated. Is the decorative part high and the utility part low? Some travel posters can be contemplated aesthetically in the same way as a fine art painting, but they were intentionally created to be easily accessible and function as mass-distributed advertisements. Does that mean they are high and low art at the same time? What about movies? Movies appeared after the traditional fine art groupings were established. Are they always low art or can they be high art too? Can they be both?

Another problem with the fine art/craft distinction is the way it implies value. The fine art view holds in esteem one way of interacting with art—aesthetic contemplation. However, art had other functions before the fine art distinction was made and continues to have those functions now. Art can instruct, entertain, mystify, propagandise and frighten to name just a few. However, the fine art approach reserves the status of “good” for work that is primarily aesthetic. Contemplation is the highest and purest goal for art. Other functions of art are considered somehow impure. Hence the loaded words high and low, which simultaneously classify and judge.

This affects how people interact with the arts. People who feel strongly that high art is good and low art is bad will think of low art as something to be avoided. Some would even consider a poor classical piece better than a great rock song, simply because the classical piece is considered a higher style. Others take a more tolerant position. They hold high art to have higher value, but see low art as “having a place.” Someone with this view would consider a symphony a higher art form, but would be okay listening to pop music in the car. Those who place a greater value on high art sometimes believe that high art serves a kind of spiritual or moral function. A common assumption is that high art is “edifying” and low art is “mere entertainment.” If only the masses can be steered into the concert halls and museums, the power of high art will awaken them from their low art-induced stupor. To them, art has a quasi-religious function, with beauty lifting us to a higher level of spirituality. It’s no accident that museums are often designed to feel like temples.

The fine art/craft approach is a problematic way to classify art to begin with, and is further weakened by the way it assigns value to narrow slice of the art experience. Another approach is to simply contrast limited-audience art with popular art, initially leaving value judgments aside.

- 40 There are several factors that contribute to whether a work will be broadly popular or not. One is how distinctive or unique the work is. Art that places a high premium on uniqueness will generally have a narrower audience. In contrast, popular art often follows proven formulas that have been shown to appeal to large groups. Popular forms are also often deliberately lower in complexity in order to be easily accessible. In short, popular art will very often be crafted to appeal to a large audience with a
- 45 minimum of effort by the viewer. Lastly, popular art is almost invariably mass produced. Using these criteria, an artwork can be placed along a continuum without the black and white distinction of high and low.

- 50 Once the work has been placed on a limited-audience/popular art spectrum, the second step would be to judge the success of the work within that context (I discuss judging success in more depth in this article). This avoids the implied value judgment of the words high and low, or fine art and craft. Judging a work's success in this way can take into account the goals of the artist, including whether the work was made for a limited audience or was meant to be popular.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. In lines 23-24, Plescher states that it is often regarded that "Contemplation is the highest and purest goal for art. Other functions of art are considered somehow impure." How far do you agree that popular art/music, whose primary function is to entertain, is a lesser form of art?
2. Plescher describes a common perception that "a poor classical piece [is] better than a great rock song, simply because the classical piece is considered a higher style" (lines 27-28). Why do you think that there is a tendency to associate less accessible forms of art with a higher style, and conversely, more popular forms of art with a lower style? What implications might there be in terms of how artistic value or beauty is ascribed to different forms of arts?
3. In lines 35-36, Plescher mentions that art has a "quasi-religious function" and that "It's no accident that museums are often designed to feel like temples." Based on your experience visiting museums, especially art museums, in what ways might they be intentionally "designed to feel like temples"? What impact might this have on the status and appreciation of art that is displayed in museums versus those that are not?

Related essay questions:

1. 'Art is only worth what people will pay for it.' Do you agree? (RI 2021 Y6 Prelims)
2. 'Pop music has no value beyond being a source of entertainment.' What is your view? (RI 2021 Y6 Timed Practice)
3. How far do you agree that popular music serves no real purpose? (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
4. Examine the extent to which fashion can be considered art. (RI 2018 Y6 Prelims)
5. 'Comic books have little to offer us except entertainment.' Comment. (RI 2017 Y5 Promo)
6. Examine the extent to which graffiti can be considered art. (RI Y6 CT1 2016)

Reading 14: Music helps us remember who we are and how we belong during difficult and traumatic times EUs 2, 4, 10

EUs 2, 4, 10

The following reading will help you:

- Has the music we listen to, and why we listen, changed during the coronavirus pandemic? Beyond the well-documented evidence of pandemic music-making at a distance and over social media, music critics have suggested there is an increased preference for music that is comforting, familiar and nostalgic.

More than half of those participating in a survey conducted by Nielsen Music/MRC Data at the end of March 2020 said they were “seeking comfort in familiar, nostalgic content” in their TV viewing and music listening. The survey was based on responses by 945 consumers in the U.S. aged 13 and older, plus online responses.

As a researcher who has examined music's power in times of crisis — most recently, exploring the music of people who were refugees from civil war El Salvador during the 1980s — I believe such work can help us understand our apparent desire to use familiar music for psychological support during this challenging period.

In a time when many are confronting both increased solitude and increased anxiety, familiar music provides reassurance because it reminds us who we are as people. Whether it is a hit we danced to with our teenage friends, or a haunting orchestral piece our grandmother played, music lights up memories of our past selves.

Music allows us to create an emotional narrative between the past and present when we struggle to articulate such a narrative in words. Its familiarity comforts us when the future seems unclear. Music helps to reconnect us to our identities. It also helps us, as all the arts do, to pursue an otherwise inexpressible search for meaning. In so doing, it helps bolster our resilience in the face of difficulty.

People have used music to such philosophical and psychological ends even in times and places where one would think music would be the last thing on peoples' minds. In one of the most extreme among many examples, survivors of Nazi concentration camps report having sung familiar songs to reinforce their sense of self and their religious identity, when both were gravely threatened.

My current research considers music's use for such purposes during the 1980s by refugees from the civil war in El Salvador. Subsistence farmers (*campesinos/campesinas*), who fled government

oppression for refugee camps in Honduras, have told me they considered music essential to their psychological survival.

In a sometimes dangerous new land, away from their war stricken home, *campesinos* and *campesinas* performed, listened and danced to old and new folk songs to help sustain a connection to their pre-war identities in the nation they had left behind. Traditional folk songs were sometimes given new words to document the refugees' persecution.

Songs thus provided both a means to maintain identity and an emotional narrative for traumatic events that were hard to describe in words. This helped the refugees manage the challenges of the present and face an uncertain future.

Norberto Amaya

In 2019, I helped conduct research for a short documentary about one leading refugee singer-songwriter in El Salvador, Norberto Amaya. Amaya's story shows how Salvadoran musicians harnessed music to help their refugee compatriots manage the psychological challenges of their situation. The film was a collaboration between Western University and Juan Bello of Triana Media, with support from the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council.

The songs of El Salvador's civil war refugees make clear that music, whether old or new, serves a vital function for humans facing hardship, both on personal and cultural levels.

Community connection

The COVID-19 pandemic has hit some communities much harder than others, and demonstrated how existing inequalities are thrown into even greater relief in times of crisis. Yet in all affected communities, the pandemic has the capacity to trigger anxious feelings about earlier traumas and current separations.

Listening to music we know well reminds us of the friends and family that have made us who we are. In our current situation, different as it is from that faced by Salvadoran civil war refugees, familiar music is similarly permitting reconnection both to personal identity and to a much larger community of family, friends and strangers who also love these familiar songs. This helps us better manage our isolation and anxiety.

This apparent human instinct to seek out mechanisms that enable cultural reconnection is a smart one. Trauma scholars believe that, for some people, familiar cultural practices may actually be more effective than psychiatric treatment in helping people deal with potentially traumatic events.

American poet and activist Maya Angelou once movingly wrote: "Music was my refuge. I could crawl into the space between the notes and curl my back to loneliness." Many can surely relate to such a sentiment. We may not yet have the words to articulate our response to the situation in which humanity currently finds itself. But engaging with music soothes us in these difficult times, providing a means to begin to process our emotions, to stay connected to our pre-pandemic identities and to participate in something larger than ourselves, even while we live apart.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. The author explores how music connects to personal identity and to a much larger community who also love these songs. How applicable are her views to you and Singapore, particularly during difficult times (such as the COVID-19 pandemic or other crises)?
2. Consider the rise of apps like TikTok today, which spread viral ideas of all kinds through clips of popular music. Does this make popular music more like a significant cultural mover or 'noise'?

3. The author suggests that music is a way to “enable cultural reconnection” (line 75), which in turn, may help people “better manage [their] isolation and anxiety” (lines 72-73). Considering relevant changes or trends in your society today, do you believe that such a role of music would grow or diminish? Why?

Related essay questions:

1. Examine the claim the music without words lacks both meaning and appeal. (Cambridge 2022)
2. ‘An appreciation of music is vital for a fully rounded education.’ How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
3. Examine the role of music in establishing a national identity in your society. (Cambridge 2017)
4. ‘The arts, such as music and literature, are of no real value to society.’ Is this a valid comment? (RI 2016 Y6 CT1)
5. Does music offer anything more than momentary pleasure? (RI 2015 Y5 Promo)

Related case studies:

- 1)  [Glory to Hong Kong: How the protesters got a new song](#) (Hong Kong, 2019, BBC): The rise of an unofficial anthem of Hong Kong during the demonstrations of 2019-2020 which, fostered a greater sense of national identity. The embedded video highlights the patriotic spirit of the participants and its impact on Hong Kong. [This CNN article](#) (2023) shows the Chinese Government’s reaction. The two articles present how the intrinsic impact of music is powerful enough to provoke a political reaction.
- 2)  [When melody meets medicine: A look at Singapore’s growing music therapy scene](#) (Singapore, 2025, The Straits Times): Music therapy is becoming more established in Singapore as a clinical, evidence-based profession to support physical, emotional, cognitive, and social wellness.

SECTION E: THREATS TO CULTURE & ARTS

Reading 15: The dos and don'ts of cultural appropriation

EUs 8, 9

Jenni Avins Quratzand | *The Atlantic* | 20 November 2015

This reading will help you:

- Identify the reasons why cultural appropriation is not only inevitable but also beneficial today
- Identify several ways in which cultural appropriation can be done in a contextually sensitive and productive manner

Sometime during the early 2000s, big, gold, “door-knocker” hoop earrings started to appeal to me, after I’d admired them on girls at school. It didn’t faze me that most of the girls who wore these earrings at my high school in St. Louis were black, unlike me. And while it certainly may have occurred to me that I – a semi-preppy dresser – couldn’t pull them off, it never occurred to me that I shouldn’t.

- 5 This was before the term “cultural appropriation”¹ jumped from academia into the realm of Internet outrage and oversensitivity. Self-appointed guardians of culture have proclaimed that Miley Cyrus shouldn’t twerk, white girls shouldn’t wear cornrows, and Selena Gomez should take off that bindi². Personally, I could happily live without ever seeing Cyrus twerk again, but I still find many of these accusations alarming.
- 10 At my house, getting dressed is a daily act of cultural appropriation, and I’m not the least bit sorry about it. I step out of the shower in the morning and pull on a vintage cotton kimono. After moisturising my face, I smear Lucas Papaw ointment – a tip from an Australian makeup artist – onto my lips before I make coffee with a Bialetti stovetop espresso maker a girlfriend brought back from Italy. Depending on the weather, I may pull on an embroidered floral blouse I bought at a roadside
- 15 shop in Mexico or a stripey marinière³-style shirt – originally inspired by the French, but mine from the surplus store was a standard-issue Russian telnyashka⁴ – or my favourite purple pajama pants, a souvenir from a friend’s trip to India. I may wear Spanish straw-soled espadrilles (though I’m not from Spain) or Bahian leather sandals (I’m not Brazilian either) and top it off with a favourite piece of jewellery, perhaps a Navajo turquoise ring (also not my heritage).
- 20 As I dress in the morning, I deeply appreciate the craftsmanship and design behind these items, as well as the adventures and people they recall. And while I hope I don’t offend anyone, I find the alternative – the idea that I ought to stay in the cultural lane I was born into – outrageous. No matter how much I love cable-knit sweaters and Gruyere cheese, I don’t want to live in a world where the only cultural inspiration I’m entitled to comes from my roots in Ireland, Switzerland, and Eastern
- 25 Europe.

There are legitimate reasons to step carefully when dressing ourselves with the clothing, arts, artefacts, or ideas of other cultures. But please, let’s banish the idea that appropriating elements from one another’s cultures is in itself problematic.

- 30 Such borrowing is how we got treasures such as New York pizza and Japanese denim – not to mention how the West got democratic discourse, mathematics, and the calendar. Yet as wave upon wave of

¹ Cultural appropriation is the unacknowledged or inappropriate adoption of the customs, practices, ideas of one people or society by members of another and typically a more dominant society or people.

² Coloured dot worn on the centre of the forehead, originally by Hindus and Jains from the Indian subcontinent.

³ Cotton long-sleeved shirt with horizontal blue and white stripes. Characteristically worn by quartermasters and seamen in the French Navy.

⁴ Undershirt horizontally striped in white and various colours and which may be sleeveless. It is an iconic uniform garment worn by the Russian navy, airborne troops and marines.

shrill accusations of cultural appropriation make their way through the Internet outrage cycle, the rhetoric ranges from earnest indignation to patronising disrespect.

35 And as we watch artists and celebrities being pilloried and called racist, it's hard not to fear the reach of the cultural-appropriation police, who jealously track who "owns" what and instantly jump on transgressors.

In the 21st century, cultural appropriation – like globalisation – isn't just inevitable; it's potentially positive. We have to stop guarding cultures and subcultures in efforts to preserve them. It's naïve, paternalistic, and counterproductive. Plus, it's just not how culture or creativity work. The exchange of ideas, styles, and traditions is one of the tenets and joys of a modern, multicultural society.

40 So how do we move past the finger pointing, and co-exist in a way that's both creatively open and culturally sensitive? In a word, carefully.

1. Blackface is never okay

This is painfully obvious. Don't dress up as an ethnic stereotype. Someone else's culture or race – or an offensive idea of it – should never be a costume or the butt of a joke.

45 You probably don't need an example, but U.S. fraternity parties are rife with them. Sports teams such as the Washington Redskins, and their fan bases, continue to fight to keep bigoted names and images as mascots – perpetuating negative stereotypes and pouring salt into old wounds. Time to move on.

2. It's important to pay homage to artistry and ideas, and acknowledge their origins

50 Cultural appropriation was at the heart of this year's Costume Institute exhibition, "China: Through the Looking Glass," at New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art. There was a great deal of hand-wringing in advance of the gala celebrating the exhibit's opening – a glitzy event for the fashion industry which many expected to be a minefield for accidental racism (and a goldmine for the cultural-appropriation police).

55 Instead, the red carpet showcased some splendid examples of cultural appropriation done right. Among the evening's best-dressed was Rihanna, who navigated the theme with aplomb in a fur-trimmed robe by Guo Pei, a Beijing-based Chinese couturier whose work was also part of the Met's exhibition. Rihanna's gown was "imperial yellow," a shade reserved for the emperors of ancient Chinese dynasties, and perfectly appropriate for pop stars in the 21st century. Rihanna could have worn a Western interpretation, like this stunning Yves Saint Laurent dress Tom Ford designed for the label in 2004, but she won the night by rightfully shining the spotlight on a design from China.

3. Don't adopt sacred artefacts as accessories

60 When Victoria's Secret sent Karlie Kloss down the runway in a fringed suede bikini, turquoise jewellery, and a feathered head dress – essentially a "sexy Indian" costume – many called out the underwear company for insensitivity to native Americans, and they were right.

Adding insult to injury, a war bonnet like the one Kloss wore has spiritual and ceremonial significance, with only certain members of the tribe having earned the right to wear feathers through honour-worthy achievements and acts of bravery.

65 "This is analogous to casually wearing a Purple Heart or Medal of Honour that was not earned," Simon Moya-Smith, a journalist of the Oglala Lakota Nation, told MTV. For this reason, some music festival organizers have prohibited feather headdresses. As The Guardian points out, it's anyone's right to dress like an idiot at a festival, but someone else's sacred object shouldn't be a casual accessory. (Urban Outfitters, take note.)

4. Remember that culture is fluid

70 "It's not fair to ask any culture to freeze itself in time and live as though they were a museum diorama," says Susan Scaëdi, a lawyer and the author of *Who Owns Culture?: Appropriation and Authenticity in*

American Law. “Cultural appropriation can sometimes be the saviour of a cultural product that has faded away.”

75 Today, for example, the most popular blue jeans in the U.S. – arguably the cultural home, if not the origin of the blue jean – are made of stretchy, synthetic-based fabrics that the inventor Levi Strauss (an immigrant from Bavaria) wouldn’t recognize. Meanwhile, Japanese designers have preserved “heritage” American work wear and Ivy League style, by using original creations as a jumping-off point for their own interpretations, as W. David Marx writes in *Ametora: How Japan Saved American Style*: America may have provided the raw forms for Japan’s fashion explosion, but these items soon became
80 decoupled from their origin. More importantly, the Japanese built new and profound layers of meaning on top of American style – and in the process, protected and strengthened the original for the benefit of all. As we will see, Japanese fashion is no longer a simple copy of American clothing, but a nuanced, culturally rich tradition of its own.

Not to mention the *ne plus ultra* for many American denim-heads.

5. Don’t forget that appropriation is no substitute for diversity

85 At Paris Fashion Week earlier this month, the Valentino designers Maria Grazia Chiuri and Pierpaolo Piccioli sent out a collection they acknowledged was heavily influenced by Africa.

“The real problem was the hair,” wrote Alyssa Vingan at *Fashionista*, pointing out that the white models wore cornrows, a style more common for those with African hair, “thereby appropriating African culture.”

90 In a recent video that went viral, the African American actress Amandla Stenberg’s offered an eloquent discourse on the complex cultural context of cornrows. But the real problem at Valentino was not the hair; it was the conspicuous absence of women of colour on the runway. Lack of diversity is an issue for the entire industry, but the problem was particularly visible at Valentino, where the designers talked the talk of multicultural acceptance: “The message is tolerance,” Piccioli told *Vogue*, “and the
95 beauty that comes out of cross-cultural expression.”

If that’s the point, the faces on the catwalk – regardless of their hairstyle – should reject it.

6. Engage with other cultures on more than an aesthetic level

“What would America be like if we loved black people as much as we love black culture?” asks Stenberg in the aforementioned video, a particularly salient point in an America coming to terms with an epidemic of police violence against young black men.

100 The rapper and TV personality Nicki Minaj echoed the message in *The New York Times Magazine*, in reference to Miley Cyrus, who criticized Minaj’s comments about being overlooked for the Video Music Awards because of her race.

105 “Come on, you can’t want the good without the bad,” said Minaj. “If you want to enjoy our culture and our lifestyle, bond with us, dance with us, have fun with us, twerk with us, rap with us, then you should also want to know what affects us, what is bothering us, what we feel is unfair to us. You shouldn’t not want to know that.”

Cherry-picking cultural elements, whether dance moves or print designs, without engaging with their creators or the cultures that gave rise to them not only creates the potential for misappropriation; it also misses an opportunity for art to perpetuate real, world-changing progress.

7. Treat a cultural exchange like any other creative collaboration – give credit, and consider royalties

110 Co-branded collaborations are common business deals in today’s fashion industry, and that’s just how Oskar Metsavaht, the founder and creative director of the popular Brazilian sportswear brand Osklen, treated his dealings with the Asháninka tribe for Osklen’s Spring 2016 collection.

115 Francisco Piyako, an Asháninka representative, told Quartz the tribe will get royalties from Osklen's spring 2016 collection, as well as a heightened public awareness of their continued struggle to protect land against illegal loggers and environmental degradation.

120 In return, Metsavaht returned from his visit with the Asháninka with motifs and concepts for Osklen's spring 2016 collection: Tattoos were re-proportioned as a print on silk organza; the striking "Amazon red" of a forest plant accented the collection; and women's fabric slings for carrying children reappeared in the crisscross shape of a dress. Metsavaht's photographs of the Amazon forest, the Asháninka, and wild animals also appeared on garments, as well as Osklen's website.

"Sharing values, sharing visions, sharing the economics, I think it's the easiest way to work," said Metsavaht. "This is the magic of style. It's the magic of art. It's the magic of the design."

And it's a magic that I'd be happy to appropriate for my closet.

For Discussion/Reflection/Research:

1. Research on the negative implications of cultural appropriation for the culture being appropriated and its people, and the dominant culture doing the appropriation.
2. Are there positive effects of cultural appropriation, especially in terms of the **continuity** of less dominant or more threatened cultures?
3. What instances of cultural appropriation have you come across in Singapore? Which of the seven tips suggested above would be most relevant in these instances?
4. Reading 19 is heavily informed by American norms and attitudes. What differences are there between the author's observations and suggestions concerning cultural appropriation and Asian societies?

Related essay questions:

1. 'There is a decline in the appreciation of traditional art forms today.' How far is this true in your society? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
2. Should efforts be made to preserve traditional art forms? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
3. How far do you agree that traditional clothing is outdated and impractical in today's world? (RI 2023 Y6 Timed Practice)
4. Consider the view that the globalisation of culture is to be embraced and not feared.' (RI 2022 Y6 CT)
5. Discuss the significance of fashion in today's world. (RI 2018 Y5 Promo)
6. 'Fashion is as much a good thing as a bad thing.' To what extent do you agree? (RI 2015 Y6 CT2)
7. To what extent has popular culture destroyed traditional art forms? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)
8. Consider the view that globalisation destroys culture. (RI 2011 Y5 CT)

Related case studies:

- 1)  [**"Frightening": AI-generated Indigenous art exploiting real artists' work \(Australia, 2024, SmartCompany\)**](#): This article discusses how indigenous artists in Australia face consequences of technological cultural appropriation of their art from tech companies and the challenges they face to stop this onslaught that comes from technology's ability to information and materials accessible to the public.
- 2)  [**Is It Offensive for Sports Teams and Their Fans to Use Native American Names, Imagery and Gestures? \(USA, 2020, NYT\)**](#): This article discusses the controversy of American sports conglomerates of using native American icons and symbols and the possible harm and good that it can bring about to the native American cultures.

SECTION E: THREATS TO CULTURE & ARTS

Reading 16: The destruction of peoples and identities in war

Dr Timothy Clack | University of Oxford Opinion | 4 Oct 2022

EUs 6-9

This article will help you to understand:

- How conflict and politics can pose an irreversible threat to our cultural heritage and our shared humanity.
- The significance of physical artifacts/structures in shaping and strengthening our cultural heritage and why destroying or removing them means that we as a collective species are all worse off.
- How the act of culturecide can serve both as a means to reinforce and erode one's identity.

The Russian invasion has precipitated humanitarian challenges not seen in Europe since the Second World War. It has also seen the deliberate damage of hundreds of places of worship, museums, historic buildings, and memorials. Cultural heritage has also been destroyed and weaponised at scale in recent conflicts in Ethiopia, Mali, Myanmar, Nagorno-Karabakh, Somali, and Syria.

- 5 The systematic destruction of heritage often forms part of strategic acts of 'culturecide'. The obliteration and theft of cultural heritage from Jewish and Roma peoples throughout Nazi-occupied Europe during the Second World War was such an offensive, compounding the drive to dehumanise and delegitimise entire ethnicities. More recently, a campaign of malicious cultural 'unfixing', accompanied by extreme physical and sexual violence, was prosecuted by Daesh (Islamic State) against the Yazidi and other communities in Iraq and Syria. Women, specifically, were brutalised and left bereft of gender-specific cultural norms.

- 10 There are many reasons why conflict actors – from the forces of large states to lone wolf terrorists – train their sights on cultural heritage. Attacks on both tangible (buildings, monuments, and artefacts) and intangible (practices, customs, and knowledges) heritage are not only forms of propaganda by deed, but serve to deny people their very identities – their sense of self.

- 15 This loss is particularly egregious as cultural heritage is central to a person's sense of belonging and attachment to place. It anchors, orientates, and locates a person, a people, in time and space. In short, this destruction disrupts and dislocates, often leaving victims psychologically adrift and emotionally hopeless.

- 20 International Humanitarian Law, including The Hague Convention for the Protection of Cultural Property in the Event of Armed Conflict (1954), to which 133 state parties – including Russia – are currently signatories, require states to ensure heritage is not damaged or misappropriated in war. The exception to such protection is military necessity. Thus, forces are permitted to damage heritage, if an adversary is utilising it to present a threat. It is legitimate, for example, for a military force to use proportionate means to neutralise a sniper in a church spire.

- 25 Despite these legal protections, however, cultural heritage remains a strategic target in war and conflict. There are, in fact, many reasons why these attacks occur. They are often intended to impact self-identity and denude the will to fight (for instance in 'The Blitz', 1940-1), or they can be the means to punish an adversary (for instance, the 'carpet bombing' of Hamburg, 1943). Other motivators include: iconoclasm, the removal of symbols of legitimacy and authority (e.g. the targeting of the Four Old Things during the Cultural Revolution in China, 1966-7); generation of publicity in order to provoke support, outrage, or other response (such as the Taliban's ruination of the Bamiyan Buddhas, 2001); wanting to gain access to spoils (e.g. sacking of the City of Benin, 1897); and opportunistic and organised looting (including thefts from the Iraq National Museum, 2003). During war, there is often also considerable collateral, inadvertent, and neglectful damage caused by armed forces.

Irregular warfare actors and terrorist organisations are often equally destructive of cultural heritage. Islamic terrorist attacks on the West, for example, are primarily focused on 'soft targets' that will

40 attract considerable media attention and are deemed justifiable – if only to the perpetrators and facilitators – on the basis of being stages of decadence, degeneracy, and impurity. The result is a terrorist attack profile that includes music concerts, nightclubs, sporting events, economic hubs, and magazine offices. These often go unrecognised as heritage, officially, and in popular consciousness, but they are, individually and collectively, emblematic of Western liberal democracies.

45 Cultural heritage is also used as a stage to amplify propaganda. During its hold on the World Heritage Site of Palmyra, for instance, Daesh routinely used the ancient architecture publicly to execute prisoners and otherwise terrorise locals. With time being a dimension of power, the site was mobilised to intimidate and as a symbol of their (self-perception of) legitimacy.

Military forces are also increasingly involved in the humanitarian response to natural disasters around the world. As climate change takes its toll – through rising sea-level, heatwaves, and wildfires, as well as in driving displacement and conflict – the need to protect heritage will escalate.

50 Understanding the character of the heritage and conflict relationship better equips states to deliver peacebuilding and post-conflict reconstruction missions, mitigate threats, generate soft power advantage, as well as protect cultural heritage directly.

55 Heritage is a human rights issue, insofar as it relates to freedom of expression, thought, conscience, and religion. Protecting heritage can, thereby, play a prominent role in safeguarding human security and the return to ‘normality’ in the aftermath of conflict. Heritage can help people find home again.

60 Western military forces are increasingly conscious of these issues and are acting to build relevant capabilities. Examples include the US Army’s Civil Affairs and Psychological Operations Command’s 38G/6V Heritage and Preservation Officer Program and the British Army’s Cultural Property Protection Unit. These modern day ‘monuments men and women’ not only protect heritage in conflict theatres, but support operational readiness through related planning, training, and intelligence work.

65 This familiarity between soldiering and heritage is long-standing, and derives, in part, from the shared features of mapping, fieldwork, and the large-scale deployment of people and equipment. T.E. Lawrence (‘Lawrence of Arabia’) was an archaeologist before he was a soldier, and Augustus Pitt-Rivers, whose founding collection was the genesis of the Pitt Rivers Museum, made the opposite transition.

70 Reflecting changes in modern warfare – from conventional wars of attrition and exhaustion to hybrid and subthreshold hostilities – state and non-state actors continue to deploy or destroy cultural heritage for political ends. Indeed, the current trajectory indicates an escalation in heritage targeting and weaponisation as part of strategies to either reinforce or erode people’s identities in and around conflict zones. Destruction in such contexts is often a matter of domination, and protection of resistance.

75 The Russian invasion is a case in point. President Putin has made clear that he believes Ukraine is an inalienable part of Russian history and culture. Despite these assertions, the targeting of Ukrainian cultural sites indicates an internal recognition of the robust and distinct character of Ukrainian identity. As the destruction goes on, however, the cultural affinity that remains between Russia and Ukraine is under threat as both become increasingly defined in opposition to one another. The Orthodox Church in Ukraine, for example, became autocephalous in 2019, meaning it split from the Moscow Patriarchate Church.

80 The display of burnt-out Russian armoured vehicles in cities across Ukraine, including Kyiv and Lviv, adds a modern twist to the conflict and heritage nexus. This material debris of combat is being transported from the battlefield and effectively converted into heritage for public consumption in almost real time. Together with viral memes on social media, most recognisably perhaps of Ukrainian farmers towing Russian tanks with their tractors, this heritage embodies an emotional truth for Ukrainians.

85 This physical and digital debris resonates with, and further informs, cultural narratives of independence and warrior ancestry. Ukrainians at once immortalise and are immortalised by Volodymyr the Great, Bohdan Khmelnytsky, Taras Shevchenko, and the Zaporizhian Cossacks riding horseback with sabres blazing through Gogol's legends of Taras Bulba.

90 Cultural heritage cannot be separated from people – it is people. When we protect one, we protect the other.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. The International Humanitarian Law necessitates the protection of cultural property in times of conflict and war, with the exception to such provisions being 'military necessity' (lines 20-25). How might 'military necessity' pose a contradiction or hurdle to our efforts in preserving cultural heritage?
2. Irregular warfare actors may at times target cultural institutions that are deemed as impure, immoral or decadent (lines 37-38) and justify the destruction of such entities or values. Using examples from either the Russia-Ukraine war or the Israel-Hamas conflict, analyse how accurate/representative this statement is.
3. How might cultural heritage be an effective tool for propaganda (line 43)? Analyse the features of such sites/spaces of heritage that make them particularly effective/ineffective as a platform for propaganda.
4. Explain how the tension between Cultural Diversity vs Homogeneity (Unit Concept for Culture) can be witnessed in modern warfare (line 66). Use relevant examples, where applicable, to support your analysis.

Related essay questions:

1. 'We shape our buildings, but then our buildings shape us.' To what extent is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2020)
2. Assess the view that traditional buildings have no future in your society. (Cambridge 2016)
3. Consider the view that the globalisation of culture is to be embraced and not feared. (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
4. Should countries spend resources on preserving historical monuments when they are struggling to meet the basic needs of their own people? (RI 2016 Y6 CT2)
5. How important are memories? (RI 2013 Y6 Prelim)

Related case studies:

- 1) [!\[\]\(6963cf05b3b10bcf4341767e88ed69fe_img.jpg\) Uyghur Heritage and the Charge of Cultural Genocide in Xinjiang \(China, 2020, New Lines Institute\)](#): This report examines the systematic erasure of Uyghur identity in Xinjiang through the destruction of religious and cultural sites. It argues that dismantling mosques, shrines, and cemeteries constitutes cultural genocide, aiming to sever the community's connection to its ancestral past and transform its social and spiritual identity into a state-approved narrative.
- 2) [!\[\]\(607eab2da1f9b63f7760330db2c63785_img.jpg\) The Taliban destroyed Afghanistan's ancient treasures. Will history repeat itself? \(Afghanistan, 2021, National Geographic\)](#): As the Taliban retake Afghan cities, cultural heritage—including artifacts and archaeological sites—is at risk. Past destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas exemplifies the threat. While the Taliban claim they will protect relics, experts remain sceptical, and museum collections and ancient sites face uncertainty under renewed insurgent control.
- 3) [!\[\]\(37fbc21e77d752184a9cf7b3ff867bcb_img.jpg\) Azerbaijan's attacks on Armenian heritage aim to erase an entire culture \(Armenia, 2024, The Conversation\)](#): This article analyses Azerbaijan's systematic destruction of Armenian cultural heritage in Nagorno-Karabakh. By targeting medieval churches, cemeteries, and monuments, the state aims to erase historical evidence of Armenian presence. Experts describe these actions as a "cultural cleansing" intended to rewrite the region's history and solidify Azerbaijan's territorial and political claims.

SECTION E: THREATS TO CULTURE AND ARTS

Readings 17 & 18 will help you to understand:

- The cultural value of languages
- Some factors that contribute to language loss
- The negative impact of language loss to those directly affected and to the rest of the world
- How technology is helping to preserve & revive threatened languages

Reading 17: Why are languages worth preserving?

EUs 8, 9

Anastasia Riehl | Anthropology Magazine | 8 November 2019 [adapted]

I met the last speaker of Naati on an empty stretch of beach on Malekula, an island in the South Pacific nation of Vanuatu. We exchanged greetings in the local creole, and the conversation quickly turned to the topic of my unlikely appearance on these shores. I told the man, Arip, that I was in the country to study one of its many Indigenous languages. When he learned I was a linguist, he excitedly shared that he speaks Naati.

With a mix of pride and sorrow, he revealed that he is the last fluent speaker of Naati. Although a few of his family members have some knowledge of the language and make an effort to use it together, he fears that with his death, Naati will soon disappear.

Naati's predicament is not unique. Of the roughly 7,000 languages spoken on the planet today, 50 to 90 percent are considered vulnerable to extinction by the end of the century.

The crisis has received increasing public attention over the past decade, punctuated by lines such as "one language dies every two weeks" and illustrated by poignant tales of the death of a last speaker. In this UNESCO International Year of Indigenous Languages, as alarm bells sound and preservation efforts are celebrated, we should pause to ask: Why does it matter?

If we are heading toward a future in which we all speak one of a few large languages, isn't that a good thing? Couldn't it be a way to facilitate communication and level the playing field across nations? Is the desire to "save" these small languages purely sentimental – a romantic notion fostered by scholars in ivory towers of isolated peoples untouched by the exhausting rush toward globalisation?

I argue "no." As a linguist who has worked with endangered language communities in Canada and the Asia-Pacific, I know that language loss is a critical and urgent problem – not only for the speakers who lose their languages, but for everyone. Languages are a vital source of culture and identity for individual communities, and for the global community, languages are an invaluable source of information about human cognition. A linguistically diverse world benefits us all.

Language as cultural glue

Consider what has happened to people whose language has been forcibly taken from them, supplanted by one of the larger, ostensibly more useful languages. This scenario has played out countless times across centuries at the hands of colonial powers or as a tool of national governments to suppress minority groups. It occurs around the world today in classrooms where children are punished or humiliated for using languages and dialects that deviate from an accepted standard.

The response of these communities has not been to celebrate the subsequent generations who speak English, Spanish, Swahili, or whatever the language of power might be. Rather, they decry this cultural genocide and, where possible, fight back against the theft of their linguistic heritage.

In Canada during the 19th and 20th centuries, the national government oppressed Indigenous people in part by removing children from their families and placing them in residential schools. In these

35 spaces, children suffered a range of physical and mental abuses, including punishment for speaking their languages. These injustices severely disrupted the transmission of dozens of Indigenous languages, the majority of which are now endangered.

40 Today, despite a scarcity of resources to address numerous challenges after decades of persecution, Indigenous Canadian communities are making huge investments in reclaiming their languages. From the “language nest” in Tyendinaga Mohawk Territory in Ontario, where children are exposed only to Mohawk throughout the day, to the Nehiyawak language and culture camps in Saskatchewan, where families learn and share their Cree heritage, Indigenous language education across Canada is flourishing.

45 It would seem easier, cheaper, and infinitely more practical just to accept English (a language that is no less highly desirable internationally) and shift the resources elsewhere. The fact that people struggle to reclaim their languages despite the obstacles¹ says something crucial about the value of language and the tragedy of loss.

Language is the cultural glue that binds communities together. Language loss is a loss of community heritage – from histories and ancestral lineages known only through oral storytelling, to knowledge of plants and practices codified through words unwritten and untranslated².

50 Language loss is also a loss of community identity, collective purpose, and self-determination. While harder to quantify, such losses have real, detrimental effects on health and quality of life. Conversely, the ability of community members to speak their indigenous language together enhances well-being.

55 In British Columbia, youth suicide rates are more than six times lower in Indigenous communities where at least 50 percent of the population speaks the native language. In Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities of Australia, young people who speak an Indigenous language have lower rates of binge drinking and illegal drug use compared to non-speakers, as well as a decreased chance of becoming victims of violence.

Why language(s) are important

The disappearance of a language may seem like an unfortunate loss only to the people involved. However, the impact for all of us is real and substantial.

60 This impact goes beyond the losses of particular bits of information, like indigenous names for medicinal plants yet to be classified by scientists outside a community, or concepts and worldviews reflected in the words and structures of one language that do not have parallels in another. Understanding language is vital to understanding human cognition. Each language is a piece of the puzzle that we need in order to determine how language works in the mind. With each missing piece,
65 we are further from seeing the full picture.

Languages may appear to differ wildly from one another, but they are all variations on a theme. Regardless, whether your language is spoken or signed, it draws on a limited set of forms and structures, and it uses them in consistent and predictable ways. The remarkable similarities across

¹ *Language has been forcibly taken from many, supplanted by one of the larger, ostensibly more useful languages. This has happened at the hands of colonial powers or as a tool of national governments to suppress minority groups. It occurs around the world today in classrooms where children are punished or humiliated for using languages and dialects that deviate from an accepted standard.*

² *Lulamogi speakers in Uganda, for example, worry that as people forget the dozens of terms that describe methods of trapping and eating white ants – such as “okukunia”, “okutegerera”, and “okubuutira” – they will forget this important cultural practice. Also at risk are the phrases and associated customs for welcoming the agricultural seasons and washing the bodies of the dead.*

70 languages suggest that there is some cognitive capacity that underlies all human language, directing how language develops and setting the boundaries for what is possible.

Analysing these patterns is far from an esoteric academic exercise; it has real implications for our lives. The more we understand about how language functions, the better equipped we are to improve our therapies for communication disorders and our methods for language teaching.

75 This knowledge contributes to technological innovation as well. Research on sound patterns is used in creating speech synthesis software, while models of grammatical structure aid in developing linguistic components for artificial intelligence.

80 Understanding language in turn gives us a window into cognition. Observations about the strikingly similar ways that children acquire language, across languages and cultures, provide insight into how the brain develops. Psycholinguistic experiments involving language production, comprehension, and recall tasks reveal clues to how the mind organises information.

The challenge of saving languages

However, taking into account all languages, or even a representative sample, is a huge challenge. Thousands of languages are undocumented or only very poorly described, and no one – neither linguists nor speakers – understand how they work.

85 Documenting a language thoroughly is a major undertaking involving years of collaboration between the members of a speech community and linguists (who may or may not be speakers themselves). Given the rapid rate of language loss in the world today, many languages are in danger of disappearing before they have been documented, taking with them irreplaceable information about human cognition.

90 The very limited documentation we have of Naati reveals that the language has a sound called a “bilabial trill.” These trills were once considered impossible speech sounds, but now linguists know that they are common in the languages of Malekula.

As I watched Arip turn back toward the cliffs that day on the beach, taking with him a wealth of linguistic and cultural knowledge, I wondered, Does Naati contain other features that could challenge our understanding of language?

95 What can the many undocumented languages teach us about language structure and cognition, about the richness of our cultures and traditions, about our very humanity? For the sake of the speakers of endangered languages, for the sake of us all, we must preserve the world’s languages as we search for answers and work to ensure linguistic diversity for generations to come.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. How does the author support her assertion that ‘the impact [of language loss] for all of us is real and substantial’ (line 59)?
2. Find some examples of extinct and threatened languages (individually or in small groups):
 - (a) What factors contributed to their respective decline?
 - (b) Which are the most common factors, comparing across the languages you’ve researched on?
 - (c) Are these factors likely to persist? Give reasons for your views.
 - (d) What efforts have been made to salvage the languages you’ve researched on? To what extent have they been successful & what factors have contributed to their relative success or lack thereof?
3. Languages in Singapore:
 - (a) To what extent has there been loss of linguistic diversity in Singapore?
 - (b) What factors have contributed to this?

- (c) To what extent is such loss of diversity acceptable?
- (d) What efforts have been made to revive and preserve linguistic diversity? To what extent have they been successful & what factors have contributed to their relative success or lack thereof?

Related essay questions:

1. Consider the view that spoken language is more important than the written form. (Cambridge 2013)
2. Is there any value in preserving minority languages in the world today? (Cambridge 2012)

Further reading:

- “Languages: Why we must save dying tongues” – Rachel Nuwer, BBC, 6 Jun 2014 @ <https://www.bbc.com/future/article/20140606-why-we-must-save-dying-languages>
- “Keeping the mother tongues alive: Singapore's bilingual challenge” – Tee Zhua, The Straits Times, 3 Nov 2019 @ <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/keeping-the-mother-tongues-alive-singapores-bilingual-challenge>
- “From Igbo to Angika: how to save the world’s 3,000 endangered languages” – Kaamil Ahmed, The Guardian, 7 Jan 2025 @ <https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2025/jan/07/cultural-identity-saving-worlds-endangered-languages-activists-online-tools-rohingya-igbo-angika>
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Related case studies:

- 1)  [What Japan and South Korea are doing to prevent their dying languages from vanishing forever](#) (Japan and South Korea, 2024, Channel News Asia): Centuries-old languages in Japan and South Korea are on the verge of being wiped out, due to an unfortunate mix of history, politics and modernisation. The Ainu people once inhabited much of Hokkaido, but their language was outlawed, and they were persecuted after Japan's Meiji government annexed the territory in 1869. Over in Jeju Island, it has its own language Jeju-eo, but it has receded in importance and is spoken mostly by the elderly.
- 2)  <https://www.channelnewsasia.com/singapore/singlish-threat-society-research-singapore-identity-code-switch-2866596>. (Singapore, 2025, Channel News Asia): Presents a case for the celebration of Singlish rather than to erase it

Reading 18: How technology is used to preserve endangered languages

EU8 8, 9

Demetrius Williams | Translate Media | 30 October 2018 [adapted]

Languages have a history of dying out, but the number of languages disappearing is growing at an alarming rate – around 3,500 languages are expected to be extinct by the end of this century.

Languages can die for a number of reasons. Some have become extinct relatively quickly due to natural disasters, civil conflict and world wars. The indigenous people of El Salvador, for example, abandoned their cultural practices and language to avoid being killed during the 1932 Salvadoran peasant massacre – which was aimed at the poorer citizens of El Salvador, many of which were indigenous people.

In the 21st-century, language loss occurs mainly due to a lack of people speaking them. In fact, UNESCO describes endangered languages as those whose speakers have disappeared or shifted to another language – usually the main language of a dominant group. This usually takes the form of

parents passing on their native tongue to their children who later on in life use the dominant language of the country they're in to gain socioeconomic advantages or avoid discrimination.

15 Although advances in modern technology are seen as a contributing factor of language loss, technology has been embraced by many developers, philanthropists and linguists in order to help preserve endangered languages across the globe.

All roads lead to the internet

Non-profit organisations who research and document endangered languages have naturally navigated to the internet to release their research for easy access to the public. Organisations such as The Living Tongues Institute for Endangered Languages publish scientific papers, conduct linguistic fieldwork and even create online talking dictionaries to preserve indigenous languages.

20 The institute takes a unique approach to language acquisition by organising digital workshops where local endogenous language activists are trained how to record and edit phrases in their language with the elders of local people.

Not only do these language activists gain additional technical skills, but many activists also become highly skilled researchers within their region while becoming local ambassadors for the institute. Since 25 2005, The Living Tongues Institute has helped to create more than one hundred talking dictionaries containing tens of thousands of words and images.

With Google as one of its founding partners, The Endangered Languages Project, another web-based platform, acts as a collaborative hub of language enthusiasts, linguists and industry partners all helping to strengthen endangered languages. Users of the website act as contributors by uploading language 30 samples in text, audio, link or video format using a unique tagging system that allows for easy searchability.

Probably one of the most notable languages that have had a revival in the 21st century is Yiddish. Once spoken for over 10 million Jews worldwide, the number of Yiddish speakers decreased dramatically due to the Holocaust and survivors who were forced to assimilate and use the native tongue to avoid 35 persecution. The use of Yiddish had all but disappeared bar a small number of Hasidic communities.

With the rapid popularity of online forums in the 2000s, the internet became a common place for Yiddish speakers to converse in their tongue and over time, the virtual world became the prime destination for Yiddish speakers.

40 Sites such as The Idish Velt (The Jewish World), a message board which boasts 200,000 visits per month, and Kave Shtiebel (The Coffee House), which features Yiddish pop up ads, are just a few examples of how Jewish communities are keeping Yiddish alive by creating safe spaces online where users can easily communicate with each other in their own language.

With online platforms becoming a destination for language preservation, language learning start-ups, including Duolingo, have diversified their product offering to contribute to the preservation process. 45 With 25 million monthly active users worldwide, the US-based start-up's main focus is with Native American languages, such as Navajo, where an estimated 1,500 people are learning the language in the more traditional way of passing it down from one generation to another.

Although Duolingo has the potential to reach hundreds of thousands of young people in the US to encourage Native American language learning, at this early stage it would be unwise to conflate this 50 with becoming a fluent, everyday speaker of a language.

The gamified app requires users to commit to using the app daily and it could take years to master fluent proficiency. But it does raise awareness of language diversity within the United States where a single language has dominated public and economic life.

Unconventional methods in Africa

55 Saving a language isn't just a matter of recording words or phrases and digitising them to be held in an online vault. Language is inherently about people, culture and identity. In order to keep a language alive, it needs to be spoken by many, immersed in everyday culture and actively passed on to future generations.

60 Countries in Africa are considered vulnerable to language loss despite the African continent being home to some 2,144 languages. That's not surprising when you consider the continent's history of nearly 200 years of colonisation and many indigenous languages historically being passed on orally, through images and in written form.

As a result, African languages have lost their seat at the diplomatic table and you're more likely to be taught English, Portuguese, French and Mandarin in the classroom to ensure a better socioeconomic future.

65 To tackle this, young Africans are experimenting with new ways to ensure local languages are passed down to younger generations. Some in the diaspora have taken to YouTube to create video tutorials in order to educate parents on how to teach their children their native tongue.

70 Gbemisola Isimi, a UK-based Nigerian created CultureTree TV, a YouTube channel that uses the effectiveness of music and video to teach children Yuroba. Launched in 2016, the YouTube channel features videos including common English nursery rhymes, as well as well-known children's stories and educational videos about animal names, professions and body parts all translated into Isimi's native Yuroba language.

75 It's become a trend that's inspired Nigerian writers to create innovative language learning children's books and opened the doors of opportunity for local women to write romance novels in order to ensure their stories are being told in their local communities – in their language.

Similarly to rural parts of India and China, low levels of literacy on the African continent still remain a barrier to technology that some in Western markets consider everyday essentials. However, unsurprisingly, smartphone adoption is on the rise. In Mali, the literacy rate was at 38.7% in 2015 according to the United Nations.

80 In order to tap into a market where 30% of the population who own a smartphone can't read its content, Mali-born, Mamadou Sidibe, created a voice-based messaging platform, Lenali, to capitalise on the way people already communicate.

85 In a country where many people can run a small business without being able to read, the messaging app has proven useful for local merchants who wish to promote their goods and services online while still being part of a 21-century online community.

Although technology is levelling the playing field for language preservation, the internet still plays a key role in snuffing out minority languages.

The internet is ruled by only a handful of dominant languages (such as English, Mandarin and French) and there's even evidence to suggest that only 5% of languages have a chance of surviving in the digital

90 world¹. But only time will tell if language activists can truly win the long game of language preservation.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. Identify the tech-related strategies used to help preserve languages, as detailed in the passage's second section (lines 16-53) and third section (lines 54-90).
2. According to the author, what factors have contributed to countries in Africa being 'vulnerable to language loss' (line 58)? To what extent might similar factors be contributing to loss of linguistic diversity in Singapore?

Related essay questions:

1. Assess the view that accurate translation between languages is always necessary. (Cambridge 2023)
2. Is there any value in preserving minority languages in the world today? (RI 2017 Y6 CT2)

Further reading:

- [In Singapore, Chinese Dialects Revive After Decades of Restrictions](#) (Ian Johnson, NYT, 26 Aug 2017)

Related case studies:

- 1) [How virtual reality could help revive endangered language and culture \(Nepal, 2025, The Conversation\)](#): Kusunda is a language spoken by a few among the Kusunda people in western and central Nepal. As of 2023, it only has a single fluent speaker, Kamala Sen-Khatri. Efforts to keep the language alive include leveraging virtual reality (VR) through multimodal storytelling and immersive visualisation.
- 2) [This new tech could save old languages from dying out \(USA, 2025, CNN\)](#): Skobot is a language teaching robot designed to be an interactive way for children to learn Anishinaabemowin. This project is part of a growing push to preserve and revitalise endangered languages with the help of robotics and artificial intelligence, often led by young people looking to connect more deeply with their Indigenous roots.
- 3) [Game designed to save dying Aboriginal language wins global awards \(Australia, 2025, ABC\)](#): A small Aboriginal community in Western Australia has won five global Anthem Awards for "Niyiparli Widi," a smartphone game designed to save their dying language. With only eight fluent speakers remaining, the innovative app teaches youth ancestral words and cultural knowledge through gameplay, successfully revitalising heritage by embracing modern technology.
- 4) [India launches AI app to save its many tribal languages before they vanish \(India, 2025, The Straits Times\)](#): An AI-powered translation platform seeks to preserve endangered tribal languages like Santali and Gondi. By bridging the digital divide, the app enables marginalised communities to access essential healthcare, education, and government services in their mother tongues, ensuring their unique cultural heritage and oral traditions are documented for posterity.
([Watch the related video here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Jnby_wjY8U](#))

¹ "Digital language death" – András Kornal, *PLoS One*, 22 Oct 2013 @ <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC3805564/>.

SECTION E: THREATS TO CULTURE AND ARTS

Reading 19: How data threatens shared mass culture

EUs 6-9

Kyle Chayka | Vox | 17 Dec 2019 [adapted]

This article will help you to understand:

- Why shared mass culture, including film, TV and music, can be useful in providing universal reference points for facilitate the formation of collective communal experiences for societies
- How the rise of digital services and streaming, which appear to increase the diversity of choices and threaten mass culture, has instead led to greater homogenisation due to the heavy-handed application of recommendation algorithms
- Why diversity in mass culture and the arts is important

The past year has felt like a peak in mega-budget world-spanning media spectacles that command our attention, one outrageous finale after another. On April 26, 2019, the film *Avengers: Endgame* was released in the United States. By July, the movie — the closing of a phase in the vast Marvel Cinematic Universe — was the highest-grossing movie in the history of Hollywood; it has so far achieved a global box office of around \$2.8 billion.

This communal moment of mass culture has occasioned celebration as well as a bout of anxiety. We're in the midst of the Streaming Wars, with so many different media products and platforms competing for our attention — Netflix, Hulu, Amazon, Disney+, AppleTV+, and the still-to-come Peacock and HBO Max, to name but a few. Journalists and critics are worried that the huge popularity and sense of universality that *Avengers* and *Game of Thrones* achieved are now disappearing for good. The word often used to describe these omnipresent mass-entertainment products is "monoculture."

Within the monoculture obsession, there are two concerns. The first is that in the digital streaming era we have lost a perceived ability to connect over media products as reference points that everyone knows, the way that we used to discuss the weather or politics, at least in a bygone time before our realities were split by climate change and Fox News.

The second concern is that, because of the pressures of social media and the self-reinforcing biases of recommendation algorithms that drive streaming, culture is becoming more similar than different. We are worried that our digital niches cause a degree of homogenisation, which the word monoculture is also used to describe.

These two concerns appear in some ways irreconcilable, and yet they coexist. Is there less monoculture today, or is culture more mass than ever? Are we siloed within our own preferences or are we unable to escape the homogenised net-average, consuming all the same things?

The meaning of monoculture

Today, the word monoculture is used to describe a **monolithic** culture: the range of artifacts, characters, voices, and stories that a specific demographic finds recognisable and relatable. But the word also evokes a homogenised space, a Monocultural Cinematic Universe in which everything is bright, vapid, and family-friendly, and any whimpering of dissent is smoothed over into sameness: **monotonous** culture.

The universality that monoculture entails is valuable, because what everyone already knows is what they are likely to keep consuming — hence the overwhelming popularity of reboots and sequels. It's also why Netflix paid \$100 million in 2018 to keep *Friends* on its platform for another year.

Big-budget productions try to worm material into the monocultural framework by manufacturing new universal reference points, as *The Mandalorian* has with its insta-meme Baby Yoda. Piggybacking on

old monoculture is less risky than starting from scratch. Businesses turn their own intellectual property into self-reproducing mini-monocultures because monopolies are easiest to monetise. The various signature franchises form walled gardens: nothing else is allowed to grow; there is no cross-pollination.

Watching together; watching separately

More than a sheer volume of viewers, what monoculture entails is a feeling. Broadcast TV gave us a monocultural feeling because we knew tens of millions of other people were watching the same channel as us at the same time, though we couldn't see them. While *tuned in* we felt connected to the "grid of 200 million," the social community of American TV watchers that George W.S. Trow observed in his 1980 essay on television, *Within the Context of No Context*. (Social media is our new grid, and its fervent fandoms in part a response to the desire for more communal experience.)

If monoculture depends on this feeling of watching together, then streaming makes it more difficult to establish, because we watch different things at different paces for different reasons. Though widespread popularity is clearly still possible, there's a distinction between media's content — its subject matter — and its context — the social environment, or lack thereof, in which we consume it.

Martin Scorsese critiqued the Marvel movies' lack of communal social context as well as their artistic content: "To be in a packed house in one of the old theatres watching *Rear Window*¹ was an extraordinary experience: It was an event created by the chemistry between the audience and the picture itself, and it was electrifying."

Scorsese complains about the homogenisation of "market-researched, audience-tested, vetted, modified, revetted and remodified" content. Yet in terms of representation and access, this change feels like a step forward. The range of widely available mass media no longer represents the vision of only one demographic group. The retro-monoculture of *Goodfellas*, or *Friends*, or *Seinfeld*, is just one choice among many. But what do our other choices look like?

Monoculture of the algorithm

Rather than the monoculture dictated by singular auteurs or industry gatekeepers, we are moving toward a monoculture of the algorithm. Recommendation algorithms — on Netflix, TikTok, YouTube, or Spotify — are responsible for much of how we move through the range of on-demand streaming media, since there's too much content for any one user to parse on their own. We can make decisions, but they are largely confined to the range of options presented to us.

In September 2019, the country music star Martina McBride attempted to create a country playlist on Spotify. The platform can automatically recommend songs to add to a playlist; in this case, it suggested 14 pages of songs by male country artists before it came up with a single woman. McBride was shocked, posting on Instagram: "Is it lazy? Is it discriminatory? Is it tone deaf? Is it out of touch?"

Contrary to our expectations of personalisation, Spotify's playlist-recommendation function only takes into account the title of the playlist, not the habits of the individual user. According to the algorithm, country = men. Spotify had created its own homogenous definition of the genre.

We all get driven toward the same things. This both immediately decreases diversity and operates at the level of perception: If we think we are getting relatively unbiased, data-backed recommendations, then we're more likely to absorb the way an algorithm defines a genre and accept it as all that exists.

Data drives sameness

Jada Watson, a professor at the University of Ottawa who studies country radio airplay, described how the country radio charts, like Billboard's Hot Country Songs list, which includes streaming, "have become incredibly homogenous, not just in gender but with songs that stay number one the entire

¹ A 1954 classic thriller by famous director Alfred Hitchcock

year.” She sees the homogenisation of music as being caused by data — a consequence of the fact that streaming, radio, and record companies can access more information about their listeners than ever, faster than ever.

On the broadcaster side, the data motivate snap business judgments: “If a particular style is really driving ratings of your service up, whether radio or streaming, you’ll want to continue to play that kind of artist, based on fear of loss of ratings.” On the label side, the data create an excuse for homogenisation. “If artist X is doing really well with a particular style, or a particular production value, then a label might do the same thing with artist Y,” explained Watson.

We thought the long tail of the internet² would bring diversity; instead we got sameness and the perpetuation of the oldest biases, like gender discrimination. The best indicator of what gets recommended is what’s already popular, according to the investor Matthew Ball, a former head of strategy at Amazon Studios. “Netflix isn’t really trying to pick individual items from obscurity and get you to watch it,” Ball said. “The feedback mechanisms are reiterating a certain homogeneity of consumption.”

An updated definition of monoculture

Instead of discrete, brand-name cultural artifacts, monoculture is now culture that appears increasingly similar to itself wherever you find it. It exists in the global morass of Marvel movies designed to sell equally well in China and the United States; the style of K-Pop, in music and performance, spreading outside of Korea; or the profusion of recognisably minimalist indie cafes from Australia to everywhere else. These are all forms of monoculture that don’t rely on an enforced, top-down sameness, but create sameness from the bottom up. Maybe the post-internet monoculture is now made up of what is *aesthetically recognisable* even if it is not *familiar* — we quickly feel we understand it even if we don’t know the name of the specific actor, musician, show, or director.

A monocultural product reinforces our established range of taste-signifiers rather than challenging them or adding something new. Is it better to choose between a few things that everyone knows, or between 100 things that share a fundamental similarity, algorithmically sorted into a you-may-also-like category? The latter may not be that much more authentic, original, or diverse than the former. In fact, it often feels oppressive, as if there isn’t much of a choice at all. By the metric of similarity, we have more monoculture than ever.

Relying on algorithms to dictate our culture means evaluating things on the basis of popularity, engagement, scale, and speed. Yet we already know that what is popular is not necessarily good, and what is good is not necessarily popular. On top of that, the data provided by Netflix and Spotify are biased, shaped by their proprietary algorithms. Their parameters are still set by a small group: not Hollywood producers, but white, male engineers and data scientists.

More diversity yet less of it

The critics giving *Avengers* and *Game of Thrones* the epitaph of Last Universal Content are wrong: Today’s form of monoculture is both larger in scale and less human, more mechanically automated, than ever before. Culture is now Big Data. Just what we have lost in the transition from human to machine tastemakers is still bearing out.

There seems to be more *opportunity* for diversity (anything can theoretically go viral) and yet the cultural artifacts that do become mainstream appear relentlessly optimised for the digital platforms of the attention economy. There isn’t enough room for products or projects (or places) that are not memes, that aren’t pre-optimised for sharing or scaling. The non-homogenised alternatives to the

² The theory that the structure of the internet drives demand away from products with mass appeal towards more obscure or niche offerings

115 mainstream become harder to find. As we grow more accustomed to the algorithmic monoculture, allowing it to occupy our senses, we might lose our understanding of, or our taste for, anything else.

Recapturing the value from the unexpected

120 Art's deepest impact comes when it is least expected. In contrast, algorithmic recommendations lead us down a path of pleasant monotony: a looming monoculture of the similar. To resist it, we should embrace obscurity, difficulty, diversity, and strangeness as just as important as recognisability or universality.

125 These are the qualities that need most to be preserved against the frictionless consumption pushed by our automated feeds. Otherwise, any new, surprising content that enters the machine of digital monoculture will quickly have its innovative quirks stripped and copied, scaled up and repeated until they become clichés. They will be incorporated into a constantly updated global homogeneity that possesses the sheen of familiarity but no substance beyond style. The algorithm is a replacement for our internal monologues and our judgements about what we want to consume.

130 The magic is still in what the algorithm can't surface, what data doesn't touch — the introspective space in which you can develop your own opinions in private before making them public commodities and measuring them against the mainstream. Because once something enters the cycle of digital monoculture, its essence will, inevitably, be lost. So enjoy it while you can.

What we stand to lose

135 The desire for a shared monoculture is understandable, though its disappearance is more perception than reality. Art is communal. We want to connect with other people over experiences that we share in common. But just as important is being alone, having a unique encounter — not seamlessly recommended or autoplayed — with something that another person created, and then gauging your deepest emotional response. The internet makes this more difficult, even as it makes sharing (or superficially liking) things easier and faster.

140 Rembrandt died in 1669, impoverished, in obscurity. And yet it is his late work, the deeply luminous portraits with scumbled³ brushstrokes, completely unpopular with his contemporaries, that strikes us most today. It took centuries for the paintings to become mainstream. The process was neither fast nor convenient, though it may now seem like a foregone conclusion.

Digital media, by contrast, prioritises immediate engagement over the slow blooming of art. I get the sense that today's algorithms would prioritise Deep Dream⁴ patterns — a memetic style without content — over late Rembrandt. The danger of prioritising the monoculture is that we might not get as many Rembrandts in the future.

For Discussion/Reflection:

1. Chayka outlines the two concerns surrounding the 'monoculture obsession' (lines 12-19). In your own words, explain why these concerns seem 'irreconcilable' (line 20).
2. Chayka defines 'monolithic culture' as 'the range of artifacts, characters, voices, and stories that a specific demographic finds recognisable and relatable' (lines 23-24). Reflect on the ways 'monolithic culture' is useful to societies.
3. Chayka posits that the communal experience of 'Broadcast TV' (line 37) has changed, and that social media satisfies our 'desire for more communal experience' (line 42). How is the communal experience obtained through social media different from that of more traditional mass media? What are the implications of such a difference, if any?

³ Scumbling refers to a painting technique

⁴ Deep Dream is a computer vision programme that uses deep learning techniques and neural networks to process images and turn them into dream-like, psychedelic pictures

4. Chayka cites Spotify's playlist-recommendation function as a specific example of how algorithms reduce diversity (lines 61-67). Based on your own experience, what other examples are there where algorithms may end up limiting our choices when it comes to cultural consumption?
5. Taking into consideration the sections 'Monoculture of the algorithm' and 'Data Drives Sameness' (lines 56-87), summarise the ways in which digital media have led to greater homogenisation of mass culture.
6. Explain what the author means when he says that the new monoculture 'create[s] sameness from the bottom up' (line 93).
7. Chayka asserts that the way digital media works today would lead to any original content or products 'copied, scaled up and repeated until they become cliches' (lines 123-124), and that we might not get 'as many Rembrandts in the future' (line 144). Do you agree or are you less pessimistic? Why?

Related essay questions:

1. 'Films are concerned with escaping from the problems of everyday life, rather than addressing them.' Discuss (Cambridge 2021)
2. Consider the view that the globalisation of culture is to be embraced and not feared. (RI 2022 Y6 Common Test)
3. How far do you agree that popular music serves no real purpose? (RI 2019 Y6 CT1)
4. To what extent has popular culture destroyed traditional art forms? (RI 2014 Y5 Promo)
5. Assess the impact of foreign films or foreign TV programmes on the culture of your society. (RI 2013 Y6 CT1)
6. Consider the view that popular culture thrives on the trivial. (RI 2011 Y5 Promo)

SECTION E: THREATS TO CULTURE & ARTS

Reading 20: The digital future is now – How the pandemic has re-energised local theatre

EUs 4, 5, 9

Darren Woo | RICE Media | 18 June 2021

This reading will help you:

- Understand how local arts scene and can adapt to the demands of modern society through the use of technology
- Consider the benefits that the online presence of the arts can have for both practitioners and audiences

If there is one thing that has really irked me during this pandemic, it's the assumption that our theatre industry has met its demise. Things like live performances and exhibitions may not be feasible in these trying times, but a closer and more nuanced investigation into the heart of our theatre scene reveals that it is anything but going extinct.

- 5 Despite the struggles and challenges posed by the pandemic, local theatre has been taking these obstacles in good stride. Companies have continued experimenting with ways to adapt their works, and upgrade their skills to push out pieces that will not only tide through this difficult period, but will also remain relevant post-pandemic.

- 10 Case in point: 3 Cups of Kopi, a group that specialises in Playback Theatre—an applied form of theatre where participants are invited to share their personal stories and have trained actors play back the different emotions, thoughts, and feelings associated with the story—has found innovative ways to incorporate their art form into the online medium of Zoom.

- 15 In essence, an online version of Playback Theatre generally operates in the following manner: after inviting a participant to tell their story, the facilitator summarises it and signals for the actors to begin performing. Using common household items such as pots and pans, small whiteboard markers, and even zoom filters, the emotions and thoughts that accompany the participant's story are represented by the actors and "played back" to the audience. The entire experience is quite surreal indeed, bringing to life an almost invisible, untold layer of the story that imbues it with new meaning and empathetic connection.

- 20 While this is certainly somewhat different from how Playback Theatre would function in person, it by no means points towards the inferiority of online theatre. To start, it helps to recognise that online theatre is more than just a substitute for live performances. It is a completely different medium that has its own unique ability to bring people together and touch the lives of many.

- 25 Certainly, having a physical process, such as purchasing a ticket from a booth, entering into a space guided by an usher, perusing an itinerary, and even exiting the space after the performance is over may be valuable to the overall experience of theatre. However, while this is understandably important in establishing a sense of ritual and ambience for the performance, who's to say that these acts of ritual and process cannot take place online?

- 30 Offstage 3.0, a production by Emergency Stairs, incorporated this very line of inquiry into its performance. Using multimedia tools such as laptops, phones, and live-streamed videography, the performance, which was performed online in December 2020, sought to challenge the need for a physical presence in arranging a theatrical production. This was just one of the many innovative ways

that theatre companies have adopted a fairly optimistic perspective when dealing with the pandemic. They've seen it as a catalyst for innovative change rather than a circumstantial hindrance.

35 Online and digital theatre has become increasingly common as a result of the pandemic. As technology continues to upgrade itself over time and change the way we live and interact with one another, so does theatre reflect this dynamism in its dramaturgy and style. With the spotlight being drawn towards avant-garde theatre companies such as New York-based experimental theatre company The Wooster Group, which specialises in multimedia performance and digitalisation, the rise in technology
40 as a whole as pivoted our focus towards what is particularly relevant to us – which oftentimes takes the form of technology as a whole.

In essence, the times have been, and are always changing. What the pandemic has done effectively to catalyse this move forward for all of us. While this transit may have been unexpectedly sudden, it is nothing completely unforeseen. Theatre groups in the past have been dabbling with the incorporation
45 of new forms of technology into their performances, and will continue doing so even after the pandemic blows over.

As our local theatre scene embarks on this journey of reformation and evolution, the last thing they need right now is for audiences to shun their digital works, and mistakenly trivialising them as being inferior copies of the real. Here are three reasons why we should celebrate this rise of online theatre.

50 **1. Accessibility**

Holding a performance in an online format has the significant benefit of allowing more and more people to access these performances from the comfort of their own home. This is especially important when we consider things such as individuals with physical disabilities, together with well, just the thought of having to physically travel down to watch something.

55 Clicking on a Zoom link and participating in an online performance from one's own home makes online theatre and performance far more accessible than it otherwise would have been pre-covid. The migration of theatre towards the online form also allows for participants to attend workshops and performances from all over the world, as long as their time zones match, of course. Participants not only enjoy a greater diversity of online shows to choose from, they also become part of a global
60 community of audience members when participating in online performances. In effect, a global tapestry of theatre is sewn together as a result of this unprecedented level of accessibility.

By allowing for a greater diversity of audienceship as well as performance groups, theatre productions experience an unprecedented range of views, expectations, and awareness as a whole. To learn more about the community's perspective of diversity in moving towards the online format, I spoke to
65 Michael Cheng, the artistic director of Tapestry Playback Theatre and Adjunct Lecturer at Singapore Polytechnic. He explains that this diversity is necessary in communicating an even greater sense of empathy and connection with groups of people we may not otherwise have the opportunity to engage with on an ordinary basis:

"I would have Palestinian friends, Arab friends, so on and so forth," he says.

70 "And you think about how politics has impacted lives, and how many different perspectives there are. Yet I can choose to say that every one of those views are valid because they are the realities for each of these individuals."

"It just makes you appreciate how complicated situations, moments, and politics can be. But at the same time it impacts individuals, and that's where I think a lot of us need to be more aware that things
75 are rarely so black and white. There are always more sides to the story."

For most of us, theatre is about bringing people together. It's about sharing stories, experiences, and perspectives with one another. It's about community building. If we accept that all of these are important to theatre, then surely it is through this transition to the online form that we better achieve this greater diversity where perspectives and opinions all across the world are shared and embraced.

2. Affordability

This is the part that some of us may be the most concerned with. Yes, shows and performances have mostly become more affordable and cheaper with the migration towards online platforms. Performance groups and troupes are able to save on things such as securing physical venues for rehearsals and the actual performances, as well as the additional logistical support that comes with hosting a live performance.

Gone are the days where expensive lighting and sound equipment had to be rented or even bought to facilitate performances. This inevitably means that ticket prices are considerably cheaper than before, which only serves to make attending an online performance an affordable and meaningful way to spend your weekend nights.

More importantly, being able to save on venues and physical logistics also means that performance groups are able to invest more time and resources in continually being innovative and finding new and creative ways to execute their performances. Expenditure on things like skills upgrading workshops for performers to accommodate the new online format for instance, are now more accessible to even smaller theatre companies.

By investing in IT skills upgrading and proficiency, theatre companies are not only able to find more creative ways to express their art over the online form, but are also able to future-proof their performances for the long run. Online theatre will not be going away even after the pandemic tides over, and these skills will ensure that their art remains relevant and up to date for the long haul.

3. Interactivity and intimacy

While arguably the most controversial aspect of online theatre, with many criticising the form for its lack of personal connection and feeling, perhaps a more nuanced discussion on this needs to be had to explore this further.

In the same way that performance groups rely upon a certain ritual (be it curtain calls, physical gestures, or even setting a particular ambience) in order to create a sense of connection with their audience members, online theatre brings with it its own set of processes and facilitation techniques to re-create this sense of ritual, and bring the heart of the performance to its audiences.

3 Cups of Kopi for instance, in holding their online playback performances, still preserve the ritualistic aspects of ice-breaking activities, physical warm-ups and use of key words such as "let's watch" that are all integral to their art form. These are all necessary steps in order for a firm emotional connection to be established with their audiences to facilitate the sharing of personal stories and experiences, which forms the backbone of their performances.

Especially in interactive performances that require participants to speak up and interact with the room, doing so in a physical space with people around you may be daunting for some. This pressure and fear is often assuaged when one is behind a computer screen. Having attended a live Playback performance in the past, I can attest to the fact that speaking up in front of a crowd about my own personal story can be incredibly intimidating. However, when attending an online version of the performance recently, I found myself more willing to share.

120 The fact that the facilitator also requested other participants who were not sharing their story to turn
off their view cameras also helped create a more intimate and personal experience between myself
and the performers alone.

Some online Playback Theatre groups have even opted to incorporate technology as means of
ensuring greater interactivity with handicapped or disabled groups. Take Karnataka-based Playback
125 group YoursTrulyTheatre for instance, who are currently embarking on a performance project catered
to the visually-handicapped community. With the transition to the online platform, they are now able
to use applications such as Clubhouse, which allows for audio-only discussions to take place, creating
conducive spaces for members of the community to participate and engage in the performance.

Ultimately, ensuring intimacy and engagement still boils down to ensuring that the basics are done
right, and that facilitation methods are kept relevant and meaningful to all participants and audiences.

130 **The way forward**

Online and digital theatre as a whole is nothing new. Performance groups all across the world have
long been incorporating the virtual space as a core part of their shows; hybrid or otherwise. The only
thing that has really changed is the surge of this very genre and the necessary transition towards it.

While the pandemic has indeed been difficult on our local arts scene, it is perhaps through the efforts
135 of groups like 3 Cups of Kopi and T:> Works, who will be hosting their online exhibition and
performance Festival of Women N.O.W 2021, which begins on the 13th of July, that we observe how
the pandemic has actually been a period of critical evolution and change for our local arts scene. You
can find out more about T:> Works' upcoming works and projects here. While the transition towards
the online form undeniably brings with it its own unique set of challenges, there is an optimism that
140 these groups carry with them that truly exemplifies the undying spirit of our local theatre scene.

This is a period of tumultuous change and uncertainty. The specific requirements that go into
instrumentalising the online platform as a medium for performance may indeed be challenging, but
this is precisely also what demands our respect for the form—that this is far from being a temporary
and inferior substitute to live theatre. Rather, it is a unique genre on its own that boasts distinct
145 benefits, charms, and poise.

By embracing this major transition towards the digital, theatre groups all across Singapore ensure not
only their survival during this trying period, but also guarantee their relevance as technology continues
to evolve and alter our expectations and attitudes towards life in general.

Performances that incorporate advanced technology such as augmented reality and virtual reality
150 have been on the rise over the past decade all across the world, and artists have been continuously
finding new and innovative ways to express their art with changing mediums that grant increasingly
diverse opportunities. We need to carry this optimism forward within our local communities in
receiving the works of performance groups who take the bold leap forward.

Their undying spirit for evolution and change is the torch that lights the way forward, piercing through
155 the miasma of the pandemic and bringing the future to us. We ought to be there with them as they
do so.

For Discussion/Reflection:

This article discusses how technology can enable dramatic artistic expression through the following reasons – Accessibility, Affordability and Intimacy and Interaction. In researching into the above examples AND other examples, examine the critical roles of these criteria with reference to other art forms in Singapore:

- a) Street Art – <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DF6SXfsH-EQ&t=199s>
- b) Urban Sketching Community – https://youtu.be/wVTp08_SsTo?si=kG3c4U6nL23_qMaS
- c) Young people's involvement in traditional arts in Singapore – <https://youtu.be/svnqTvCgu7Q?si=jWHhCSB8051TCSeo>

Related essay questions:

- 1. 'Dramas on television or film are never as effective as a live performance.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2022)
- 2. Would it matter if all the performing arts venues in your society, such as concert halls and theatres, were closed down? (Cambridge 2010)
- 3. To what extent should traditional art forms be preserved in a world driven by innovation? (RI 2022 Y6 Prelims)
- 4. To what extent are the arts valued in your society? (RI 2022 Y6 Timed Practice)
- 5. To what extent has technology had a negative impact on the arts, such as music or photography? (RI 2018 Y6 CT1)
- 6. To what extent has technology revolutionised the arts? (RI 2012 Y6 Prelims)
- 7. Do the arts have a future in Singapore? (RI 2010 Y6 CT1)